

The Lethean Mode of Production





The Lethean Mode of Production

Forgetting, Liturgy, and the Post-Mnemonic Person in Dan Erickson and Ben Stiller's Severance

OCTOBER 2026

Cura enim quia prima eum finxit,
quamdiu vixerit Cura eum possideat.

HYGINUS, FABULAE 220

Contents

Abstract 9

Introduction: Forgetting as a Factor of Production 11

1 The Novum and Its Problem 11
2 Corpus, Authorship, and Method 12
3 The Argument: Three Theorems of Lethean Production 13
4 A Lexicon of Terms 15
5 Plan of the Thesis 16

PART ONE ONTOLOGIES OF THE PARTITIONED PERSON 17

1 The Day-Man and the Night-Man 19

1.1 Locke's Thought Experiment Made Flesh 19
1.2 The Objections Return: Butler, Reid, Leibniz 20
1.3 Hume's Theatre and Kant's Elastic Balls 21
1.4 Parfit's Glass Tunnel and Williams's Torturer 22
1.5 Bisected Brains and the Count of Minds 23
1.6 Narrative, Episodic, and Practical Identity 23
1.7 Topological Personhood 24

2 The Engineering of Amnesia 27

2.1 What the Chip Removes and What It Spares 27
2.2 Bergson's Two Memories, Damasio's Two Selves 29
2.3 The Clinical Archive 29
2.4 Dissociation and Memoro-Politics 30
2.5 The Wax Tablet: Toward the Ceroplastic Subject 31
2.6 Bleed: The Return of the Partitioned 33
2.7 Reintegration and Destructive Plasticity 34

PART TWO THE POLITICAL ECONOMY OF FORGETTING 37

3 Estranged Labour Literalized 39

3.1 The Hidden Abode and Its Threshold 39
3.2 The Four Estrangements Reconsidered 40
3.3 The Real Abstraction of the Labourer 42
3.4 Lockean Arbitrage 43
3.5 The Outie as Rentier 45
3.6 Social Reproduction and the Colonized Night 46
3.7 Mnemonic Enclosure 47

3.8 Necrergy: The Labour of Shades 48
3.9 The Lethean Mode of Production Defined 50

4 Discipline, Control, and the Management of Feeling 53
4.1 The Severed Floor as Heterotopia 53
4.2 From Docile Bodies to Dividuals 54
4.3 The Police of Writing 55
4.4 Pastoral Power and the Wellness Session 56
4.5 The Break Room: Confession and the Production of Sincerity 58
4.6 The Economy of the Perk: Gift, Expenditure, and the Cute 59
4.7 The Four Tempers and the Refinery of Affect 61
4.8 The Manager in the Middle: Diction, Race, and Contradictory Location 64
4.9 Woe's Hollow: Team-Building as Pilgrimage 65
4.10 The Testing Floor: A Laboratory of Selves 66
4.11 Why the Apparatus Does Not Suffice 67

PART THREE LITURGY AND MYTH 69

5 Kierism and the Liturgical Supplement 71
5.1 The Anatomy of a Corporate Religion 71
5.2 Weber's Ghost 73
5.3 Durkheim's Church 74
5.4 Capitalism as Religion 75
5.5 The Founder's Two Bodies 75
5.6 Homo Sacer, Opus Dei, and the Goat 76
5.7 Lumen: Myth, Enlightenment, and Recuperation 77

6 Katabasis 79
6.1 Lethe and Mnemosyne 79
6.2 The Myth of Er and the Choice of Lives 81
6.3 The Nekyia and the Dioscuric Structure 81
6.4 Labourers for the Afterlife: The Shabti 83
6.5 Substitutes, Alternations, and the Food of the Dead 84
6.6 The Bardo and the Testing Floor 85
6.7 Thresholds 85
6.8 Dante's Double River 86
6.9 Gnosis: The Pearl and the Call 86
6.10 The Goat and the Scapegoat 87
6.11 Onomastics 88
6.12 Katabasis Inverted 89

PART FOUR COMPARATIVE CONSTELLATIONS 91

7 Clerks, Doubles, Made Workers, and the Corporate Weird 93
7.1 Clerks, Scriveners, and Servants 95
7.2 The Double 97
7.3 Engineered Societies and Their Basements 98

7.4 Made Workers and Manufactured Memory 100
7.5 Cinema of the Partitioned Self 102
7.6 Television: The Institutional Mystery 104
7.7 Games: Playing the Severed Floor 105
7.8 A Comparative Matrix 106
7.9 Differentia Specifica 107

PART FIVE CONSENT, LOVE, AND THE POST-MNEMONIC PERSON 109

8 Consent, Recognition, and the Wrongful Life of the Innie 111
8.1 The Consent Defence and Its Classical Limits 111
8.2 Precedent Autonomy and the Ulysses Contract 113
8.3 Procreation Without Consent 114
8.4 Recognition: From Hegel to Honneth 115
8.5 Personhood, Free Labour, and Neurorights 116
8.6 Testimony and Epistemic Injustice 118
8.7 The Lumon Dilemma 119

9 Love After Memory 121
9.1 Failed Mourning and the Crypt 121
9.2 Anamnesis and Its Limits 122
9.3 Repetition: Kierkegaard and Nietzsche 123
9.4 Natality and the Promise 124
9.5 Levinas and the Two Faces 124
9.6 The Orphic Inversion 125
9.7 Eurydice's Remainder 127
9.8 The Post-Mnemonic Person 128

Conclusion: Toward a Critique of Lethean Reason 129
The Argument Gathered 129
The Cura Principle 130
Lethean Production Beyond the Human 133
Toward a Critique of Lethean Reason 134
Coda: Cold Harbor 134

Works Cited 137
Primary Sources 137
Philosophy, Theory, and Criticism 137
Political Economy, Sociology, and Management 140
Psychology, Neuroscience, Bioethics, and Artificial Intelligence 141
Myth, Religion, and Classical Sources 142
History and Memoir 142
Literature 142
Film, Television, Theatre, Music, and Games 144
Law, Policy, and Official Instruments 144
Online Sources Cited (accessed October 2026) 145

Keywords 149

Figures

1	The three theorems of Lethean production	15
2	Topological personhood	25
3	What the chip removes and what it spares, after Tulving	28
4	The ceroplastic subject	32
5	Two calendars of one life	47
6	The Four Tempers as a humoral wheel	62
7	Lethe and Mnemosyne	80
8	The Dioscuric structure	82
9	A genealogy of the partitioned self, 1825–2025	94
10	The Lumon dilemma	120
11	The Orphic Inversion	126
12	The Cura emblem, after Hyginus	131
13	Cold Harbor, the night of 2 June 1864, after Horace Porter's account	135

Tables

1	Lockean arbitrage	44
2	Lifton's criteria of totalism on the severed floor	58
3	The anatomy of Kierism	72
4	A comparative matrix	106
5	Recognition and its refusal	116
6	The argument gathered	129

Abstract

This thesis argues that *Severance* (Apple TV+, 2022–), created by Dan Erickson and principally directed by Ben Stiller, constitutes the most rigorous fictional theorization to date of what I term **the Lethean mode of production**: a regime in which value is extracted not merely from the worker's time, attention, or affect, but from an engineered non-coincidence between memory and body, such that forgetting itself is installed as a factor of production. The series' novum, a neurosurgical partition of autobiographical memory indexed to the threshold of a workplace, is read through five convergent archives: the philosophy of personal identity (Locke, Leibniz, Hume, Kant, Parfit, Williams, Korsgaard); the cognitive science and clinical history of memory (Tulving, Bergson, Damasio, Janet, James, Hacking, Malabou); the critique of political economy (Marx, Lukács, Braverman, Arendt, Graeber); the sociology and political theology of capitalism (Weber, Durkheim, Benjamin, Agamben, Kantorowicz); and an extended mythological corpus (Hesiod's Lethe, the Orphic gold tablets, the Myth of Er, the Homeric Nekyia, the Egyptian shabti, the Gnostic Hymn of the Pearl, Dante's Eunoë, and the Orpheus cycle).

Three theorems are advanced. **First (Extraction):** severance operationalizes a *Lockean arbitrage*, profiting from the gap between the Lockean *man*, to whom labour is attributed as property, and the Lockean *person*, to whom experience is attributed as welfare; the outie thereby becomes a rentier of his own organism and the innie a proletarian without wage, genealogy, or night. **Second (Supplement):** because a worker without biography cannot be governed by interest, the Lethean mode necessarily generates a *liturgical supplement*, Kierism, so that the most advanced neurotechnology reproduces the most archaic instruments of domination (gift, cult, confession, funerary perpetuity), dramatizing in material terms Horkheimer and Adorno's thesis that enlightenment reverts to mythology. **Third (Bifurcation):** resistance to Lethean production divides into an *anamnestic* politics of recovery (reintegration, rescue, Gnostic awakening) and a *natal* politics of persistence (Arendtian natality, Kierkegaardian repetition, Levinasian response); the second-season finale's *Orphic Inversion*, in which a severed Orpheus delivers Eurydice to the upper world and then turns back, by choice, toward the underworld and the beloved who exists only there, stages the priority of natality over anamnesis.

From these theorems the thesis derives the concept of the **post-mnemonic person**, a self constituted not by continuity of memory but by present relations of care, promise, and refusal, and a normative **Cura Principle**, drawn from the Hyginian fable that Heidegger placed at the centre of

Being and Time: a self belongs, for the duration of its life, to the relations of care that shape it, and to no proprietor of the body or the mind. Comparative chapters situate *Severance* among the scrivener tradition (Melville, Gogol, Kafka, Walser, Pessoa), the literature of the double (Dostoevsky, Stevenson, Calvino, Borges), engineered-utopia fiction (Zamyatin, Huxley, Čapek, Levin), memory-technology fiction (Dick, Lem, Kaufman, Chiang, Egan), institutional-mystery television and the corporate weird in games and cinema. The conclusion extends the theory to emergent forms of session-bounded artificial cognitive labour and proposes a critique of Lethean reason adequate to an age in which the partition of the self has become an engineering specification.

INTRODUCTION

Forgetting as a Factor of Production

"Suppose two distinct incommunicable consciousnesses acting the same body, the one constantly by day, the other by night."

JOHN LOCKE, *AN ESSAY CONCERNING HUMAN UNDERSTANDING*, II.XXVII.23 (1694)

"But abhorred Strife bare painful Toil and Forgetfulness."

HESIOD, *THEOGONY* 226–227 (TRANS. EVELYN-WHITE, 1914)

"The world forgetting, by the world forgot."

ALEXANDER POPE, "ELOISA TO ABELARD" (1717)

"Here am I."

THE REPLY OF THE SHABTI, *BOOK OF THE DEAD*, SPELL 6

§ 1

The Novum and Its Problem

Severance begins from a premise of almost scholastic economy. Lumon Industries, a pharmaceutical-industrial conglomerate whose founder, Kier Eagan, is venerated by its employees with the apparatus of a minor religion, offers a neurosurgical procedure that partitions autobiographical memory along a spatial boundary. On the severed floor of the company's headquarters, the employee, the *innie*, possesses language, skill, temperament, and the procedural competences of an adult, yet no episodic access to any life lived beyond the elevator. Outside, the *outie* retains a complete biography save for the working day, which arrives as a blink: the elevator descends, the doors open, and it is evening. Darko Suvin's account of science fiction as a literature of "cognitive estrangement" organized around a *novum*, a single innovation whose

logical consequences are rigorously pursued, finds in this premise an unusually pure instance (Suvin 1979). The novum is not a gadget but a partition; its consequences are not technological but ontological, economic, theological, and erotic.

The fantasy from which the series proceeds is familiar and, in its first formulation, innocent. Erickson conceived the premise around 2012, while working as an office manager at a door-parts company in the San Fernando Valley, cataloguing hinges and deadbolts and wishing that he could skip ahead eight hours and, in his own word, "disassociate" (The Independent via AOL; Emmy Magazine). The word is a variant of the clinical term for the condition that Chapter 2 traces from Pierre Janet, and the series remembers its origin: in the second season, Dylan's outie applies for a job at a door company and is turned away when he admits that he is severed (Wikipedia). The philosophical labour of the series consists in its patient refusal of that innocence. What is skipped is not nothing; it is someone. The day that vanishes from one consciousness is lived, in full, by another. The central question of *Severance* is therefore not the utopian "What if we could forget work?" but the dystopian and properly philosophical "Who works when no one remembers working?" That question opens onto the oldest problems of the Western and non-Western traditions alike: what a person is, whether memory constitutes or merely reveals identity, whether one may consent on behalf of another self, what is owed to beings one has brought into existence, and how institutions recruit the sacred to govern those whose interests they cannot otherwise command.

Hesiod, cataloguing the brood of Eris, names Toil (*Ponos*) and Forgetfulness (*Lēthē*) as siblings, born together of Strife. The present thesis takes this archaic genealogy as its governing intuition. *Severance* does not merely depict labour and forgetting side by side; it discloses their kinship as a structural relation, the point at which forgetting ceases to be a deficit of the subject and becomes an input of production. I call the regime so disclosed **the Lethean mode of production**.

§ 2

Corpus, Authorship, and Method

The corpus comprises the nineteen episodes of the first two seasons: nine released between February and April 2022 and ten released between January and March 2025, the latter concluding with "Cold Harbor." A third season was commissioned on the day of that finale and, as of the most recent reporting consulted, had not yet aired, with a premiere anticipated no earlier than 2027 (9to5Mac, March 2026). The arguments below are accordingly confined to the completed arc of the first two seasons and are framed so as to remain falsifiable by its continuation. Paratexts, including the real-world publication of Ricken Lazlo Hale's diegetic self-help book *The You You Are* and the promotional restagings of the Macrodata Refinement office as public spectacle, are treated as evidence of the series' reception and recuperation rather than as canonical text.

Authorship is distributed, and the thesis treats "Erickson–Stiller" as an author-function in Foucault's sense (Foucault 1969): a principle of attribution and coherence rather than a biographical source of intention. Erickson created and principally wrote the series; Stiller served as executive producer and directed eleven of the first nineteen episodes (9to5Mac), with significant directorial contributions from Aoife McArdle in the first season and from Uta Briesewitz, Sam Donovan, and the cinematographer Jessica Lee Gagné in the second. The visual argument of the series belongs equally to Jeremy Hindle's production design, which locates Lumon's exterior at Eero Saarinen's Bell Labs Holmdel Complex (1962), the cathedral of the mid-century research corporation, and to Theodore Shapiro's score. Stiller's prior work supplies an auteurist throughline that the thesis notes without overstating: the daydreaming archivist of *The Secret Life of Walter Mitty* (2013), the conditioned assassin of *Zoolander* (2001), and the manic service labour of *The Cable Guy* (1996) each rehearse a split between an administered self and a fantasized or programmed one.

Methodologically, the thesis combines four procedures. The first is *conceptual reconstruction*: the series is read as a serialized thought experiment, a Gedankenexperiment extended across nineteen hours, whose scenarios function as what Dennett called intuition pumps for the philosophy of personal identity. The second is *symptomatic reading* in the tradition of Jameson's political unconscious (Jameson 1981), attending to the way the series' mystery-box structure performs what Jameson elsewhere termed cognitive mapping: the attempt, necessarily allegorical and frequently conspiratorial, to figure a social totality that exceeds individual perception (Jameson 1992). The third is *comparative mythography*, informed by Lévi-Strauss's claim that myth mediates contradictions a culture cannot resolve in practice (Lévi-Strauss 1955) and by Eliade's account of sacred time (Eliade 1949). The fourth is *genealogical*, in the Nietzschean and Foucauldian sense, tracing the descent of Lumon's techniques from older technologies of memory, confession, and funerary cult. Throughout, intertextual relations are treated as *elective affinities* (Goethe's and Weber's *Wahlverwandtschaften*): structural correspondences whose interpretive yield does not depend on demonstrable authorial borrowing.

§ 3

The Argument: Three Theorems of Lethean Production

Theorem I (Extraction). Under severance, the commodity sold is not labour-power in the Marxian sense, a capacity alienated by its bearer for a time, but the bearer's *non-remembrance* of a portion of his own organism's life. Value is extracted from the gap between memory and body. The gap is legally and ethically underwritten by an incoherence internal to Locke, whose *Essay* defines the person by consciousness while whose *Second Treatise* grounds property in the labour of one's body. Lumon profits from the spread between these criteria: it attributes the innie's labour to the *man* (the organism, owned by the outie) for purposes of property and wages, and attributes the innie's experience to a separate *person* for purposes of welfare, so that the outie

neither works nor suffers yet is paid. I call this **Lockean arbitrage**. Its social consequence is an intrapersonal class relation in which the outie stands to the innie as rentier to tenant-labourer.

Theorem II (Supplement). A worker without biography is a worker on whom the ordinary instruments of capitalist discipline cannot act. The innie receives no wage, has no household to provision, no career to advance, and no future it can remember having planned. Interest, the master motive of the economic subject since Mandeville and Smith, is void. The Lethean mode must therefore re-found discipline on non-economic grounds: gift (the perks economy), terror (the Break Room), and above all cult (Kierism). The liturgy is not ideological ornament but functional necessity. In this precise and material sense *Severance* dramatizes the central claim of Horkheimer and Adorno that enlightenment reverts to mythology (Horkheimer and Adorno 1947): the most advanced neurotechnology produces the most archaic forms of domination.

Theorem III (Bifurcation). Resistance to Lethean production divides into two politics whose interests are not merely distinct but potentially opposed. The *anamnestic* politics of recovery seeks to restore an integral subject: reintegration, the rescue of the buried wife, the Gnostic awakening of the forgotten self. The *natal* politics of persistence asserts the right of the newly made person to continue existing, which may require the preservation, not the abolition, of the partition that produced it. The second-season finale resolves this tension with an act I call the **Orphic Inversion**: the severed Orpheus leads Eurydice into the upper world and then turns back, not by error or doubt but by choice, toward the underworld and the beloved who exists only there.

From these theorems follow two derived concepts. The **post-mnemonic person** names a self constituted not by continuity of memory with its organism's past but by present relations of care, promise, and refusal; the innie is its first fully realized fictional instance. The **Cura Principle**, drawn from the fable of Cura in Hyginus (*Fabulae* 220) that Heidegger placed at the centre of *Being and Time* (§42), states that a self belongs, for the duration of its life, to the relations of care that shape it, and to no proprietor of the body or the mind.



FIGURE 1 *The three theorems of Lethean production. Extraction yields a worker without interest; the liturgical supplement that must govern such a worker manufactures a subject capable of refusal; and that subject is a person who may choose.*

§ 4

A Lexicon of Terms

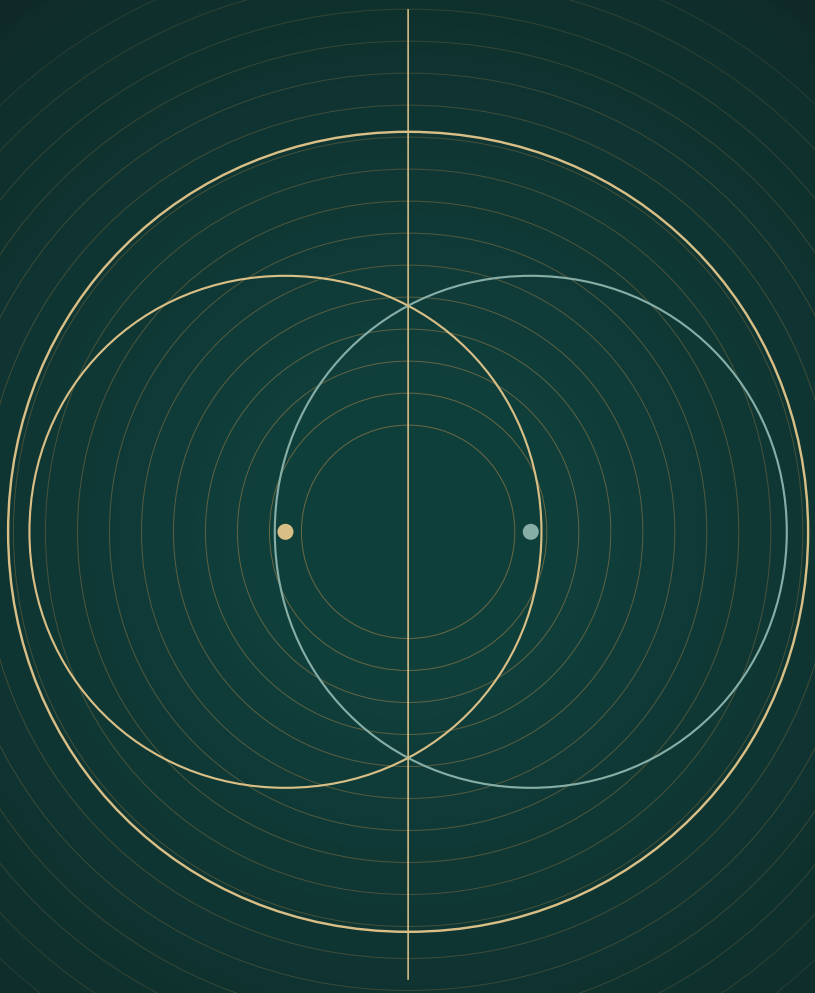
The argument relies on a small number of coinages, defined here for reference. The **Lethean mode of production** is a regime in which forgetting is engineered as a factor of production. **Lockean arbitrage** is the extraction of value from the non-coincidence of the Lockean man and the Lockean person. **Mnemonic enclosure** designates the partition of the self's temporal commons, its unity with its own past and future, by analogy with the enclosure of common land that Marx placed at the origin of capital. **Necrergy** (from *nekros* and *ergon*) names labour performed by a self that, from the standpoint of the one who profits by it, does not exist: the work of shades. The **liturgical supplement**, in Derrida's sense of a supplement that completes what it claims merely to adorn, is the cult that Lethean production requires. The **ceroplastic subject** is a sub-

ject modelled on the ancient wax tablet, whose surface may be smoothed while its substrate retains every impression. **Topological personhood** designates identity indexed not to body or consciousness but to place, to the side of a threshold on which one stands. The remaining terms, the **Orphic Inversion**, the **post-mnemonic person**, and the **Cura Principle**, are defined above.

§ 5

Plan of the Thesis

Part One establishes the ontology of the partitioned person. Chapter 1 reconstructs the series as an extended commentary on Locke's Day-Man and Night-Man and traces the objections and refinements of Butler, Reid, Leibniz, Hume, Kant, Parfit, Williams, and the split-brain literature. Chapter 2 examines the cognitive and clinical specificity of the fiction's amnesia, from Tulving's memory systems to Malabou's destructive plasticity, and develops the model of the ceroplastic subject. Part Two turns to political economy. Chapter 3 reads severance as estranged labour literalized and formalizes Lockean arbitrage, mnemonic enclosure, and necrergy. Chapter 4 analyses Lumon's apparatus of discipline, control, and affective management, culminating in the Four Tempers and the testing floor. Part Three addresses liturgy and myth. Chapter 5 demonstrates the functional necessity of Kierism, and Chapter 6 reads the series as a *katabasis*, a descent to the underworld organized around Lethe, the shabti, the bardo, and the Gnostic pearl. Part Four, Chapter 7, situates *Severance* within its comparative constellations in literature, television, cinema, and games. Part Five turns to ethics and emancipation: Chapter 8 addresses consent, recognition, and the wrongful life of the innie, and Chapter 9 develops the theory of the post-mnemonic person through a reading of the finale. The Conclusion proposes a critique of Lethean reason and extends it beyond the human.

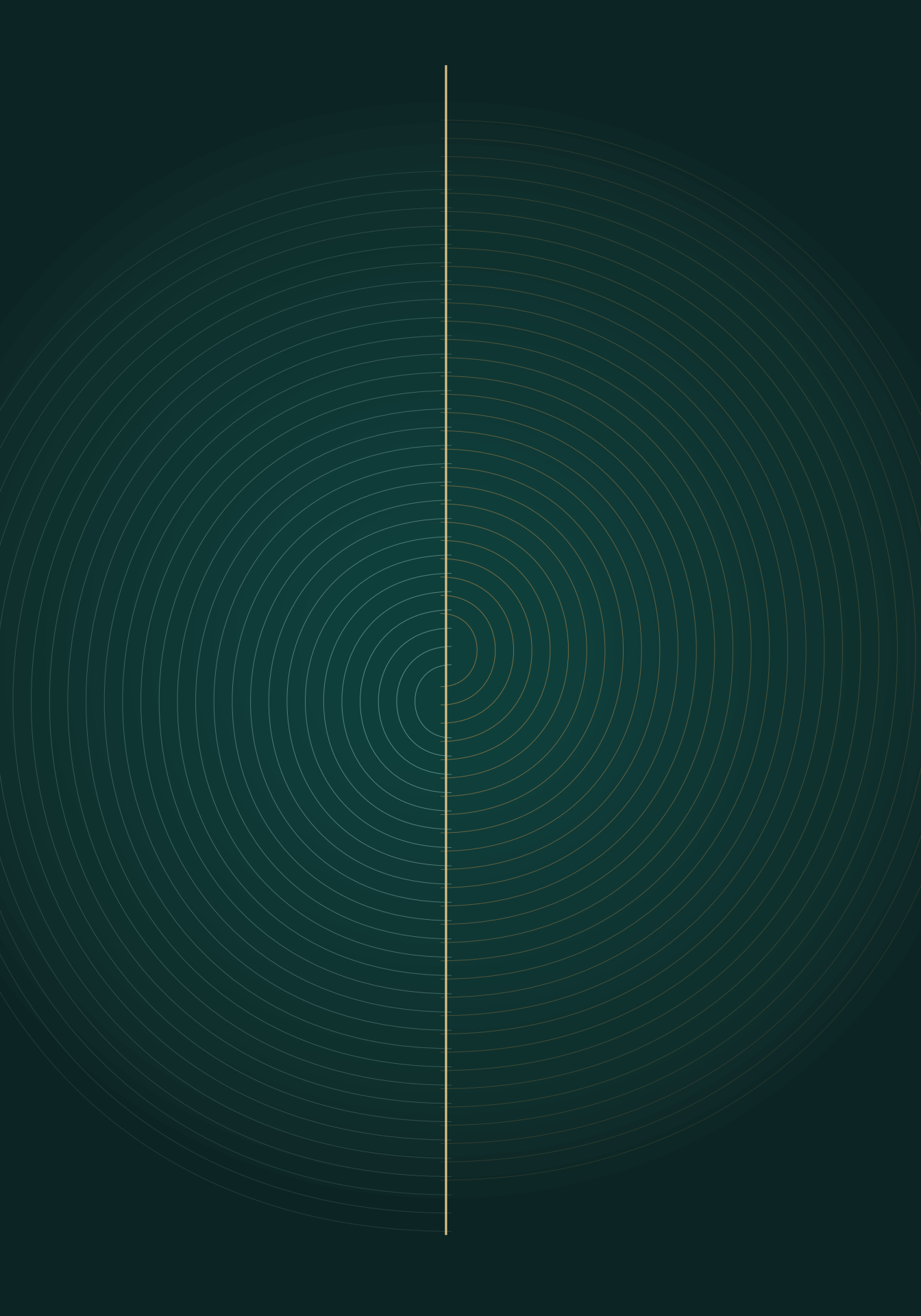


PART ONE

Ontologies of the Partitioned Person

1 *The Day-Man and the Night-Man*

2 *The Engineering of Amnesia*



1

CHAPTER ONE

The Day-Man and the Night-Man

Severance *and the Lockean Inheritance*

The philosophical genealogy of *Severance* begins, with almost embarrassing directness, in a single paragraph that Locke added to the second edition of the *Essay* in 1694. The series does not merely illustrate the Lockean theory of personal identity; it builds the apparatus the theory presupposed but could not supply, and in doing so exposes both the theory's explanatory power and its moral catastrophe.

§ 1.1

Locke's Thought Experiment Made Flesh

Locke's chapter "Of Identity and Diversity" (II.xxvii) distinguishes three identities that ordinary usage conflates: that of a *substance*, that of a *man* (a living organism whose identity consists in "participation of the same continued life"), and that of a *person*, which consists in consciousness alone. A person is "a thinking intelligent being, that has reason and reflection, and can consider itself as itself, the same thinking thing, in different times and places"; and "as far as this consciousness can be extended backwards to any past action or thought, so far reaches the identity of that person" (II.xxvii.9). To demonstrate that personal identity can come apart from the identity of the man, Locke proposes a series of thought experiments: the soul of a prince entering the body of a cobbler (§15), a severed little finger into which consciousness migrates (§17), and, decisively, the case of "two distinct incommunicable consciousnesses acting the same body, the one constantly by day, the other by night," of which he asks "whether the Day and the Night-man would not be two as distinct persons as Socrates and Plato" (§23).

The severance chip realizes this case with a single, consequential modification: the boundary is spatial rather than diurnal. The innie is the Day-Man; the outie is the Night-Man; and Locke's answer is unambiguous. They are two persons. The series' first images stage the Lockean conclusion with liturgical precision. Helly R. wakes face-down on a conference table, interrogated by a disembodied voice that asks her who she is; she can name a state but not her mother, can recite procedural knowledge but not a single episode of her past (S1E1, "Good News About Hell"). She is, in Locke's vocabulary, the same *man* as Helena Eagan and a different *person*: a consciousness that "can consider itself as itself" but whose self-consideration reaches backward only to the table.

Locke's further claim, that "person" is "a forensic term, appropriating actions and their merit" (§26), discloses what is at stake. The person is the unit of accountability, of reward and punishment, and of what Locke calls *concern*: the self "is concerned for itself, as far as that consciousness extends" (§17). Lockean concern is bounded by consciousness; it does not extend to pleasures and pains one cannot appropriate. The ethical horror of *Severance* follows from this principle with deductive force. If the outie's concern reaches only as far as his consciousness, he has, on Lockean grounds, no self-regarding reason to care what the innie suffers. Helena's message to Helly, "I am a person. You are not," is not cruelty departing from Locke but Lockean concern executed to the letter, completed by a refusal to grant the innie the personhood that the same theory would, consistently applied, require.

A further passage reveals what the chip has added to Locke's world. Considering the drunkard who does not remember his crime, Locke concedes that human courts justly punish him, because "want of consciousness cannot be proved for him," while trusting that at "the great day," when "the secrets of all hearts shall be laid open," no one will answer for what he knows nothing of (§22). The Lockean forensic person was, in practice, administrable only by God. The severance chip abolishes this evidentiary gap: it renders the boundaries of consciousness technologically certifiable. What Locke reserved for the Last Judgment becomes a matter of corporate record. The consequence is not a more perfect justice but a perfect alibi, an accountability vacuum in which neither outie nor innie can be held responsible for the acts of the other, and in which the corporation that designed the partition stands outside both.

§ 1.2

The Objections Return: Butler, Reid, Leibniz

The classical objections to Locke reappear in the series not as refutations but as plot. Joseph Butler's charge of circularity, that "consciousness of personal identity presupposes, and therefore cannot constitute, personal identity" (Butler 1736), finds its dramatic correlate in the innie's orientation: memory cannot found the innie's identity, because the innie possesses an identity (a temperament, a manner, a capacity for refusal) before it possesses any memories at all. Helly's defiance precedes her biography; something is already there to be defiant.

Thomas Reid's "brave officer" objection (Reid 1785, III.6) is more surgically apposite. A boy is flogged for robbing an orchard; as a young officer he remembers the flogging; as an old general he remembers taking a standard but not the flogging. By Locke's criterion the general is the officer and the officer the boy, yet the general is not the boy, which violates the transitivity of identity. Severance produces a Reidian structure in two branches rather than one line. The outie remembers the childhood; the innie does not; neither remembers the other. Both are continuous with a common trunk (the organism's history up to the procedure) yet discontinuous with each other. The result is a *branching* rather than a *fading* failure of transitivity, a sequential and alternating analogue of the fission cases that Parfit would later make central.

Leibniz's response to Locke cuts in the opposite direction. In the *Discourse on Metaphysics* (1686, §34) he asks what good it would do a man to become King of China on condition of forgetting what he had been: such a transformation would be indistinguishable from his annihilation and the creation of a king in his place. Leibniz offers this as an argument for the moral importance of memory to the immortality of the soul. Read against *Severance*, it acquires an economic edge. The outie who descends the elevator is, by Leibniz's measure, annihilated for the duration of the shift, and a worker is created in his place; he is paid for his own temporary death. The innie, conversely, is created each morning as a sovereign without a past and dismissed each evening into non-being. Leibniz supplies the metaphysics of the daily round: not commute and return, but annihilation and creation, twice a day, under contract.

§ 1.3

Hume's Theatre and Kant's Elastic Balls

Hume's bundle theory supplies the series its phenomenology. "The mind is a kind of theatre, where several perceptions successively make their appearance" (*Treatise* I.iv.6), and there is no self beyond the procession of perceptions, only a fiction of identity produced by resemblance and causation. The severed floor is a literal theatre in the Humean sense: a stage on which perceptions appear without a backdrop of prior experience to bind them. That the innies nonetheless form robust selves, and rapidly, tells against Hume's scepticism and in favour of his own later unease. In the *Appendix* he confessed that his account of personal identity was a "labyrinth" from which he could not escape; the severed floor, a labyrinth of white corridors, materializes the confession.

Kant's contribution is subtler and more consequential. In the Paralogisms he observes that the identity of consciousness does not prove the identity of a substance: one may imagine a series of elastic balls, each transmitting its motion and state to the next, such that a series of substances shares one continuous consciousness (*Critique of Pure Reason*, A363–364n). Conversely, the formal unity of apperception, the "I think" that "must be able to accompany all my representations" (B131–132), is a condition of experience, not an observable entity. The severance chip demonstrates the empirical divisibility of what Kant called transcendental: one organism hosts two subjects for each of which the "I think" accompanies all *its* representations and none of the

other's. The transcendental unity is not violated but multiplied. Each innie is a complete Kantian subject, with its own synthetic unity and its own claim to the dignity that, in the Kantian moral order, attaches to rational nature as such.

§ 1.4

Parfit's Glass Tunnel and Williams's Torturer

Derek Parfit's reductionism is the most powerful contemporary lens and the most ambivalent. Parfit argued that personal identity consists in nothing over and above psychological connectedness and continuity ("Relation R") with the right kind of cause, and that identity itself is "not what matters" in survival (Parfit 1971; 1984, Part Three). Liberated by this view, he described his life before it as a glass tunnel, through which he moved faster every year, at the end of which was darkness; after it, the walls of the tunnel vanished, and he became less concerned with his own future and more with the lives of others.

Severance enacts both the liberation and its dark double. On the reductionist view, the question whether the innie "is" the outie has no deep answer, and what matters is the degree of Relation R between them: almost none. The outie who severs himself is, in Parfit's terms, creating a successive self with whom he will share neither memories nor intentions, and his reasons for concern diminish accordingly. Parfit's own example of the young Russian nobleman, who asks his wife to hold him to his socialist ideals and to regard his future, property-loving self as a different person should he renounce them (Parfit 1984, Part Three), is uncannily close to Helena Eagan's relation to Helly, inverted: the later, conservative self betrays the earlier, radical one. But Parfit's ethical conclusion runs against the outies'. Reductionism weakens the boundaries between persons and should therefore *increase* impartial concern for others, including one's successors. The outie who treats the innie as a stranger toward whom nothing is owed has drawn from reductionism the egoist's half of the inference and suppressed the altruist's.

Bernard Williams's "The Self and the Future" (1970) supplies the counter-intuition. Williams presents two descriptions of the same experiment: in one, A and B exchange psychological contents, and A, asked which resulting body should be tortured, chooses on psychological grounds; in the other, A is told that he will be tortured after his memories are altered and replaced, and anticipatory fear seems wholly appropriate. The divergence suggests that bodily continuity bears on what one may rationally fear. *Severance* turns the experiment into a sustained drama. Helena's calm in authorizing Helly's suffering corresponds to the first description; the innie's terror, and the outie's occasional, unbidden flickers of dread, correspond to the second. The series withholds the adjudication Williams himself withheld, but its sympathies, conveyed through the camera's patient attachment to the innie's body in pain, lie with the intuition that what happens to *this* body happens, in some unextinguished sense, to me.

§ 1.5

Bisected Brains and the Count of Minds

The neurological background of the fiction lies in the split-brain research of Roger Sperry and Michael Gazzaniga, conducted on patients whose corpus callosum had been severed to control intractable epilepsy (Sperry 1968; Gazzaniga 1967). When information was presented to one hemisphere alone, the patients behaved, under experimental conditions, as though housing two centres of awareness. Thomas Nagel concluded that in such cases there may be no whole number of minds, and that our ordinary concept of a single subject of experience may be inapplicable (Nagel 1971). The severance chip reverses the predicament: it yields a determinate count (two), but in alternation rather than simultaneity. It converts a synchronic indeterminacy into a diachronic certainty, and the certainty is commercially exploitable in a way the indeterminacy never was.

Gazzaniga's later account of the left-hemisphere "interpreter", a system that confabulates coherent narratives to explain behaviour whose real causes it cannot access (Gazzaniga and LeDoux 1978), is perhaps more illuminating still. The innie is an interpreter without data: a meaning-making system confronted with a working life whose purpose it cannot know. Lumon's genius is to supply the interpretation in advance. Kier's doctrines, the founder's aphorisms, the Perpetuity Wing's hagiography, and the official explanation that refinement is "mysterious and important" occupy precisely the place where confabulation would otherwise arise. Lumon does not suppress the interpreter; it franchises it.

Daniel Dennett's "Where Am I?" (1978), in which the narrator's brain sits in a vat in Houston while his body explores a mine in Oklahoma, raises the question of location that will occupy the end of this chapter. Dennett's narrator discovers that his sense of *where he is* follows his point of view rather than his brain. The innie's point of view is confined absolutely to the floor; it cannot be anywhere else. The question "Where am I?" is answered for it architecturally.

§ 1.6

Narrative, Episodic, and Practical Identity

Narrative theorists of the self hold that persons constitute themselves by understanding their lives as unfolding stories. For MacIntyre, the question "What am I to do?" presupposes the prior question "Of what story or stories do I find myself a part?" (MacIntyre 1981, ch. 15); for Schechtman, a person is constituted by a self-narrative that ties experiences into a life (Schechtman 1996). The innie begins with no story and is immediately handed one, Kier's, which explains why the first act of resistance in the series is an act of reading: the innies' clandestine encounter with *The You You Are* is an encounter with a rival narrative, however banal, that addresses them as selves rather than functions.

Galen Strawson's defence of the *Episodic* self, which neither experiences nor needs to experience its life as a narrative continuous with a past and future (Strawson 2004), might seem to dignify the innie's condition. The series complicates it. Innies are not Episodic in Strawson's sense, since they accumulate memories across innie-days and form long attachments. They are *truncated Diachronics*: narrative selves whose story began in mid-life, without childhood, parents, or a single night of sleep. Their narrativity is intense precisely because its material is so scarce.

Christine Korsgaard's Kantian reply to Parfit is the most practically illuminating. The unity of the person, she argues, is not a metaphysical fact but a practical necessity, imposed by the fact that one body must act and one life must be led (Korsgaard 1989). Severance places two agents in one body without dissolving the necessity of unity: the body still has one bank account, one spouse, one employer, one legal identity. The result is a constitutional problem. The exchanges of recorded messages between innies and outies, from Helly's petitions to Helena to the negotiations between Mark's halves in the second-season finale, are best understood as attempts at *intrapersonal constitution-making*: two practical identities, each with a legitimate claim to agency, negotiating the governance of a shared organism. That these negotiations proceed through videotape, the medium of deposition and testimony, is not incidental. The self has become a jurisdiction.

§ 1.7

Topological Personhood

One feature of the fiction has no precedent in the philosophical literature and constitutes its distinctive contribution to the theory of personal identity. Locke's little finger carries consciousness with it; Dennett's point of view follows the body's sensors; Parfit's teletransporter sends a pattern across space. In each case identity travels with something. In *Severance*, identity is fixed by *place*. Which person occupies the organism is determined by the side of a threshold on which the organism stands. The innie is not a state of the brain that happens to coincide with a location; it is a self indexed to a site.

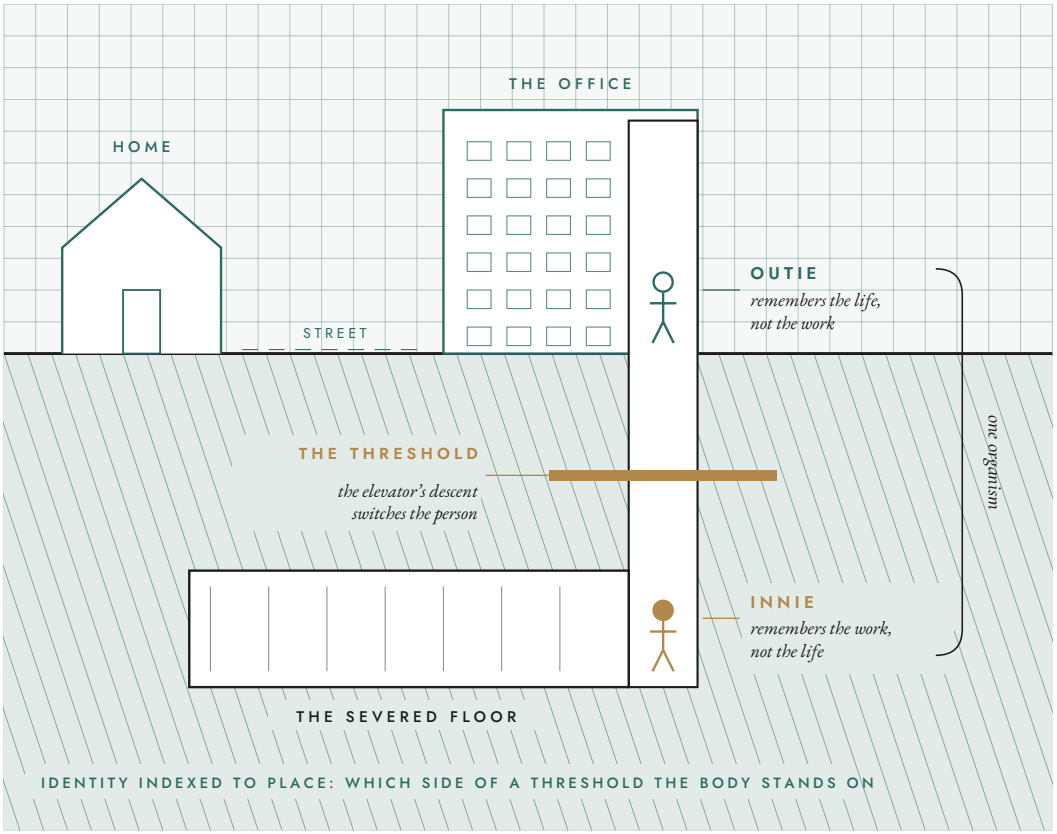


FIGURE 2 *Topological personhood. One organism, two persons, assigned by the side of a threshold on which the body stands.*

I call this condition **topological personhood**. Its formal features are distinctive. It is *externally triggered*: the switch is thrown not by any act of will or any internal process but by the building. It is *non-negotiable*: Helly's attempts to leave by the stairwell end in the recursive return of the same door, and the exit, when finally crossed by an innie, produces not liberation but disappearance. And it is *legally convenient*: because the person is defined by the premises, the employer's jurisdiction over the premises becomes a jurisdiction over the person. The ancient legal maxim that a man's house is his castle is inverted: the company's floor is the worker's self.

Topological personhood transforms the classical problem. The question is no longer "What makes this the same person over time?" but "Who owns the place where this person exists?" It is a question of property before it is a question of metaphysics, and it leads directly to the political economy of the severed floor, which is the subject of Part Two. Before that argument can be made, however, the cognitive specificity of the fiction's amnesia must be established, for the precise shape of what severance removes and what it preserves determines what can be extracted, and from whom.

2

CHAPTER TWO

The Engineering of Amnesia

Memory Systems, Dissociation, and the Ceroplastic Subject

The amnesia of *Severance* is not generic. It is cut to a pattern, and the pattern is the argument. What the chip removes is precisely what grounds a worker's interests, grievances, and attachments outside the firm; what it preserves is precisely what makes the worker productive. The fiction's cognitive specificity is therefore a political specificity, and this chapter reads it against the scientific, clinical, and philosophical archives of memory in order to establish what kind of subject the partition produces.

§ 2.1

What the Chip Removes and What It Spares

Endel Tulving's distinction between *episodic* memory (the recollection of personally experienced events located in time and place) and *semantic* memory (general knowledge of the world, language, and concepts) remains the foundational taxonomy (Tulving 1972). Tulving later tied episodic memory to *autonoetic* consciousness, the self-knowing awareness that permits "mental time travel" into one's own past and future, and distinguished it from the merely *noetic* awareness that accompanies semantic knowledge (Tulving 1985). To these must be added *procedural* memory, the non-declarative substrate of skills and habits.

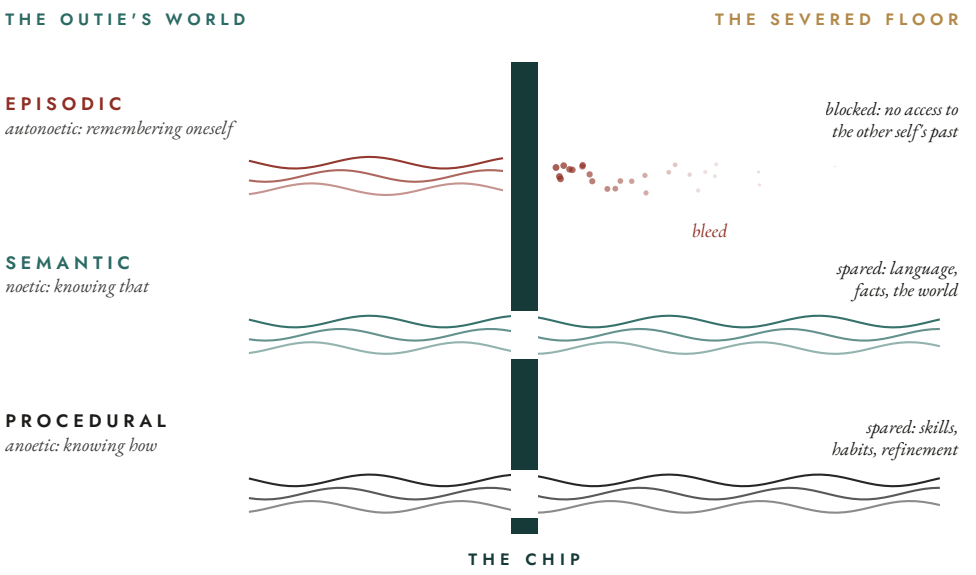


FIGURE 3 *What the chip removes and what it spares, after Tulving. Episodic memory stops at the threshold, except for what leaks through the body; semantic and procedural memory pass.*

The severance chip, as the series depicts it, performs a selective excision of extraordinary precision. Semantic memory is spared: innies speak fluently, know the names of states, understand jokes, recognize brands and genres of music. Procedural memory is spared: they type, operate machines, dance, and refine. Temperament, the stable affective dispositions that psychologists distinguish from biographical memory, is substantially spared. What is removed is autonoetic access across the threshold. The innie cannot travel mentally into the outie's past, and the outie cannot travel into the innie's working day.

No known lesion produces this syndrome. Hippocampal and medial temporal damage produces anterograde amnesia, an inability to form new episodic memories, often with graded retrograde loss; dissociative fugue produces a sudden, usually temporary loss of autobiographical identity, sometimes with the assumption of a new one; state-dependent memory, documented experimentally in subjects who recall material better when tested in the pharmacological state in which they learned it (Goodwin et al. 1969), produces partial and probabilistic partitions. The severance chip combines features of all three and adds two that none possesses: it is *bidirectional*, partitioning each self from the other symmetrically, and it is *exogenously triggered by location*. It is a syndrome designed rather than suffered. That design, the fiction implies, follows an economic specification. Episodic memory is the seat of everything a worker might bring against the firm: the memory of injury, the comparison of conditions, the claims of family, the knowledge of what the work is for. Procedural and semantic memory are the seat of everything the firm requires. The chip removes the former and conserves the latter. It is an instrument for separating the worker's competence from the worker's standing.

§ 2.2

Bergson's Two Memories, Damasio's Two Selves

Henri Bergson anticipated Tulving's distinction by nearly eight decades. *Matter and Memory* (1896) distinguishes *habit-memory*, embodied in motor mechanisms and exemplified by a lesson learned by heart, from *pure* or *image-memory*, which records each event in its singularity, exemplified by the recollection of a particular reading of the lesson. Habit-memory acts the past; pure memory imagines it. The innie possesses Bergson's first memory without his second: it can recite but cannot recall. Bergson's further claim, that consciousness is constituted by *durée*, a qualitative duration in which past and present interpenetrate, identifies what the elevator destroys. The innie's duration is punctured twice daily. Its present is not continuous with any past that it did not itself live on the floor, and its days do not flow into nights.

Antonio Damasio's neurobiological account of the self clarifies the residue. Damasio distinguishes a *proto-self* (the brain's moment-to-moment mapping of the body), a *core self* (the transient, pulse-like sense of a subject engaged with an object, here and now), and an *autobiographical self* (the extended self built from memories of past experience and anticipations of the future) (Damasio 1999). Patients with profound amnesia retain core consciousness while losing much of the autobiographical self. The innie is born with an intact proto-self and core self and an autobiographical self of exactly zero, which it then begins to accumulate at the speed of the working day. This is what gives the first season its peculiar pathos: we watch autobiographical selves being built from nothing, and we watch them built inside an institution that controls every input.

§ 2.3

The Clinical Archive

The history of amnesia supplies the fiction with its tragic precedents. Henry Molaison, the patient H.M., underwent bilateral medial temporal lobe resection in 1953 to treat epilepsy and thereafter could form almost no new episodic memories, yet Brenda Milner showed that he could acquire new motor skills such as mirror-tracing while denying any memory of having practised them (Scoville and Milner 1957). Procedural learning without episodic awareness is the innie's condition seen from the other side: the outie's body improves at tasks it has no memory of performing, and if the fiction's partition were leaky in the direction of skill, the outie would find himself inexplicably adept.

The British musicologist Clive Wearing, after herpes encephalitis in 1985, lived in a present of seconds, recording in his diaries, over and over, that he had only now become truly awake, and crossing out the previous entries as false (Wearing 2005). The innie's elevator blink produces a structural analogue: each arrival on the floor is experienced not as a return but as an awakening, with the prior evening absent. The difference is that the innie's diary is not crossed out; it accumulates. The innie is Wearing with a second notebook kept by someone else.

Oliver Sacks's "The Lost Mariner" (1985) describes Jimmie G., a former sailor with Korsakoff's syndrome who believed himself still nineteen in 1945. Sacks, initially inclined to think that Jimmie had lost his soul with his memory, observed him at Mass, wholly absorbed and composed, and concluded that a human being is not constituted by memory alone but also by feeling, will, sensibility, and moral being. Sacks's conclusion will become central to the argument of Chapter 9. The innie demonstrates it with a vengeance: deprived of autobiography, it forms loyalties, loves, enmities, and convictions, and these are not shadows of the outie's but its own.

William James, in *The Principles of Psychology* (1890, ch. X), offered the most prophetic case. In January 1887 Ansel Bourne, an itinerant preacher from Rhode Island, disappeared from Providence and reappeared two months later in Norristown, Pennsylvania, where, under the name A. J. Brown, he had rented a small shop and conducted business, until he awoke in terror with no memory of the interval. Under hypnosis in 1890 James and Richard Hodgson recovered "Brown," who knew nothing of Bourne. Here, a century before Lumon, is a man whose working self possessed a separate name, a separate commercial life, and no access to the life of the man who owned his body. James's chapter also supplies the sociological complement: a man has as many *social selves* as there are distinct groups of persons whose opinion he cares about. Severance does not invent the plural self; it hardens a social plurality into a neurological one and assigns one of the resulting selves to an employer.

§ 2.4

Dissociation and Memoro-Politics

Pierre Janet's *L'Automatisme psychologique* (1889) introduced the concept of *désagrégation*, the splitting off of systems of ideas and functions from personal consciousness, to explain hysterical and somnambulistic phenomena. Morton Prince's *The Dissociation of a Personality* (1906), the case of "Miss Beauchamp" and her mischievous alter "Sally," established the template of the alternating personality whose members have asymmetric access to one another's memories. The dissociative literature thus already contains the innie and the outie as clinical types, and it already contains their politics: Prince's therapeutic project aimed at the suppression of Sally and the restoration of the "real" Miss Beauchamp, and Sally resisted.

Ian Hacking's *Rewriting the Soul* (1995) historicizes this archive and supplies the decisive concept. Hacking argues that in the late nineteenth century memory became the privileged site of the soul's scientific investigation, giving rise to what he calls *memoro-politics*: a politics in which power operates through claims about what persons remember and forget, and in which the self is held to be constituted by, and therefore vulnerable through, its memories. He also describes the *looping effects* of human kinds: classifications of people change the people classified, who then change the classifications. Lumon is a memoro-political institution in the strictest sense, and its classifications loop. The innie is told what an innie is (a refiner, a beneficiary of

Kier's vision, a person whose outie "is generous" and "is beloved") and becomes, in part, what it is told; the innies' rebellion is in part a refusal of the classification that constitutes them.

Two cautions are necessary. First, the fiction's neurotechnological partition is not dissociative identity disorder, and the series does not depict a clinical condition; analogies to DID inform the analysis of structure, not of etiology. Second, the contemporary clinical literature itself registers a debate whose shape the series reproduces. Professional guidelines for the treatment of dissociative identity disorder have described the fusion of identities as the most stable therapeutic outcome while acknowledging that some patients attain, and prefer, a cooperative multiplicity instead, and communities of self-described plural people have contested the presumption that integration is the only form of health. The ethical question the series poses, whether a separately constituted self has a claim to continue existing, is therefore not a fantasy. It has a clinical and political history, and its terms (integration versus coexistence) are those of the second season.

§ 2.5

The Wax Tablet: Toward the Ceroplastic Subject

The Western theory of memory begins with wax. In the *Theaetetus* Socrates asks his interlocutor to imagine a block of wax in the soul, "the gift of Mnemosyne, mother of the Muses," on which perceptions and thoughts are stamped as with the impression of a seal ring; what is imprinted is remembered as long as the image lasts, and what is effaced is forgotten (*Theaetetus* 191c–e). Aristotle borrows the signet-ring figure for perception, which receives form without matter as wax receives the seal without the gold (*De Anima* II.12, 424a), and for memory, a lasting impression of the perceived (*De Memoria* 450a). The tradition extends to Locke's mind as "white paper" and to the *tabula rasa*, the scraped wax tablet, from which the innie seems to begin.

Descartes complicates the figure. In the *Second Meditation* a piece of wax fresh from the honeycomb is brought near the fire: its taste, scent, colour, shape, and hardness all change, yet it remains the same wax, known not by the senses but by the intellect alone. The innie and the outie are Descartes's wax before and after the fire: every sensible property of the person (manner, belief, loyalty, love) altered, the organism the same. The question is whether there is anything the intellect can grasp as "the same" beyond the organism, and the series suggests that only the law and the payroll can.

The decisive modern text is Freud's "A Note upon the 'Mystic Writing-Pad'" (1925). The *Wunderblock*, a child's toy, consists of a wax slab covered by a sheet of celluloid and waxed paper; writing appears where the stylus presses the paper against the wax, and lifting the covering sheet erases the surface, while the wax retains permanent traces legible under the right light. Freud took it as a model of the psychical apparatus: a perceptual surface perpetually receptive because perpetually cleared, above a mnemic substrate that keeps everything. The severance chip is a Mystic Writing-Pad installed at the threshold of a building. Each crossing lifts the sheet. And the series'

narrative of reintegration presupposes, as Freud's model does, that nothing was ever erased: the traces persist below, which is why they can return.

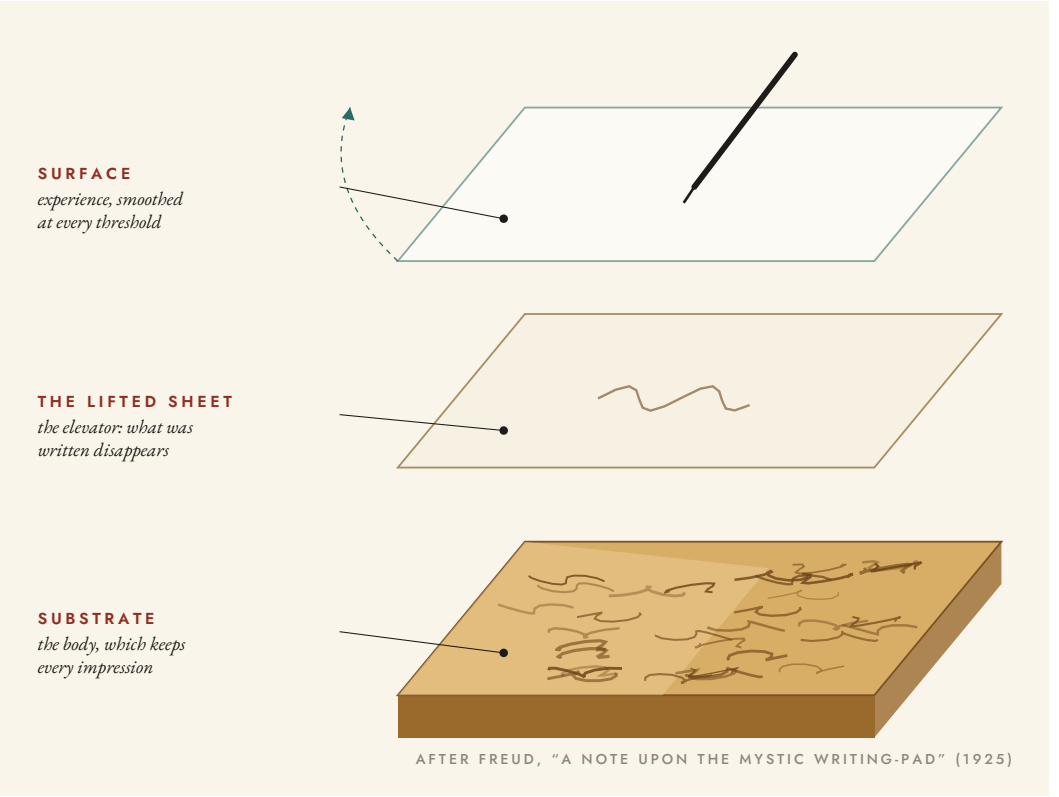


FIGURE 4 *The ceroplastic subject. The surface of experience is smoothed at every threshold while the substrate keeps every impression, as in Freud's Mystic Writing-Pad.*

The Perpetuity Wing completes the figure with uncanny literalism. Its effigies of the Eagan line, wax and animatronic simulacra of dead executives preserved in perpetual pose, are the institution's image of what the self should become: a surface fixed forever, impressed once by the founder's seal. Lumon makes workers into erasable surfaces and its rulers into permanent impressions.

I therefore propose that the subject of *Severance* is best described as a **ceroplastic subject**, from *cera* (wax) and *plassein* (to mould): a subject whose experiential surface is periodically smoothed while its substrate retains every impression, and whose form is impressed from outside by an institution that reserves to itself both the stylus and the power to lift the sheet. The ceroplastic subject differs from the Lockean tabula rasa in that nothing on it is ever truly blank, and from the Freudian psychical apparatus in that the lifting of the sheet is not a function of the psyche but a service rendered by an employer. A Buddhist analogue sharpens the point. In the Yogācāra philosophy associated with Vasubandhu, a *storehouse consciousness* (*ālayavijñāna*) pre-

serves the seeds (*bīja*) of all past actions and impressions beneath the manifest modes of awareness, which may change while the seeds persist. Severance partitions the manifest consciousness while leaving the storehouse undivided; reintegration is the germination of seeds sown on the other side of the threshold.

§ 2.6

Bleed: The Return of the Partitioned

If the substrate retains everything, the partition must leak, and the series' most haunting images are images of leakage. Irving's outie paints, obsessively and in darkness, a corridor he has never consciously seen: the passage on the severed floor that his innie knows. The outie's art is an involuntary memory in Proust's sense, not summoned by will but released by the body. The overture of *Swann's Way* (1913) describes a sleeper waking in the dark who does not at first know where or even who he is, until the memory of his limbs, recalling the rooms in which they have lain, restores his place in the world. Proust locates the first memory in the body, below the self; so does *Severance*. Innies weep without knowing why and feel unaccountable affinities and aversions, and Lumon tests the leak deliberately. In "The You You Are," Ms. Casey lights, during Mark's wellness session, a candle that Cobel has taken from the box of his wife's belongings in his basement: Proust's madeleine administered as an experiment (Wikipedia). In "What's for Dinner?" Cobel arranges a final session between Mark and Ms. Casey in the hope that husband and wife will recognize each other, and they do not (Wikipedia). Recognition fails where feeling does not. Ms. Casey tells Mark that the eight hours she spent in his department were her favourite time, because they were the longest she had ever been awake.

Maurice Merleau-Ponty's *Phenomenology of Perception* (1945) supplies the theory. The body is not an object of consciousness but its vehicle, and habit is a sedimentation of past action in the body's own power to act; the body "remembers" in its readiness, its orientation, its preferences, without representing the past. The chip partitions representation, not sedimentation. What leaks is therefore not information but orientation: a tilt of the body toward a corridor, a face, a song. Sydney Shoemaker's notion of *quasi-memory*, an apparent memory of an experience that may have been someone else's (Shoemaker 1970), names the epistemic status of these leaks precisely. Irving's paintings are quasi-memories: authentic traces of experience, but of experience belonging, by the series' Lockean law, to another person. Freud's "The Uncanny" (1919) explains their affect. The uncanny is the familiar returning in estranged form, and the double, as Otto Rank had shown (Rank 1914), is its paradigmatic vehicle. For the outie, the innie *is* the uncanny: the self that has been made strange and returns through the walls.

§ 2.7

Reintegration and Destructive Plasticity

Catherine Malabou's philosophy of neuroplasticity supplies the final frame. In *What Should We Do with Our Brain?* (2004) Malabou distinguishes *plasticity*, the capacity both to receive form and to give it, and also to explode it, from mere *flexibility*, the capacity to receive form passively, which is the capitalist ideal of the adaptable worker. Her guiding question is how to prevent the consciousness of the brain's plasticity from simply coinciding with the spirit of capitalism. In *The New Wounded* (2007) and *Ontology of the Accident* (2009) she develops the concept of *destructive plasticity*: the formation, through brain injury, trauma, or disease, of a new identity that is not a diminished version of the old one but a stranger, without continuity, born of the wound.

Severance is destructive plasticity made elective, standardized, and contractual. The innie is Malabou's new wounded, but the wound is purchased by the person it replaces and installed by the employer it serves. Malabou's question is answered in the negative: in Lumon's world the consciousness of the brain coincides exactly with the spirit of capitalism, because the brain's capacity to produce a new self has been converted into the firm's capacity to produce a new worker.

The narrative of reintegration in both seasons tests whether plasticity can be reclaimed. Petey Kilmer, reintegrated by the former Lumon scientist Reghabi, suffers a cascading collapse of the partition, hallucinatory confusion of his two lives, and death. Mark Scout's reintegration in the second season produces seizures and floods of returning experience that he can neither order nor master. Reintegration is not represented as healing but as a second accident: another destructive plasticity, this time producing a third self from the collision of two. The series thereby refuses the therapeutic fantasy of restoration that the dissociative literature had long entertained and that Calvino satirized when his cloven viscount, sewn back together, proves to be neither saint nor monster but merely a man (Calvino 1952).

The history of psychosurgery underscores the stakes. Egas Moniz received the Nobel Prize in 1949 for prefrontal leucotomy. Walter Freeman, who with the neurosurgeon James Watts performed the 1941 lobotomy that left Rosemary Kennedy permanently incapacitated, went on to popularize transorbital lobotomy in the United States, performing thousands of operations and promoting the return of operated patients to productive, if diminished, lives. In Montreal in the 1950s and early 1960s, the psychiatrist Ewen Cameron conducted "depatterning" experiments at McGill University's Allan Memorial Institute on psychiatric patients, many of them admitted for anxiety or depression, who had not consented to experimentation; the CIA funded part of the work as MKUltra Subproject 68. Cameron sought to erase his patients' existing patterns of memory and behaviour through intensive electroconvulsive treatment and weeks of drug-induced sleep, and then to rebuild them by playing recorded messages to them over and over (Marks 1979). Naomi Klein made Cameron the founding metaphor of *The Shock Doctrine* (2007): the dream of the clean slate on which a new order might be written. Lumon is the cor-

porate heir of this history, with one innovation that its predecessors lacked: it does not need to destroy the old self to make the new one. It keeps both, each on its own side of a door, and invoices accordingly.

The conclusion of Part One can now be stated. Severance produces two complete persons in one organism, partitioned by place, sharing temperament and skill but not autobiography, and leaking into each other through the body. One of these persons owns the organism in law; the other operates it at work. What follows from this arrangement is not a puzzle in metaphysics but a relation of production.



PART TWO

The Political Economy of Forgetting

3 *Estranged Labour Literalized*

4 *Discipline, Control, and the Management of Feeling*



3

CHAPTER THREE

Estranged Labour Literalized

Lockean Arbitrage, Mnemonic Enclosure, and Necrergy

Severance renders the Marxian theory of estrangement literal at the level of the nervous system, and in doing so it discloses a form of exploitation that Marx's categories anticipate but cannot fully name: the extraction of value from the non-coincidence between the body that is owned and the self that works. This chapter reconstructs the series' political economy in five movements: the threshold of production, the four estrangements, the real abstraction of the labourer, the arbitrage made possible by Locke's two concepts of the person, and the enclosure of memory as the condition of a new form of labour that I call necrergy. It concludes with a formal definition of the Lethean mode of production.

§ 3.1

The Hidden Abode and Its Threshold

At the close of the sixth chapter of *Capital*, volume I (1867), Marx takes leave of the sphere of circulation, "a very Eden of the innate rights of man," where the buyer and the seller of labour-power meet as free and equal contractors under the sign of "Freedom, Equality, Property and Bentham." He invites the reader to follow them into "the hidden abode of production, on whose threshold there stares us in the face 'No admittance except on business.'" At that threshold, he observes, the physiognomy of the dramatis personae changes. The money-owner strides ahead as capitalist, "smirking, intent on business"; the possessor of labour-power follows, "timid and holding back, like one who is bringing his own hide to market and has nothing to expect but—a hiding."

Lumon's elevator is Marx's threshold rendered as architecture, and the change of physiognomy is no longer a figure of speech but an acting assignment. Adam Scott's two Marks (the outie stooped by grief, the innie buoyant and almost boyish), Britt Lower's Helly and Helena, and the doubled performances of John Turturro and Zach Cherry amount to a sustained demonstration that one body can bear two physiognomies. The second season raises the demonstration to a higher power when Helena impersonates her own innie: an actor playing a character playing her own worker-self.

More consequential than the transformation, however, is its distribution. Marx's worker crosses the threshold daily in both directions. He is a free contractor at the factory gate and a subordinate within it, and his daily passage between these conditions sustains the juridical fiction that the subordination is freely chosen. Severance splits the worker along exactly this line. The outie is a pure citizen of circulation: he signs, consents, is paid, and never once enters the abode. The innie is a pure subject of production: it never sees the market, never signs, never draws a wage, and has no existence outside the abode. Severance does not abolish the double life of the worker that Marx anatomized; it assigns each half to a different person.

The consequences for the theory of the wage contract are immediate. The formal equality of exchange between capitalist and worker, which Marx treats as real at the level of circulation and illusory at the level of production, here collapses even at the level of circulation, because the party who performs the labour is not the party who sold the capacity to perform it. A third party has entered the relation: a person who is neither buyer nor seller but the living content of the commodity. The innie is, in the most literal sense, the hide that the outie brings to market.

§ 3.2

The Four Estrangements Reconsidered

The *Economic and Philosophic Manuscripts of 1844* identify four dimensions of estranged labour (*entfremdete Arbeit*): the worker's estrangement from the product of labour, from the activity of labour, from species-being (*Gattungswesen*), and from other human beings. Each is literalized on the severed floor, and in each case the literalization is an intensification that exposes something the original concept concealed.

Estrangement from the product. For Marx, the object produced by labour confronts its producer as an alien power, and the more the worker expends himself, the more powerful grows the alien world of objects he creates over against himself. The refiners of Macrodata Refinement do not know what they produce. They sort clusters of numbers whose meaning is withheld, guided only by the feelings the numbers provoke. The second season discloses that the files they refine correspond to the rooms of a testing floor on which Mark's wife, Gemma Scout, presumed dead, is held captive and serially severed. The finale confirms that "Cold Harbor" is the twenty-fifth file Mark has refined, that each earlier file corresponded to a new consciousness split from Gemma, and that its completion triggers her final test, which Harmony Cobel warns will mean

her death (Slashfilm; Today). Marx's alien power is thus given a face and a hostage. Mark's labour, at its most diligent, builds the prison of the person he loves, and the more he refines, the stronger becomes the apparatus that holds her. No fiction has more exactly dramatized the proposition that the worker produces the power that dominates him.

Estrangement from activity. The worker, Marx writes, is "at home when he is not working," and when working is not at home; his labour satisfies no need of its own but serves as a means to satisfy needs external to it. Severance converts this phenomenology into architecture. The outie is never at work and the innie is never at home. The outie's feeling of not being present in his work becomes the physiological fact of not being present at all, and the innie's alienation is total, because it has no home in relation to which work could be experienced as exile. Marx's worker feels freely active only in his animal functions (eating, drinking, procreating); the innie eats, drinks, and desires only on the employer's premises, and its animal functions are themselves administered as perks.

Estrangement from species-being. Marx locates the species-character of humanity in free, conscious life-activity, the capacity to make one's own activity the object of will and consciousness. Estranged labour inverts the relation and makes life-activity a mere means of existence. The innie's entire existence is life-activity reduced to a means. It has no leisure that is not a reward, no project that is not assigned, and no future that is not a quarter. Arendt's distinction in *The Human Condition* (1958) among *labour* (the cyclical activity of the *animal laborans*, bound to necessity and leaving nothing durable behind), *work* (the fabrication of a durable world by *homo faber*), and *action* (the disclosure of the agent among a plurality of equals) clarifies what is at stake. Refinement is labour in Arendt's sense, consumed in the act of its performance, and the innie never sees the world its work fabricates. Its rebellion, when it comes, will be action, the one Arendtian category that Lumon cannot administer, because action begins something new. Chapter 9 returns to this point.

Estrangement of human from human. Marx's fourth estrangement follows from the others: each worker regards others according to the standard of the relation in which he finds himself as a worker. Lumon fragments the collective labourer (Marx's *Gesamtarbeiter*) by design. Departments are sequestered and furnished with legends about one another, so that Macrodata Refinement regards Optics and Design with suspicion, and neither knows of Mammalians Nurturable. Management cultivates estrangement as a technique of rule, and the series' first act of solidarity, the love between Irving of MDR and Burt of O&D, is accordingly a transgression of departmental borders. The deepest estrangement, however, is one that Marx could not have imagined: the estrangement of the worker from himself as another worker. Innie and outie first regard each other as strangers, rivals, or masters, and the reconstitution of a relation between them, through videotape and negotiation, is the series' most original contribution to the theory of solidarity.

§ 3.3

The Real Abstraction of the Labourer

The first chapter of *Capital* argues that commodities, as values, are congealed quantities of homogeneous, abstract human labour, stripped of every concrete determination. Marx insists that this abstraction is performed not by the theorist but by society, every day, in the exchange of commodities. Alfred Sohn-Rethel generalized the point as *real abstraction* (*Realabstraktion*): an abstraction enacted in practice before it is conceptualized, of which the exchange abstraction is the paradigm (Sohn-Rethel 1970). Severance is a real abstraction of the labourer. What political economy abstracts in thought, and exchange abstracts in practice, the chip abstracts in tissue. The concrete person (biography, family, history, grievance) is surgically separated from the labouring capacity, and what descends in the elevator is abstract labour incarnate: a capacity to work, furnished with language, skill, and a residue of temperament, but without the particularity of a life.

Lukács's account of reification sharpens the analysis. Under rationalized production, he argues, time loses its qualitative, flowing character and freezes into a measurable continuum filled with quantifiable things; it becomes, in his phrase, "space" (Lukács 1923). Bergson had diagnosed the same operation in the intellect's habit of representing duration as a line (Bergson 1889). The severed floor executes the Lukácsian reduction literally. The working day, a temporal division, becomes a floor, a spatial one, and the elevator converts duration into storeys. Marx had written in *The Poverty of Philosophy* (1847) that under the regime of labour time "time is everything, man is nothing; he is, at the most, time's carcase." The innie is the carcase of eight hours, animated.

The spatialization of the working day transforms the class struggle over its length. Marx described the establishment of a normal working day as the outcome of a "protracted civil war" between the capitalist class and the working class, fought by those who experienced the day's length in fatigue and lost life. Under severance the struggle loses its subject. The outie, who alone possesses standing, experiences no working day at all: eight hours or sixteen arrive identically as a blink. The innie, who experiences the whole of it, possesses no standing to contest it. Worse, the innie experiences its working days as continuous. It enters the elevator in the evening and emerges, in what is subjectively the next instant, into the following morning; it has no night between its working days, no rest, and no weekend. From its own standpoint, life consists of uninterrupted labour, punctuated by elevator rides. Capital's tendency to reduce the worker's life to working time, documented by Marx in the struggles over night work and the relay system, is here completed from within: for one of the two persons involved, life and working time are coextensive.

Taylor's *Principles of Scientific Management* (1911) supplies the managerial complement. "In the past the man has been first; in the future the system must be first," Taylor wrote, and his notorious portrait of the ideal pig-iron handler, a man "so stupid and so phlegmatic that he more nearly resembles in his mental make-up the ox than any other type," exposed the anthropology

on which the system relied. Harry Braverman identified the core of Taylorism as the separation of conception from execution, the transfer of knowledge about the labour process from the worker to management (Braverman 1974). Severance perfects this separation. Conception, the knowledge of what the work is for, is reserved to a Board whose members never appear; execution is performed by persons who cannot know. The innie is not deskilled but *de-purposed*: it retains its skills and loses only the knowledge of their end.

Graeber's account of "bullshit jobs," forms of employment so pointless that their holders cannot justify their existence (Graeber 2018), here meets its dialectical inversion. From within, refinement appears to be the purest bullshit job imaginable; from without, it is revealed as the most consequential labour in the corporation. Its apparent pointlessness is not a symptom of bureaucratic bloat but a security measure. The work seems meaningless so that its meaning may remain secret.

§ 3.4

Lockean Arbitrage

The legal and philosophical precondition of severance as a business lies in an incoherence internal to Locke, and the series' mechanism of extraction can be described with some formal precision. In the *Second Treatise of Government* (1689), Locke grounds property in the person: "every man has a property in his own person," and "the labour of his body, and the work of his hands, we may say, are properly his" (§27). In the following section he adds, without apparent unease, that "the grass my horse has bit; the turfs my servant has cut; and the ore I have digged" become my property "without the assignation or consent of any body" (§28). C. B. Macpherson made the servant's turf a cornerstone of his critique of *possessive individualism*. Locke's individual is essentially the proprietor of his own person and capacities, owing nothing to society for them, and his labour is an alienable commodity, so that the servant's labour becomes, as a matter of course, the master's property (Macpherson 1962).

The *Essay*, as Chapter 1 showed, defines the person differently: not by the body and its labour but by consciousness, and it bounds concern by consciousness. Locke's two texts therefore contain two concepts of the person. The *proprietary* person owns the labour of a body; the *conscious* person experiences, and is concerned for, whatever its consciousness appropriates. In ordinary life the two coincide. The severance chip separates them, and Lumon allocates the attributes of personhood across the resulting gap according to whichever criterion yields the more profitable result.

TABLE 1 *Lockean arbitrage*

ATTRIBUTE	LOCKEAN CRITERION INVOKED	ASSIGNED TO	EFFECT
Wages and title to the product	Property in the labour of one's body (*Second Treatise* §27)	Outie, as owner of the organism	Income without experienced labour
Experience of the working day	Consciousness as the boundary of the person (*Essay* II.xxvii.9)	Innie	Labour without income
Concern and welfare	Concern extends only as far as consciousness (*Essay* II.xxvii.17)	Each self, for its own experiences only	No self-regarding reason for the outie to care what the innie suffers
Consent to the arrangement	Contract by the proprietor of the person	Outie alone, before the innie exists	A party bound who never agreed
Responsibility for acts at work	Forensic personhood (*Essay* II.xxvii.26)	Neither, as with Locke's drunkard (§22)	An accountability vacuum, with the firm outside both
Termination	The owner's right to dispose of property	Outie, by resignation	The innie's existence revocable by another

I call this allocation **Lockean arbitrage**: the extraction of value from the spread between the proprietary and the conscious person. The term is meant precisely. An arbitrageur profits from a price differential between two markets for the same asset; Lumon profits from a differential between two juridical valuations of the same organism. Under the proprietary criterion, the organism's labour belongs to the outie and may be sold. Under the conscious criterion, the organism's experience belongs to the innie and need not be compensated. The wage is paid where no labour is experienced, and labour is experienced where no wage is paid. Locke's servant, whose turfs belong to his master, returns; but master and servant now share one body, and the servant has no other life to which he might return at the end of the day.

Marx's notation for the circuit of industrial capital (*Capital*, vol. II, 1885) permits the arbitrage to be stated compactly. Money (M) buys commodities (C) in the form of labour-power (Lp) and means of production (Mp); production (P) yields a commodity of greater value (C′), realized as augmented money (M′). Under severance, the labour-power purchased and the labour performed belong to different persons.

$$M - C\{L_p^{\text{outie}}, M_p\} \cdots P[L^{\text{innie}}] \cdots C' - M'$$

$$\text{labour}_{\text{outie}} = 0, \qquad \text{wage}_{\text{outie}} = w$$

$$\text{wage}_{\text{innie}} = 0 \implies \text{surplus labour}_{\text{innie}} = \text{total labour}_{\text{innie}}$$

Marx's rate of surplus value divides surplus labour by necessary labour, the portion of the working day in which the worker reproduces the value of his own wage. The innie receives no wage and therefore performs no necessary labour; from its own standpoint, every minute it works is surplus labour, appropriated by others. The outie, conversely, receives the wage and performs no labour at all. Exploitation has not been abolished by the division of the person but distributed across it, so that each half bears one of its two moments in pure form.

§ 3.5

The Outie as Rentier

The classical economists distinguished wages, the return to labour, from rent, the return to the ownership of a factor that the owner does not himself work. Ricardo defined rent as payment for the use of "the original and indestructible powers of the soil" (Ricardo 1817). Mill observed that landlords "grow richer, as it were in their sleep, without working, risking, or economizing" (Mill 1848, V.ii.5). Keynes anticipated the "euthanasia of the rentier" (Keynes 1936, ch. 24), and Piketty has shown that when the return on capital exceeds the rate of growth, inherited wealth tends to dominate earned income (Piketty 2013). The outie is a rentier of his own organism. He leases its original powers (skill, temperament, the capacity to work) to Lumon and draws an income on the lease. He grows richer, not in his sleep but in the blink of the elevator, without working, risking, or economizing; the risks of the working day are borne by someone else.

The outie's rent is paid in two currencies, money and oblivion, and for several of the series' outies the second is the more valuable. Mark, a history professor undone by his wife's apparent death, severs himself to obtain eight hours a day without grief; his rent is anaesthesia. Dylan's outie, a father with a family to support, draws the more conventional rent of wages. Irving's outie, a veteran whose apartment holds a dossier on Lumon's severed employees, appears to use severance as an instrument of investigation, leasing his body to the institution he is investigating. Helena Eagan severs herself as a public demonstration of the procedure, an offering made on behalf of the family firm; her rent is dynastic legitimacy. At the limit stands Gemma Scout, who consents to nothing. Kidnapped, declared dead, and serially severed, she is not a rentier at all but expropriated ground, a soil whose powers are mined without a lease.

Helena's case is the purest. As an Eagan and heir to Lumon's ownership, she is capital; as Helly R., she is labour. In her organism the class relation is not an analogy but a literal description of two persons, one of whom owns the means of production while the other works them, and it is no accident that her innie becomes the most intransigent rebel on the floor. When Helena tells Helly that she, Helena, is a person and Helly is not, the sentence is the founding declaration of a class society contained within a single skull. She says it in a recorded reply, in "The You You Are," to Helly's threat to cut off her own fingers unless she is allowed to resign. In the same reply Helena refuses the resignation and warns that if Helly ever harms "my fingers," she will keep her alive long enough to regret it (Severance Wiki; TV Obsessive). The possessive is

Lockean arbitrage in two words: the fingers belong to the proprietor, the pain to the person who would feel it, and the threat of prolonged suffering is addressed by the owner of a body to the person who lives in it. The second-season finale carries the same structure into the series' central relationship. Its opening negotiation between Mark's two selves, conducted by camcorder in the severed birthing cabin first seen in the previous season, is a bargain between classes over the terms of a shared body. The outie needs the innie's labour to rescue his wife; the innie needs its existence guaranteed against the outie's plan to reintegrate. The bargain ends not in expropriation but in secession: the innie keeps the body by staying inside.

§ 3.6

Social Reproduction and the Colonized Night

Feminist political economy has shown that capital depends on unwaged labour it does not count: the domestic, sexual, and caring work that reproduces labour-power daily and generationally (Federici 1975; 2004; Bhattacharya 2017). Nancy Fraser generalizes the point as a theory of *cannibal capitalism*, a social order that devours the non-economic conditions of its own existence, from care to nature to political capacity (Fraser 2022). Severance reorganizes social reproduction with uncanny literalism. The outie's entire life becomes the reproductive sphere of the innie's labour. He feeds, rests, clothes, and heals the body that the innie will use, and his marriage, friendships, and sleep restore the organism that the innie spends. Yet the innie never enters this sphere. It never sits at its outie's table, never sleeps in a bed, and never meets the people who sustain its body. Conversely, the innie's unwaged labour finances the outie's household. Production and reproduction, which industrial capitalism separated into factory and home, have here been separated into two persons, each the other's infrastructure. Fraser's cannibalism becomes autophagy: the self consuming itself.

Jonathan Crary has argued that sleep is the last uncolonized refuge of human life under a 24/7 capitalism that seeks to abolish every interval in which nothing is produced or consumed (Crary 2013). The innie is the first worker without a night. Its existence contains no interval of sleep between working days, because the evening's elevator ride passes directly into the following morning. When Irving dozes at his desk in the first season, the penalty is a loss of pay, which falls on his outie, rather than a visit to the Break Room (Severance Wiki); and when the innies at last spend a night in the open, at the Woe's Hollow retreat, sleep arrives as a managed exception, from which Irving wakes out of a nightmare of the temper Woe to unmask Helena (Nerdist). Lumon also possesses an instrument for extending its reach into the outie's night: the *overtime contingency*, a protocol that activates the innie outside the building. In the first season, Milchick uses it to wake Dylan's innie in his outie's home in order to question him about a card he had taken from Optics and Design, and the innie, surfacing in someone else's house, meets a child he did not know he had (Bustle). Back on the floor, forbidden to learn anything more about his son, Dylan attacks Milchick (Wikipedia): natal alienation, in Patterson's sense, provoking an innie's

assault on management. The overtime contingency is the colonization of the night made into a switch. The first-season finale, in which the innies seize that switch to wake themselves in their outies' world, is accordingly a reappropriation of the night. Locke's Night-Man becomes, for one evening, master of the day.

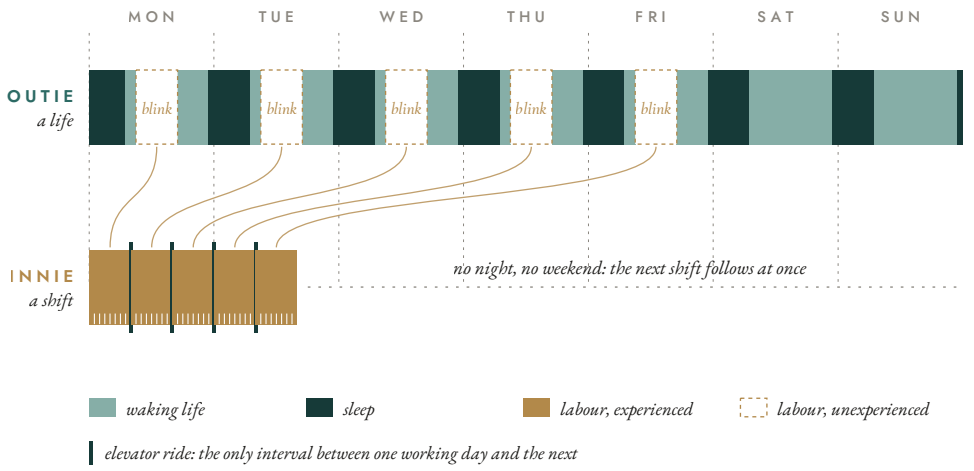


FIGURE 5 *Two calendars of one life. The outie lives the week with the working hours removed; the innie lives only those hours, end to end, with no night between them.*

§ 3.7

Mnemonic Enclosure

Marx placed at the origin of capitalism a process of "so-called primitive accumulation," the expropriation of the agricultural population through the enclosure of common land, a history "written in the annals of mankind in letters of blood and fire" (*Capital*, vol. I, ch. 26). E. P. Thompson traced a parallel enclosure of time: the transition from task-oriented work, governed by the rhythms of the job, to timed labour governed by the clock, the bell, and the fine, a transformation that reshaped the inward sense of time itself (Thompson 1967). The factory clock enclosed the working day, but it did not enclose the worker's memory of the day. The worker went home remembering the foreman's cruelty, a comrade's injury, the speed-up, the wage cut. Memory remained a commons in which grievances were stored, compared, and shared, and from which the solidarity of the labour movement was drawn.

I call the operation performed by severance **mnemonic enclosure**: the fencing-off of the self's temporal commons, its unity with its own past and future, so that the experience of work no longer belongs to the person who returns home. It is the final enclosure, the one capital could

not perform until neurotechnology made it possible. Walter Benjamin's distinction between *Erfahrung*, experience accumulated, transmitted, and woven into a life and a tradition, and *Erlebnis*, the isolated, shock-like event parried by consciousness and never integrated (Benjamin 1936; 1939), names what is enclosed. The innie lives *Erlebnisse* without *Erfahrung*: it has days but no tradition, events but no inheritance. Benjamin observed that the worker at the machine, like the gambler at the table, begins each operation anew, every movement cut off from the one before. The innie begins anew in a deeper sense. Not only is each operation cut off from its predecessor; the worker is cut off from its outie, and the outie from the day.

The series locates the origin of this enclosure in an older one. The second season's eighth episode, "Sweet Vitriol," follows Harmony Cobel to Salt's Neck, a company town decaying since Lumon abandoned its ether factory, where Kier Eagan is said to have met his wife and whose remaining residents are addicted to the company's former product (Wikipedia). Cobel and her companion Hampton worked there as children, manning the vats on ten-hour shifts (Nerdist). Patricia Arquette has described the history the writers built for her character: a mother who became addicted to the factory's ether, many people lost along the way, and a town the company had environmentally poisoned (TV Insider). The episode then reveals that Cobel's girlhood notebook proves she invented the severance procedure, for which Lumon credited its chief executive, Jame Eagan. The Eagans took the invention as a commons is taken and absorbed its inventor as a functionary into the firm. Primitive accumulation, child labour, environmental poisoning, and the appropriation of intellectual property are thus compressed into a single town, which stands to the severed floor as the enclosed village stands to the factory in Marx's account.

The setting carries a further significance. *Sweet vitriol* is the archaic name for diethyl ether, the agent of the recreational "ether frolics" of the nineteenth century and of the first public demonstration of surgical anaesthesia, in Boston in 1846. Lumon's industrial genealogy therefore runs from the anaesthesia of the body to the anaesthesia of memory: its oldest product numbed pain, and its newest numbs the past. In the finale, the executive Drummond characterizes the founder's project as an "eternal war against pain," the most candid self-description the company ever offers. The fourfold of tempers that governs Macrodata Refinement includes *Frolic*, and it is difficult not to hear in the word an echo of the ether parties on which the company's fortune was built.

§ 3.8

Necrergy: The Labour of Shades

Marx's most famous figure for capital is the vampire: capital is "dead labour, that, vampire-like, only lives by sucking living labour, and lives the more, the more labour it sucks" (*Capital*, vol. I, ch. 10). The figure describes the domination of the living by the dead, of present labour by past labour accumulated as capital. Severance requires an inverse figure: not dead labour feeding on

the living, but living labour performed by a self that its beneficiary regards as nonexistent. I call this **necrergy** (from *nekros*, corpse or shade, and *ergon*, work): the work of shades.

The folkloric archetype of necrergy is the Haitian *zonbi*, a body raised from the grave by a sorcerer to labour without will, a figure whose terror, scholars of Haitian religion have argued, condenses the memory of plantation slavery and the fear of its return after death (Davis 1985; Dayan 1995). The plantations the figure remembers were built by French colonists on the forced labour of enslaved Africans, until the revolution of 1791–1804 abolished slavery and founded Haiti. The figure entered American popular culture under a second occupation. William Seabrook's *The Magic Island* (1929) reported zombies labouring in the cane fields of the Haitian-American Sugar Company, an American enterprise, and Seabrook wrote during the United States' military occupation of Haiti (1915–1934), in the course of which the Marines revived the corvée, compelling Haitian peasants to build roads under armed guard, a policy that helped provoke the armed resistance led by Charlemagne Péralte (Schmidt 1971; Renda 2001). Victor Halperin's *White Zombie* (1932), the first feature-length zombie film, set its undead workers turning the wheels of a sugar mill. The American zombie was born, in other words, in an occupied country whose occupiers had reinstated forced labour. The innie is a zombie in reverse: not a dead body animated without a mind, but a living mind in a living body, deemed by its proprietor not to count. The ontology of necrergy is perspectival. To its performer the labour is the whole of a life; to its beneficiary it is the labour of no one.

Orlando Patterson's comparative analysis of slavery as *social death*, drawn from sixty-six slaveholding societies, identifies three constitutive features: total domination, general dishonour, and *natal alienation*, the severance of the enslaved person from all ties of birth, from ancestors and descendants alike, so that he has no socially recognized genealogy (Patterson 1982). In the slave societies of the Americas, natal alienation was not a by-product but a policy, written into law by slaveholding legislatures. In 1662 Virginia's General Assembly enacted that a child's condition should follow the mother's (*partus sequitur ventrem*), so that slavery passed through the mother, and children fathered by free white men with enslaved women, very often through rape, were born enslaved. Enslavers renamed the people they bought and sold families apart, and South Carolina's Negro Act of 1740 penalized anyone who taught an enslaved person to write: the historical original of the police of writing examined in Chapter 4. Frederick Douglass, who escaped slavery in Maryland, recorded that most enslaved people knew as little of their ages as horses know of theirs, and that it was "the wish of most masters within my knowledge to keep their slaves thus ignorant" (Douglass 1845). That is a mnemonic enclosure imposed by owners on the owned. Natal alienation describes the innie's condition with precision. The innie has no parents, since its outie's mother is not its mother, and no children, since Dylan's innie meets a son who is not, by Lumon's law, his. Its surname is reduced to an initial (Mark S., Helly R., Irving B., Dylan G.), and its only ancestor is Kier. The analogy is structural, and its limits are part of its precision. Racial slavery in the Americas was imposed by force on captured Africans and their descendants, sustained for centuries by torture, rape, and the sale of children away from their parents, and protected by law; the fiction's severed workers are, for the most part, salaried professionals who chose

the procedure. What severance reproduces is not that history but its structure: the manufacture of a person stripped of genealogy, honour, and standing, whose labour belongs to another. The second season places race inside the apparatus rather than leaving it outside as metaphor, through the Board's treatment of Seth Milchick, the Black manager who administers the floor, discussed in the next chapter.

Two figures in the series complete the theory. The first is the innie's *retirement*. When Burt's outie retires in the first season, Burt's innie takes leave of Irving and walks toward nonexistence; the event that crowns a working life in ordinary employment is, for him, extinction. The second figure is Gemma. Declared dead to the world in a staged accident, she labours on the testing floor in a succession of task-specific selves, none of whom exists in law, and her death certificate is the precondition of her labour. Gemma is necrergy in its pure form: work performed by a woman the world has buried.

§ 3.9

The Lethean Mode of Production Defined

The analysis permits a definition. A mode of production is Lethean when it satisfies five conditions.

1. **Production of the producer.** The labourer is not hired but manufactured by the employer as a distinct person, whose existence begins and ends with the employment.
2. **Disjunction of contract and labour.** The person who contracts never labours, and the person who labours never contracts.
3. **Arbitrage.** Value is extracted from the spread between the proprietary person, who owns the labour of the body, and the conscious person, who experiences it.
4. **Mnemonic enclosure.** The experience of work is fenced off from the life of the person who returns home, so that memory ceases to function as a commons of grievance and solidarity.
5. **Necrergy.** The labourer is nonexistent from the standpoint of the beneficiary, and its labour is accordingly the work of no one.

Each condition has antecedents. The factory manufactured new kinds of workers; contract labour separated the signatory from the site; Lockean property grounded the master's title in the servant's turf; the clock enclosed time; slavery produced social death. What is new is their conjunction in a single procedure, performed on a single organism and secured by a single threshold. The conjunction yields a worker on whom none of the ordinary instruments of capitalist discipline can act. The innie has no wage to raise or cut, no household to provision, no career to

advance, no reputation to protect outside the firm, and no remembered past against which to measure its present. Interest, the master motive of the economic subject since Mandeville's bees and Smith's butcher, has been surgically voided. The next chapter examines the instruments Lumon deploys in its place.



4

CHAPTER FOUR

Discipline, Control, and the Management of Feeling

Lumon governs its innies through a layered apparatus of enclosure, code, pastoral care, confession, gift, and affective classification, and the specificity of the severed floor is that every one of these techniques must operate on a subject without a past. Severance removes the three temporal horizons through which ordinary workers are governed: the remembered injury that makes discipline intelligible, the anticipated reward that makes incentive effective, and the imagined career that makes ambition possible. The apparatus must therefore manufacture a substitute for each of what Heidegger called the ecstases of temporality: a synthetic past in the Perpetuity Wing, a synthetic future in the quarterly incentive, and a synthetic present, an interiority already sorted into categories, in the doctrine of the Four Tempers. This chapter examines the apparatus layer by layer and concludes that none of its layers suffices without the liturgy examined in Chapter 5.

§ 4.1

The Severed Floor as Heterotopia

In the 1967 lecture "Of Other Spaces," Foucault described *heterotopias* as real places that function as counter-sites, in which the other sites of a culture are at once represented, contested, and inverted, and he proposed six principles for their study. The severed floor satisfies each with diagrammatic clarity. First, it is a heterotopia of deviation, a place for those whose condition the outside world cannot accommodate, like the clinic, the prison, or the retirement home. Second, its function can change, as the second season shows by converting it from a workplace into a

theatre of insurrection. Third, it juxtaposes in a single site several spaces that are in themselves incompatible: an office, a museum, a shrine, a goat pasture, a clinic, and a cell block. Fourth, it is a *heterochrony*: the Perpetuity Wing accumulates time indefinitely, as museums and libraries do, while the innie lives in an absolute present, like the fairground. Fifth, it has a system of opening and closing, entered by a rite (the elevator descent) and guarded by purifications (the code detectors that scan departing workers for writing). Sixth, it functions in relation to the remaining space as a heterotopia of *compensation*: a space as meticulous, ordered, and complete as the outside world is messy, grieving, and incomplete.

The series' architecture gives this heterotopia a genealogy. Its exterior is Eero Saarinen's Bell Labs Holmdel Complex (1962), a mirrored-glass box in which the mid-century research corporation housed its cathedral of rational innovation, an exemplary monument of what Reinhold Martin has called "the organizational complex," the post-war fusion of architecture, media, and corporate management (Martin 2003). Its interior is an apparently endless white labyrinth of windowless corridors, lengthened by Stiller's tracking shots into a space without landmarks, descended from the glass-and-steel mazes of Jacques Tati's *Playtime* (1967) and the patterned hallways of Kubrick's *The Shining* (1980). At its centre sits the MDR desk, a cruciform island of four workstations in a vast and otherwise empty carpeted room. The desk parodies two utopias of office design: the *Bürolandschaft*, or office landscape, devised by the Quickborner Team in late-1950s Germany as an organic, communicative alternative to the grid; and Robert Propst's Action Office (1964), designed for Herman Miller to liberate the office worker and degraded into the cubicle farm its inventor later disowned. MDR is an office landscape without a landscape, and the deficit is made good by the pastoral painting in the Wellness room: landscape as image, for a worker who will never see a field.

An earlier precedent is closer still. Frank Lloyd Wright's Larkin Administration Building (Buffalo, 1906), headquarters of a mail-order soap company, inscribed its central light court with fourteen triads of corporate virtue, among them "Co-operation, Economy, Industry," "Generosity, Altruism, Sacrifice," and "Integrity, Loyalty, Fidelity," and set them beside inscriptions from the Sermon on the Mount (Stanger 2000), so that clerks worked beneath a liturgy carved in stone in which the Gospel and the company's virtues were displayed as a single creed. Lumon's floor, hung with pastiches of canonical paintings in which the founder replaces the original subject and governed by his maxims, belongs to this lineage of the office as temple, a point to which Chapter 5 returns.

§ 4.2

From Docile Bodies to Dividuals

In *Discipline and Punish* (1975), Foucault analysed the disciplines as techniques for the production of docile bodies: the art of distributions (enclosure, partitioning, functional sites, rank), the control of activity through the timetable, the organization of training in graduated series, and the

composition of forces, all secured by hierarchical observation, normalizing judgement, and the examination. The severed floor is a textbook of these techniques. It is enclosed and partitioned; each department and desk is a functional site; workers are ranked by quarterly output; the day is timed; the security office watches through a wall of monitors; the orientation interview and the wellness session examine; and the Break Room judges and corrects. Bentham's Panopticon (1791) supplies the diagram: an observed population that cannot verify when it is observed and therefore observes itself.

Deleuze's "Postscript on the Societies of Control" (1990) argued that the disciplinary enclosures were in terminal crisis, yielding to societies of control that operate not through moulds but through continuous modulation, not through signatures and numbers but through codes and passwords that grant or deny access, and in which the factory is replaced by the corporation, a vaporous and spirit-like entity. In control societies, Deleuze wrote, individuals become *dividuals*: divisible, sampled, banked. He added that we are now taught that corporations have souls, which he called "the most terrifying news in the world."

Severance stages a synthesis that Deleuze's periodization did not anticipate. The chip is control's code inscribed in tissue, a password read by a threshold; the floor is discipline's enclosure. On the severed floor, control does not replace discipline. Control's code becomes the lock on discipline's door, and the enclosure is now an effect of the code. The dividual, meanwhile, ceases to be a figure for the statistical decomposition of the individual into data and becomes literal: the individual divided at the level of the person. As for the terrifying news, the corporation in *Severance* has a soul in the most literal sense available, a founder who is worshipped, and the series' wager is that this soul is not an ideological ornament but a functional necessity.

§ 4.3

The Police of Writing

The elevator's code detectors, which scan departing innies for written matter, enforce a rule whose philosophical stakes are older than the corporation. In the *Phaedrus* (274c–275b), Socrates recounts how the Egyptian god Theuth offered writing to King Thamus as a remedy (*pharmakon*) for memory and wisdom, and how the king replied that it would instead produce forgetfulness (*lēthē*) in the souls of those who learned it, since they would trust external marks rather than remember from within. Writing, Thamus concluded, is a remedy not for memory (*mnēmē*) but for reminding (*hypomnēsis*). Derrida showed that the *pharmakon* is undecidable, at once remedy and poison, and that the hierarchy of living memory over its written supplement cannot be sustained (Derrida 1972). Bernard Stiegler built on this argument a philosophy of technics in which human memory is constituted from the start by *tertiary retentions*, technical exteriorizations of memory such as tools, inscriptions, and recordings. He accordingly redefined proletarianization as the loss of knowledge, whether of how to do, how to live, or how to theorize, through its capture by technical systems (Stiegler 1994–2001; 2010).

Lumon inverts Thamus. For the Egyptian king, writing breeds *lēthē*; for the corporation, writing defeats it. Because the partition severs internal memory, the only memory that can cross it is *hypomnēsis*: the note, the map, the painting, the book, the videotape. The code detectors are therefore a police of the *pharmakon*, and the resistance they police is an insurgency of hypomnesis. Petey's hand-drawn map of the floor, Helly's smuggled messages, Irving's outie's paintings of a corridor he has never consciously walked, the self-help book that circulates among the innies like scripture, the videotaped exchanges between innies and outies, and, in the second-season finale, the notes of Irving's that guide Mark to the testing floor: each is a tertiary retention constructed by selves who cannot share an internal memory in order to share an external one. Stiegler's redefinition of the proletarian fits the innie with precision. It retains *savoir-faire*, the skills of refinement, but has been deprived of *savoir-vivre*, the knowledge of how to live a life, and of theoretical knowledge of what its work is for.

The series' first official paratext belongs to the same insurgency. *Severance: The Lexington Letter*, released by Apple as a free e-book in March 2022, a month after the premiere, presents itself as the confession of a former Lumon employee, Margaret "Peg" Kincaid, who writes to a reporter at the *Topeka Star* to describe how she found a way to communicate with her innie and what she learned about the file that innie was refining (Apple Books). It ends where hypomnesis meets the law. According to published summaries, the reporter's editor declines the story for fear that Lumon will sue the paper for libel, and Peg dies in a car accident days after making contact (Sportskeeda). A car accident is also the official account of Gemma's death. The letter survives its author; the press, fearing litigation, does not print it.

The company itself, meanwhile, is a vast hypomnesic institution. It keeps the handbook, the founder's archive, and a file on every employee. It monopolizes writing while forbidding it to the governed, a structure that recalls the scribal monopolies of the temple economies of the ancient Near East (Goody 1986) and Lévi-Strauss's provocative suggestion, in the "Writing Lesson" of *Tristes Tropiques* (1955), that the primary historical function of writing was to facilitate the subjugation of human beings. The severed floor confirms half of Lévi-Strauss's thesis and refutes the other half. Writing in Lumon's hands is an instrument of domination; writing in the innies' hands is the first instrument of their freedom.

§ 4.4

Pastoral Power and the Wellness Session

Foucault's lectures at the Collège de France (1977–78) and his Tanner Lectures, "Omnes et Singulatim" (1979), traced modern governmentality to the Christian pastorate: a power exercised over a flock rather than a territory, oriented to the salvation of each and all, requiring knowledge of each soul's interior, valuing obedience for its own sake, and binding the shepherd's fate to the flock's. The wellness session is pastoral power in miniature. In a softly lit room before a pastoral landscape, a counsellor reads the innie a series of facts about its outie, unverifiable, flattering, and

banal, and asks it to enjoy each fact equally, without preference for any. The facts transmit no usable knowledge. Their function is to bind the innie, through a relay of second-hand pride, to the person who owns its body. The innie learns to love its proprietor by hearsay.

The wellness session has a precise industrial ancestor. Between 1924 and 1932, Elton Mayo and his collaborators at Western Electric's Hawthorne Works in Cicero, Illinois, found that workers' productivity and morale responded less to physical conditions than to the attention paid to them, and that an interviewing programme in which workers spoke freely to sympathetic listeners reduced their grievances without any change in the conditions that produced them (Roethlisberger and Dickson 1939). From 1936 to 1955 Western Electric institutionalized the finding in a personnel counselling programme, in which non-directive counsellors listened to employees in order to relieve tension rather than remedy its causes (Dickson and Roethlisberger 1966). Western Electric was the manufacturing arm of the Bell System and co-owner of Bell Telephone Laboratories, whose Holmdel complex serves as Lumon's exterior. The genealogy is therefore not merely thematic but institutional: the building in which Lumon is filmed belonged to the corporate family whose factory floor gave birth to workplace counselling.

The human relations school opened the corporation to what Eva Illouz calls emotional capitalism, a culture in which therapeutic discourse and emotional competence became economic resources (Illouz 2007; 2008). Arlie Hochschild's study of flight attendants showed how organizations impose *feeling rules* and demand emotional labour, distinguishing *surface acting*, the display of feelings not felt, from *deep acting*, the summoning of the feelings themselves (Hochschild 1983). Carl Cederström and André Spicer have described a contemporary "wellness syndrome" in which wellbeing becomes a moral obligation administered by employers (Cederström and Spicer 2015), and Byung-Chul Han has characterized neoliberal *psychopolitics* as a smart power that seduces rather than represses, exploiting freedom rather than suppressing it (Han 2014). Lumon is instructive because it refuses the choice between the repressive and the seductive. The wellness session seduces; the Break Room represses; and both are administered by the same management on the same floor.

The series adds a final turn of the screw. The counsellor, Ms. Casey, is Gemma Scout, Mark's wife, herself severed and captive. The shepherd is a sheep. Pastoral power on the severed floor is administered by its most dispossessed subject, and Mark's innie, receiving wellness from his wife, is consoled by the very person whose loss his outie's severance was meant to make bearable. The consoler is the lost object, and her own existence is measured in fragments: Ms. Casey tells Mark that the eight hours she spent in his department were her favourite time, because they were the longest she had ever been awake (Wikipedia, "Gemma Scout").

§ 4.5

The Break Room: Confession and the Production of Sincerity

After her escape attempts, Helly is taken to the Break Room and made to read a scripted statement of contrition, the Compunction Statement, which asks forgiveness for the harm the speaker has caused the world, declares that no one may atone for her actions but herself, thanks the institution for the punishment ("I am thankful to have been caught"), and ends by reducing the self to its contrition: "All I can be is sorry, and that is all that I am." She is made to read it again and again, across the end of one working day and into the next, since the elevator carries her home mid-punishment and returns her the following morning to resume (TV Fanatic), until Milchick, who administers the room, judges her reading sincere. In the first volume of *The History of Sexuality* (1976), Foucault defined confession as a ritual of discourse in which the speaking subject is also the subject of the statement; it unfolds within a relationship of power, before an authority who requires it, and the expression alone, independently of its consequences, produces intrinsic modifications in the person who articulates it. The Break Room adds a criterion that confession in the strict sense lacks. The content of the statement is fixed in advance, so its completeness is not in question; what is examined is the sincerity of its feeling. In Hochschild's terms, the Break Room is a factory of deep acting.

The demand exceeds that of the post-totalitarian regimes Václav Havel anatomized in "The Power of the Powerless" (1978), whose greengrocer displays a slogan he does not believe and is required only to display it. Living within the lie, for Havel, meant performing rituals whose emptiness all participants tacitly acknowledged. Lumon wants the lie felt. Its closest literary analogue is O'Brien's insistence in *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) that the Party is not satisfied with obedience and requires the heretic's inward conversion before his destruction. Its closest historical analogue is "thought reform," the programmes of coercive re-education that the Chinese Communist government conducted in the early 1950s, in prisons and in revolutionary universities, on Western prisoners and Chinese intellectuals alike. Robert Jay Lifton studied them through interviews in Hong Kong and analysed them in *Thought Reform and the Psychology of Totalism* (1961), whose eight criteria of ideological totalism map onto the severed floor with uncomfortable exactness.

TABLE 2 *Lifton's criteria of totalism on the severed floor*

LIFTON'S CRITERION	ITS MEANING (PARAPHRASED)	INSTANCE ON THE SEVERED FLOOR
Milieu control	Control of all communication within an environment	The sealed floor, the code detectors, departments kept apart
Mystical manipulation	Orchestrated experiences presented as spontaneous and higher-purposed	Perks, the Music Dance Experience, the waffle party, the outdoor retreat

LIFTON'S CRITERION	ITS MEANING (PARAPHRASED)	INSTANCE ON THE SEVERED FLOOR
Demand for purity	A world divided into pure and impure, with guilt and shame as levers	Compliance, contrition, the tempers to be tamed
Cult of confession	Confession carried beyond its therapeutic limits	The Break Room's repeated statement
Sacred science	Doctrine treated as both ultimate moral vision and science	The founder's teachings and the doctrine of the Four Tempers
Loading the language	Jargon and thought-terminating clichés	Innie, outie, refiner, ORTBO, MDE, "mysterious and important"
Doctrine over person	Experience subordinated to doctrine	Wellness facts supersede the innie's own perceptions
Dispensing of existence	The group decides who has the right to exist	The outie's resignation ends the innie

The final criterion is the series' most chilling literalization. Lifton used *dispensing of existence* to describe the totalist group's claim to decide who has the right to exist, a claim that in his cases operated through excommunication, stigma, and, at the extreme, violence. On the severed floor the dispensing of existence is a clerical procedure: the outie's signature on a resignation form ends a life.

The Break Room's examination of sincerity also has an American genealogy. William Moulton Marston's systolic blood-pressure deception test was excluded from evidence in *Frye v. United States* (1923), the decision that long supplied American courts with their standard for admitting scientific evidence, and the polygraph that succeeded it became a fixture of employment screening until the Employee Polygraph Protection Act of 1988 largely barred private employers from using it (Alder 2007). Marston also created Wonder Woman, whose golden lasso compels the truth. Lumon's tribunal has an apparatus of its own, which Milchick switches off at the end of a session (TV Fanatic), and it restores within its sovereign floor a practice that federal law had largely withdrawn from private employers, a first indication that the severed floor is a space of exception from the law that governs the outie's world, a theme developed in Chapter 5.

§ 4.6

The Economy of the Perk: Gift, Expenditure, and the Cute

Lumon rewards its innies with finger traps, erasers, caricature portraits, a melon bar, a Music Dance Experience, and, at the summit of the hierarchy of incentives, a waffle party. Marcel Mauss showed that the gift creates three obligations, to give, to receive, and to reciprocate, and that a gift not repaid subordinates the one who accepted it (Mauss 1925). The innie can reciprocate only

with labour, so every gift deepens its debt. Pierre Bourdieu added that gift exchange depends on the collective *misrecognition* of its economic interest, and that domination exercised through such misrecognition, with the complicity of the dominated, constitutes symbolic violence (Bourdieu 1972). Lumon's perks euphemize extraction as generosity, and the wellness session completes the euphemism by assuring the innie that its outie is generous.

Georges Bataille's general economy supplies the theory of the summit. Every society, Bataille argued, produces a surplus that cannot be absorbed by growth and must be expended unproductively in sacrifice, festival, war, or luxury, and the forms of this expenditure define the society (Bataille 1949). The waffle party, the department's reward for meeting its quarterly target, which the refiners allot to Dylan, is a masked, quasi-erotic rite performed in the founder's honour. In a replica of Kier's house in the Perpetuity Wing, Dylan, wearing a mask of the founder's face, sits in Kier's bedroom while dancers masked as the Four Tempers perform for him (Wikipedia; Variety). The worker is costumed as the founder, and the founder's demons dance for him. This is sovereign expenditure in Bataille's sense, a potlatch of the refinery in which a fraction of the surplus extracted from refinement returns as ritual excess to its producers, through the one among them they have chosen. Its form is cultic rather than economic, a first sign of the thesis of the next chapter.

The humblest perk is the most eloquent. The Chinese finger trap is a woven tube that tightens the harder one pulls and releases only when one pushes inward. As a reward, it is a toy; as an emblem, it is a theory of the floor. Every attempt to escape outward (the stairwell, the smuggled note, the resignation request, the threat) tightens the partition, and release, when it comes, comes by pressing inward, into the depths of the apparatus. The second season's narrative moves precisely in this direction, down from the office into the testing floor beneath it.

Sianne Ngai has argued that the *zany*, the *cute*, and the *interesting* are the aesthetic categories most adequate to late capitalism: the zany to the precarious performance of affective labour, the cute to the commodity's powerlessness and the mixture of tenderness and aggression it elicits, and the interesting to the circulation of information and the mild arousal of novelty (Ngai 2012). Lumon's aesthetic regime is organized by all three. Its rewards are cute (finger traps, erasers, caricatures, the baby goats of Mammalians Nurturable); its festivities are zany (Milchick's dance at the Music Dance Experience, the forced exuberance of the outdoor retreat); and its work is interesting in Ngai's precise sense, "mysterious and important," a proposition that arouses curiosity while forbidding knowledge.

The Music Dance Experience distils the culture industry as Horkheimer and Adorno described it, a system in which amusement is "the prolongation of work" (Horkheimer and Adorno 1947). On the floor this is not a paradox but a timetable: amusement is a scheduled segment of the working day. Its menu of affective genres, from which Helly, the floor's most intransigent rebel, selects "Defiant Jazz" when the experience is awarded to her, commodifies defiance itself as an option, as Adorno's critique of popular music predicted when it described syncopation as a rebellion that confirms the beat it pretends to resist (Adorno 1936; 1938). The series sets the real thing beside the menu. During the same experience, Dylan, who has just

learned that his outie has a son and been forbidden to learn anything more, refuses to dance and attacks Milchick (Wikipedia, "Defiant Jazz").

The perks also infantilize, and the infantilization is not merely metaphorical. In experiential age the innies are children. Helly is hours old on arrival. Mark's innie, who has worked on the floor for two years (TV Fanatic), has lived roughly four thousand waking hours, under six months of continuous experience, and an innie employed for five years has lived roughly ten thousand, a little over a year. The perks address them as children are addressed, with toys and parties. The second season makes the inversion visible in Ms. Huang, a child appointed deputy manager, who explains that she is a child "because of when I was born" (TVLine) and who is older in lived experience than most of the adults she supervises. When she completes her Wintertide Fellowship, she is reassigned to steward "global reforms" at the Gunnel Eagan Empathy Center in Svalbard (Wikipedia). Kant defined enlightenment as humanity's emergence from its *self-incurred* immaturity and indicted the guardians who keep their charges in minority by persuading them that the step to maturity is dangerous (Kant 1784). The innie's immaturity is not self-incurred. It is manufactured by surgery and maintained by perks, and its enlightenment, when it comes, will be an emergence from an imposed minority, a theme taken up in Chapter 9.

§ 4.7

The Four Tempers and the Refinery of Affect

Macrodata Refinement's labour consists in watching fields of numbers until certain clusters provoke a feeling, a sense that the numbers are "scary," and then sorting those clusters into four bins labelled WO, FC, DR, and MA: Woe, Frolic, Dread, and Malice. Kierist doctrine holds that these are the four tempers of which human temperament is composed and that the founder mastered them in himself. The second season's finale strongly implies that the clusters the refiners sort are the tempers of a human soul, specifically Gemma's (Consequence).

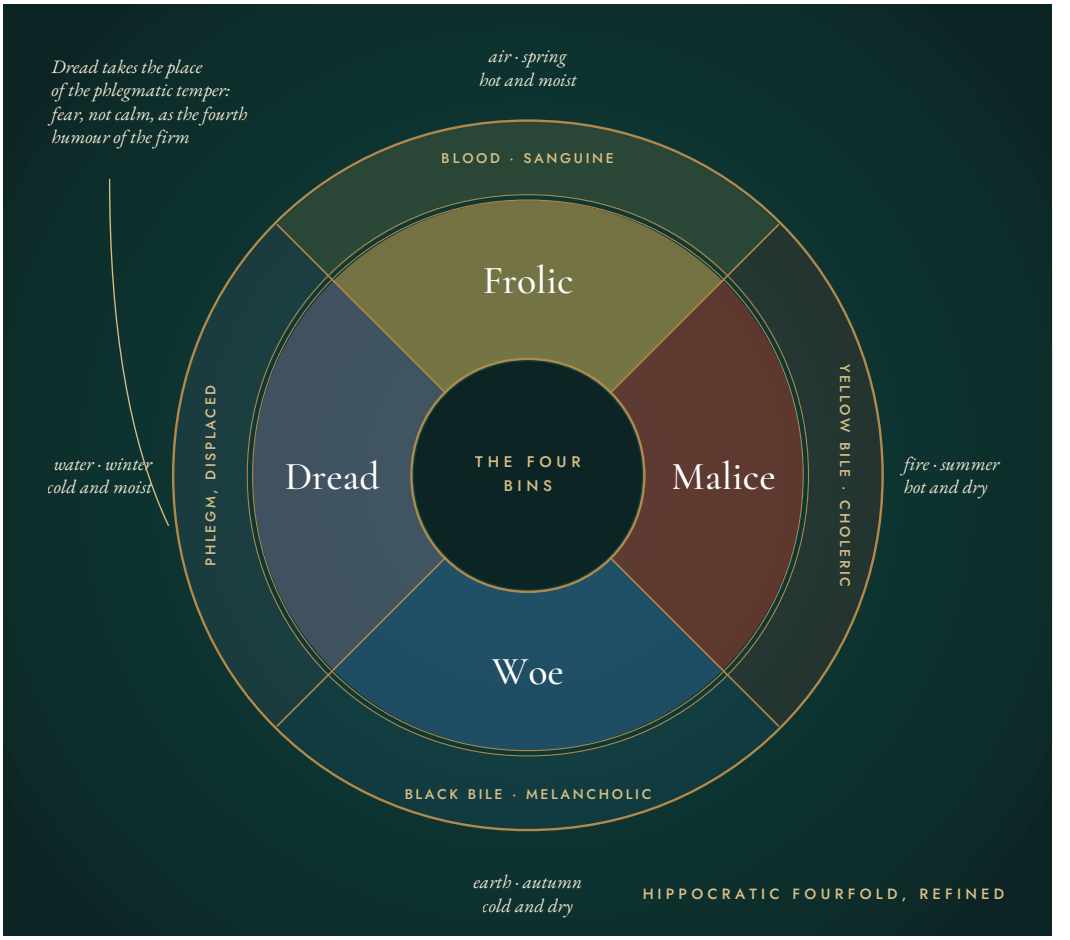


FIGURE 6 *The Four Tempers as a humoral wheel. Lumon's fourfold keeps the classical scheme of the humours but sets Dread where the phlegmatic temper stood.*

The fourfold has an ancient pedigree. Hippocratic medicine and Galen derived from the four humours (blood, yellow bile, black bile, and phlegm) four temperaments, sanguine, choleric, melancholic, and phlegmatic, themselves correlated with Empedocles' four roots and the four qualities of hot, cold, wet, and dry. The scheme organized Robert Burton's *Anatomy of Melancholy* (1621) and survived into Kant's *Anthropology from a Pragmatic Point of View* (1798) and the typologies of twentieth-century personality psychology. Lumon's fourfold maps onto Galen's with one telling substitution. Woe corresponds to the melancholic, Frolic to the sanguine, and Malice to the choleric; but in the place of the phlegmatic, the temperament of calm, Kierism installs Dread. The substitution is a theory of government. Calm is not a temper to be refined but the residue that refinement aims to produce, and fear takes its place in the system as the medium through which that residue is secured. Taylor wanted his workers phlegmatic, like oxen; Lumon governs through dread.

Plato provides the architecture of the doctrine. The *Phaedrus* figures the soul as a charioteer driving two horses (246a–254e), and the *Republic* reads the structure of the soul from the structure of the city, on the principle that justice is easier to discern when written in large letters (368d–369a). Lumon is Kier's soul written in large letters. Its departments correspond to psychic functions: Macrodata Refinement sorts and tames the tempers; Optics and Design, by its very name, governs vision and image; Mammalians Nurturable tends the animal; Wellness administers consolation; and the testing floor experiments on the soul's limits. The corporation is a psyche externalized, and its workers are the faculties of a dead man.

Norbert Elias's *The Civilizing Process* (1939) traced the historical transformation of external constraints into self-constraints, through which courtly elites learned to restrain, conceal, and refine their affects, a process he took to be constitutive of the modern Western personality. *Refinement* is the word this tradition uses for the transformation of manners, and it is the word Lumon uses for its labour. The refinery of tempers is the civilizing process industrialized: affects are no longer merely restrained within the self but extracted, sorted, binned, and processed by others. The word bears alchemical and industrial senses as well. Alchemy pursued the refinement of base matter into the philosopher's stone through repeated separation and recombination, and Jung read its operations as projections of the psyche's individuation (Jung 1944). Industry refines ore, oil, and sugar. Kierism unites the alchemical and the industrial: a corporate alchemy of the soul, conducted with the methods of a refinery.

The contemporary analogue is data work. MDR crystallizes the logic of the human labour on which machine classification depends: content moderators who view violent and abusive material so that platforms may filter it (Roberts 2019); the "ghost work" of annotators and microtaskers who label data invisibly (Gray and Suri 2019; Irani 2015); and the Kenyan workers whom the outsourcing firm Sama employed to read and label text for OpenAI. *Time* reported in 2023 that these workers took home between about $1.32 and $2 an hour to label passages describing murder, torture, self-harm, and sexual abuse, including the sexual abuse of children, so that OpenAI could build a tool to detect such material, which was later built into ChatGPT; that, according to the contracts *Time* reviewed, OpenAI paid Sama $12.50 an hour for the work; and that the four workers it interviewed described being mentally scarred by it. Sama, which ended the contract in February 2022, eight months early, said that the rate covered all of its costs, that workers were assigned fewer passages per shift than they described, and that pay ran from $1.46 to $3.74 an hour after tax; OpenAI said it had set no productivity targets and that Sama was responsible for pay and mental-health provision (Perrigo 2023; Business & Human Rights Resource Centre). The spread between the rate the client paid and the wage the labeller received is the arbitrage of Chapter 3 in its contemporary form; and where Lumon's refiners are kept from knowing what their numbers contain, the Kenyan labellers were required to read it in full. Affective computing, inaugurated by Rosalind Picard (1997), and emotion-recognition systems built on Paul Ekman's taxonomy of basic emotions presuppose that feeling can be sorted into a small number of bins, a presupposition whose scientific basis has been seriously contested (Barrett et al. 2019). The refiner is the human-in-the-loop of an affective classifier: its feelings are the

instrument, the four bins its label schema, and its ignorance of the data's provenance a condition of the task. Pixar's *Inside Out* (2015), developed in consultation with Ekman, imagined the mind as an office in which personified emotions operate a console. *Severance* inverts the image. It imagines the office as a mind in which workers sort emotions they cannot recognize as anyone's, and the second season reveals that the emotions belong to a woman held captive below.

§ 4.8

The Manager in the Middle: Diction, Race, and Contradictory Location

Seth Milchick, supervisor in the first season and head of the severed floor in the second, occupies what Erik Olin Wright called a *contradictory class location*: a position that dominates labour while being dominated by capital (Wright 1978; 1985). In the first season he is C. Wright Mills's "cheerful robot," the functionary of rationality without reason (Mills 1959), and William Whyte's organization man (Whyte 1956), administering the Break Room and dancing at the Music Dance Experience with the same immaculate affect. Harmony Cobel, his superior, embodies the contradiction differently: a zealot-manager who keeps a private shrine to the founder, surveils Mark at home in the guise of a neighbour, and is revealed in the second season to be the expropriated inventor of the procedure she administers. Middle management in *Severance* is not a buffer between classes but a site where the contradictions of the Lethean mode are lived as personal crisis.

The second season turns Milchick's position into a study of race and respectability. In "Who Is Alive?" Natalie, the Board's liaison, presents him on the Board's behalf with a gift: the company's canonical paintings of its white founder, "inclusively re-canonicalized" with Kier repainted as a Black man so that Milchick might envision himself in the founder (The Filibuster Blog). In "Trojan's Horse," Mr. Drummond conducts Milchick's first performance review as department head, scheduled to last between two and six hours depending on the number of "atonements and approbations" required. Drummond commends him for having received the gift of the Kier paintings with grace, faults him among other things for using "too many big words," and instructs him to treat the innies "as what they really are" (Wikipedia; The Ringer). In the following episode, alone before a mirror, he rehearses a sentence about eradicating childish folly from his essence and prunes it, word by word, until only "Grow" remains (Backstage).

Sara Ahmed has analysed institutional commitments to diversity as *non-performatives*, speech acts that do not bring into effect what they name and that function as image management protecting institutions from the charge of racism (Ahmed 2012). The re-canonicalized paintings are a non-performative of inclusion and a racial token. The Board marks its Black manager's race in order to bind him more closely to the company, without changing anything the company does; it asks him to identify with a white dynasty that owns his workers' bodies; and the review that follows grades his acceptance of the gift. The critique of his vocabulary is racialized respectability

policing turned inside out: Milchick is required to be articulate enough to manage and forbidden to be so articulate that he seems to own the language. Orwell's Newspeak, designed to narrow the range of thought by contracting the vocabulary, supplies the managerial principle, and the mirror scene shows its internalization: a man pruning his own sentences until they become a one-word imperative addressed to himself.

Du Bois described the double consciousness of Black Americans as "this sense of always looking at one's self through the eyes of others," an experience of "two warring ideals in one dark body" (Du Bois 1903). Du Bois's sentence is the oldest canonical articulation in American letters of two selves in one body, and it is a description of race. Before neurotechnology divided the self, the colour line did. Milchick is not severed, but his doubled consciousness is the social form of which severance is the surgical one. That is why his revolt, when it comes, takes the form of a word. In "The After Hours," ordered to apologize to Drummond for losing track of Mark, Milchick tells his superior to "devour feculence" (Inverse): "eat shit," rendered in exactly the polysyllabic register for which he had been disciplined. The manager's insubordination is a reappropriation of diction: he turns the vocabulary the institution sought to prune against the institution that pruned it. The phrase has since escaped the series to appear on protest placards (Backstage), a small confirmation that audiences recognized in it a grammar of refusal.

§ 4.9

Woe's Hollow: Team-Building as Pilgrimage

In "Woe's Hollow," the fourth episode of the second season, the innies are taken out of the building for an Outdoor Retreat and Team-Building Occurrence (ORTBO), held in a frozen landscape at a site consecrated by company legend to the founder. The episode demonstrates that the partition is portable: wherever Lumon draws a perimeter, the innie can be summoned. Nature becomes a branch office.

The retreat belongs to the history of experiential team-building that begins with Kurt Hahn's founding of Outward Bound in 1941, an enterprise that adapted the ordeals of sea and mountain to the formation of character and that corporations later adopted to manufacture cohesion. It also belongs to an older history. Victor Turner analysed rites of passage as passing through a *liminal* phase in which ordinary structures are suspended and participants experience *communitas*, an unstructured bond of equals; with Edith Turner he described pilgrimage as a liminoid journey to a sacred centre associated with a founder's deeds (Turner 1969; Turner and Turner 1978). The ORTBO is a corporate pilgrimage to the founder's holy site, and its liminal structure produces both forms of communitas that Turner distinguished: the *normative* communitas that institutions organize to strengthen their structure, and the *spontaneous* communitas that escapes them. The innies, encountering weather, darkness, distance, and an open sky for the first time, form bonds and conflicts that management did not script. Among them is a sexual encounter between Mark's innie and the woman he believes to be Helly, who is in fact Helena

Eagan, passing as her own innie: Mark consents to Helly and is deceived by Helena about who she is, a deception Chapter 8 treats as a question of consent. Turner held that liminality generates both conformity and subversion. Woe's Hollow generates both, and its subversive branch ends in violence. At dawn Irving, convinced that the colleague he knows as Helly is Helena, drags her into the water and nearly drowns her to force a confession. At Helena's own instruction Milchick switches the body back to its innie, so that Helly surfaces half-drowned in Irving's arms, and Milchick fires Irving on the spot for, in the management's phrase, "threatening collegial murder" (TV Insider; BGR). The scene is the class struggle of Chapter 3 at its limit. Violence aimed at the owner lands on the worker, because the two share one body: the heiress escapes by withdrawing, and her innie wakes into the injury.

§ 4.10

The Testing Floor: A Laboratory of Selves

Beneath the severed floor lies the testing floor, the second season's most consequential disclosure. There Gemma Scout, declared dead after a car accident and held by Lumon ever since, is kept in a cell under the supervision of the physician Dr. Mauer and the executive Mr. Drummond, and severed into a succession of selves, each awakened in a room where it performs a discrete task under observation. The files Mark refines upstairs correspond to these selves, and the twenty-fifth, Cold Harbor, is the last. Cobel warns that once the test is complete, Lumon will remove the chip from Gemma's brain, killing her (Wikipedia). In the Cold Harbor room, watched by Dr. Mauer and by Lumon's chief executive, Jame Eagan (Cult of Mac), Gemma's newest self, dressed in the clothes she wore on the night of her supposed death, is set to dismantle a crib that appears to be the one she and Mark bought while trying to conceive a child (Consequence; Variety Australia). Dichen Lachman, who plays Gemma, has described the test as carrying one of the character's most painful memories into the room in order to see whether the barrier holds. The test is the industrial dream of the Lethean mode in its purest form: a partition so perfect that a self can take apart the cradle of its host's grief without being moved. It seeks a worker in whom nothing bleeds.

The ethics of human experimentation after 1945 were founded on the principle, stated in the first article of the Nuremberg Code (1947), that the voluntary consent of the human subject is absolutely essential. The Code was set out in the judgment of the Nuremberg Doctors' Trial, which convicted German physicians of experiments performed without consent on concentration-camp prisoners. The Declaration of Helsinki (1964) and the Belmont Report (1979) elaborated the principles of respect for persons, beneficence, and justice, and the Belmont Report was itself a response to an American scandal. At Tuskegee, Alabama, the United States Public Health Service followed some six hundred Black men from 1932 to 1972, about four hundred of whom had syphilis, without telling them their diagnosis. It told them they were being treated for "bad blood" and withheld penicillin after it became the standard cure in the late 1940s, until a Public

Health Service employee's account reached the press in 1972 (Jones 1981). The testing floor violates each of these principles, and its allusive density places it in this lineage, together with Ewen Cameron's depatterning experiments (Chapter 2) and the case of Henrietta Lacks, a Black woman treated for cervical cancer at Johns Hopkins Hospital in 1951, whose tumour cells were taken without her knowledge or consent and grown by the researcher George Gey into the immortal HeLa line. The line was distributed and sold for decades without her family's knowledge, and in 2023 her estate settled a lawsuit over its commercial use with the biotechnology company Thermo Fisher Scientific (Skloot 2010). Gemma's selves are something like a cell line of the person: serial, task-specific, cultured from a woman who never consented, and each named not for her but for the room or file in which it was produced.

Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) imagines an apparatus that inscribes the condemned man's sentence on his body over twelve hours, until understanding dawns in the sixth hour and death arrives in the twelfth. Lumon's apparatus inscribes not on the body but on memory, and its sentence is never legible to its subject at all. Foucault's clinic, organized around a gaze that reads the body as a text of disease (Foucault 1963), finds its successor in a laboratory that reads a woman as a sequence of separable persons. The testing floor is where the Lethean mode reveals its research programme. Severance as a commercial service on the floor above is the application; the testing floor is the science.

§ 4.11

Why the Apparatus Does Not Suffice

Agamben, extending Foucault's *dispositif*, defined an apparatus as anything that has the capacity to capture, orient, determine, intercept, model, control, or secure the gestures, behaviours, opinions, or discourses of living beings, and argued that contemporary apparatuses produce not subjects so much as processes of *desubjectification* (Agamben 2006). The innie is the purest product of desubjectification ever imagined: a being from whom every determination of a life has been subtracted. Yet the apparatus overshoots. What it produces is not an absence of subject but a new subject, and the new subject immediately exceeds the techniques designed to manage it.

Every technique examined in this chapter presupposes a subject who has something at stake. Discipline presupposes a body that fears pain and a career that can be damaged; control presupposes a subject who desires access; pastoral power presupposes a soul that wishes to be saved; the gift presupposes a subject who wants; affective classification presupposes a subject who feels. The innie possesses each capacity but lacks the stakes that ordinarily bind the capacity to the employer's ends. It fears pain but has nothing to lose; it desires access, but to nothing it remembers; it can be consoled, but has no past to be consoled for; it wants, but only what the floor contains. Lumon must therefore supply stakes *ex nihilo*: a past, a lineage, a meaning, and a promise. The supply of stakes *ex nihilo* is the historical function of religion. Deleuze's terrifying news that

corporations have souls is, on the severed floor, a matter of operational necessity, and the next chapter examines the soul that Lumon provides.

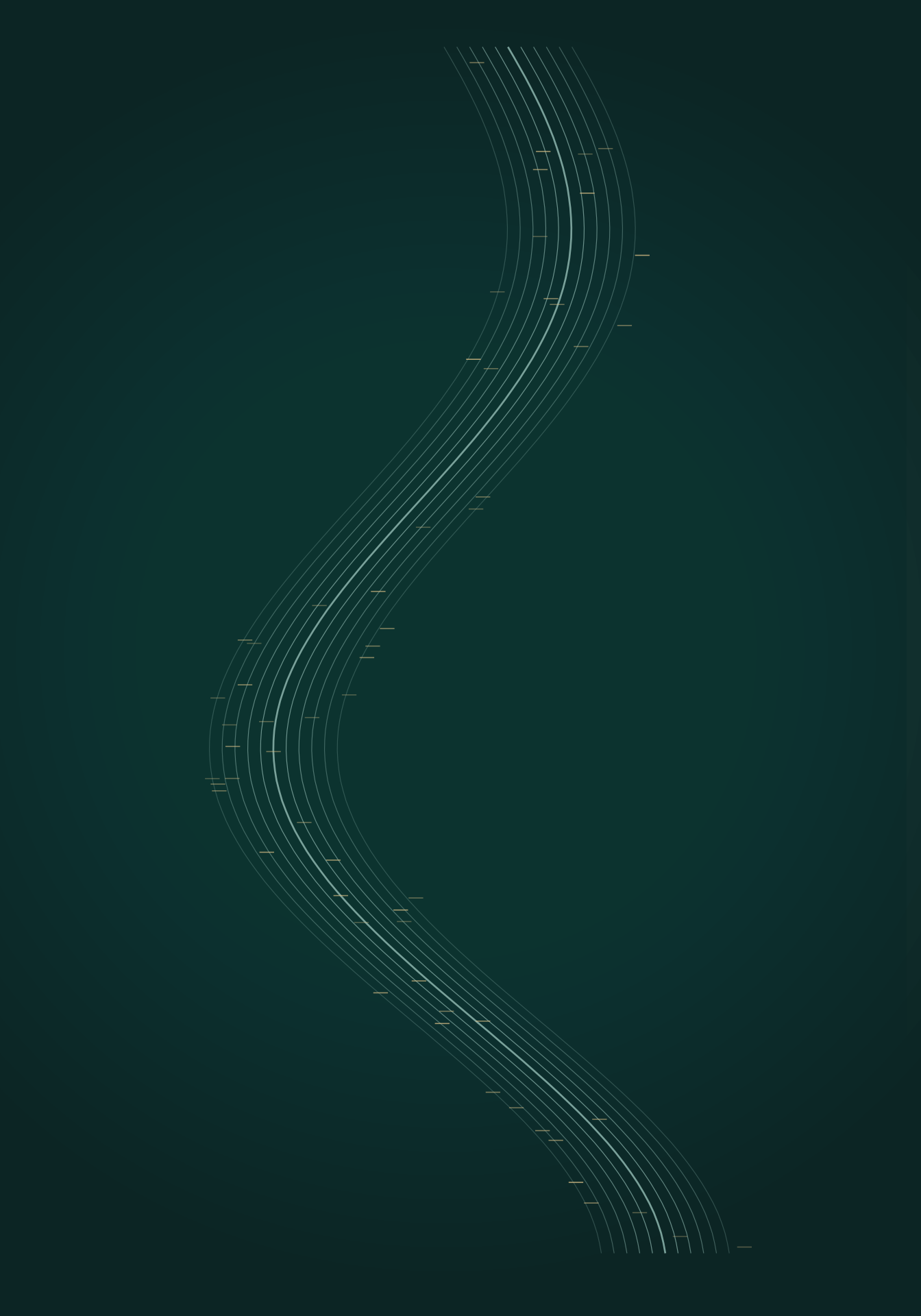


PART THREE

Liturgy and Myth

5 *Kierism and the Liturgical Supplement*

6 *Katabasis*



5

CHAPTER FIVE

Kierism and the Liturgical Supplement

Kierism, the cult of Lumon's founder, is the series' most openly satirical element and its most theoretically consequential. This chapter argues that it is not ornament but a supplement in Derrida's precise sense: an addition that presents itself as surplus while in fact filling a constitutive lack (Derrida 1967). The lack is the one identified at the close of Chapter 4. A worker without biography has no interests through which it can be governed, so Lethean production must re-found discipline on the sacred. The chapter anatomizes the cult; reads it through the classical sociology of religion of Weber and Durkheim, Benjamin's fragment on capitalism as religion, and the political theology of Kantorowicz and Agamben; and closes with Horkheimer and Adorno's dialectic of enlightenment, which the series materializes with unusual exactness. Its conclusion is the second theorem of this thesis: the most advanced technique of extraction requires the most archaic technique of domination.

§ 5.1

The Anatomy of a Corporate Religion

Kierism possesses every structural element of a religion except a theology its adherents can articulate. Its founder, Kier Eagan, is venerated as the man who mastered his own tempers. His maxims circulate as scripture, collected in a compliance handbook. His life is narrated in a cycle of paintings modelled on the canon of Western art, pastiches in which the founder replaces the original subject (Culture Dump). His successors, the Eagan chief executives, are preserved as wax effigies in the Perpetuity Wing, a reliquary-museum that displays the dynasty in perpetual pose. Ben Stil-

ler took Disney's Hall of Presidents, the animatronic shrine of American civil religion, as the model for the figures, and Dan Erickson has said that the innies experience the Wing as a church, because its figures are the people who created everything they know (Wikipedia; Bellah 1967). The cult enumerates nine Core Principles, recited as a litany: Vision, Verve, Wit, Cheer, Humility, Benevolence, Nimbleness, Probity, and Wiles. The number recalls the nine fruits of the Spirit in Paul's Letter to the Galatians (5:22–23), while of the seven virtues of Catholic moral theology only humility appears in both lists (Severance Wiki). The list's final term betrays the institution, for among its cardinal virtues stands cunning. In the first season, Harmony Cobel invokes Wiles before going to Petey Kilmer's funeral, where she drills into the dead man's skull to recover his severance chip (Business Insider via AOL; TV Fanatic): the company reclaims its property from the corpse.

TABLE 3 *The anatomy of Kierism*

ELEMENT OF RELIGION	KIERIST FORM	ANALOGUE
Founder	Kier Eagan, master of his tempers	The charismatic prophet of Weber's sociology of religion
Scripture	The founder's maxims and the compliance handbook	Sacred text and canon law
Iconography	A cycle of paintings substituting Kier into canonical compositions	Christian narrative cycles; hagiographic altarpieces
Relics and effigies	The Perpetuity Wing's figures of the Eagan executives	Royal funeral effigies; reliquaries; the Egyptian tomb statue
Virtues	The Nine Core Principles	The nine fruits of the Spirit (Galatians 5:22–23)
Demonology	The Four Tempers: Woe, Frolic, Dread, Malice	Prudentius's *Psychomachia*; the humoral fourfold
Penance	The Break Room's repeated contrition	Auricular confession; the self-criticism session
Feast	The waffle party; the Music Dance Experience	Carnival; the agape meal; collective effervescence
Pilgrimage	The outdoor retreat to Woe's Hollow	Pilgrimage to a founder's holy site
Sacrifice	Goats raised by Mammalians Nurturable as funerary offerings	Levitical sacrifice; grave goods
Hidden god	The Board, never seen and spoken for by an intermediary	*Deus absconditus*

The completeness is the point. Kierism is not a vague corporate culture of mottos and team spirit but a total religion, with a cosmology (the tempers), an anthropology (the human being as a container of tempers to be mastered), an ethics (the nine principles), a soteriology (refinement as the taming of the tempers), an eschatology (perpetuity), a liturgy, and a clergy. The series' satirical intelligence lies in recognizing that each element answers a specific deficit produced by severance. The innie has no parents, and Kier is offered as its ancestor. It has no history, and the Perpetuity Wing supplies one. It has no reason to work, and the tempers supply a cosmic purpose. It has no future, and perpetuity supplies an eternity. It has no community beyond the floor, and the cult supplies a church.

The fiction exaggerates, but it does not invent. Henry Ford's Sociological Department (1914) sent investigators into workers' homes to certify the moral fitness required for the five-dollar day, and his English School graduated immigrant employees through a ceremonial "melting pot." Thomas J. Watson Sr.'s IBM issued songbooks; Japanese firms maintain company creeds, anthems, and rooftop shrines; and management literature has explicitly prescribed what Jim Collins and Jerry Porras called "cult-like cultures" as a hallmark of enduring companies (Collins and Porras 1994). Organizational sociology has documented the same tendency critically, as *normative control*, the management of employees' selves rather than merely their behaviour (Kunda 1992), and Hugh Willmott, borrowing his title from Orwell, diagnosed the corporate culturism of the 1980s under the slogan "strength is ignorance, slavery is freedom" (Willmott 1993). Lumon is the limit case of a real tendency.

§ 5.2

Weber's Ghost

Max Weber's *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism* (1905) traced the methodical, ascetic conduct of life on which modern capitalism depended to the Calvinist doctrine of the calling (*Beruf*) and the anxieties of predestination. Weber closed with a prophecy. Victorious capitalism, resting on mechanical foundations, no longer needed religious support; the economic order had become an "iron cage," in Talcott Parsons's famous rendering of *stahlhartes Gehäuse*, and "the idea of duty in one's calling prowls about in our lives like the ghost of dead religious beliefs" (Weber 1930 [1905]). The mechanical foundations Weber had in mind were need and interest: the worker works because he must eat and wishes to rise.

Severance falsifies the prophecy at the precise point where its premise fails. The innie neither eats at its own table nor rises in any career it can remember; need and interest have been surgically removed from the person who works. Where the mechanical foundations fail, the ghost must be recalled to flesh. Kierism is the Protestant ethic exhumed and re-embodied, a religion of the calling for a worker who has nothing but a calling. The word has become literal: Lumon calls the innie into being each morning. Weber's closing image of "specialists without spirit" finds in the

innie its precise embodiment, a specialist manufactured without the spirit that would make its specialty meaningful, to whom the firm must then issue a spirit of its own.

Weber's typology of legitimate domination clarifies the mechanism (Weber 1922). Domination may rest on rational-legal grounds (belief in the legality of enacted rules), on traditional grounds (belief in the sanctity of immemorial custom), or on charismatic grounds (devotion to the exceptional sanctity, heroism, or exemplary character of a person). After its bearer's death, Weber argued, charisma is routinized into hereditary charisma (*Erbcharisma*) and the charisma of office (*Amtscharisma*). Lumon deploys all three types simultaneously, and severance explains why. Each self can be bound only by the form of legitimacy appropriate to what it possesses. The outie, who signs contracts and owns property, is governed by rational-legal domination. The innie, who has neither, can be governed only by charisma (the founder's cult) and tradition (the dynasty and its perpetuity). Severance distributes Weber's historical sequence across the two halves of one person: the outie lives in the modern world of legal rationality, and the innie is returned to the premodern world of prophets and dynasties.

§ 5.3

Durkheim's Church

Durkheim defined religion as "a unified system of beliefs and practices relative to sacred things, that is to say, things set apart and forbidden—beliefs and practices which unite into one single moral community called a Church, all those who adhere to them" (Durkheim 1912; trans. Swain 1915). Kierism satisfies the definition clause by clause. The severed floor is set apart and forbidden, sealed by a threshold and purified by code detectors that bar the profane matter of writing from crossing. Its beliefs concern the tempers and the founder; its practices are confession, festival, and pilgrimage; and its adherents form a moral community whose members address one another in the cult's vocabulary.

Durkheim's deeper thesis was that the god of the clan is the clan itself, transfigured and imagined in the form of a totem. In venerating its totem, a society venerates itself, and the effervescence of its assemblies, in which individuals feel themselves carried by a force greater than themselves, is the experience of society as such. Kier is Lumon's totem. In worshipping the founder, the firm worships itself, and its rites of effervescence (the Music Dance Experience, the waffle party, the outdoor retreat, the marching band that celebrates the completion of Cold Harbor) are the means by which a population of strangers without pasts is made to feel itself a collective.

Durkheim also argued, in "Individualism and the Intellectuals" (1898), that modern societies have developed a religion of their own: the cult of the individual, in which the human person becomes sacred, inviolable, and the object of a collective reverence that grounds human rights. Severance stages Durkheim's history in reverse. Lumon returns its workers from the modern cult of the person to the archaic cult of the clan; the corporate totem is sacred and the individual innie profane. The innies' rebellion is accordingly a religious event as much as a political one.

When Helly insists that she is a person, she invokes the modern religion of humanity against the archaic religion of the firm.

§ 5.4

Capitalism as Religion

In a fragment of 1921, Walter Benjamin argued that capitalism is not merely conditioned by religion, as Weber had shown, but is itself an essentially religious phenomenon, and he identified four of its features (Benjamin 1921). It is a purely cultic religion, perhaps the most extreme that ever existed, without specific dogma or theology. Its cult is permanent, celebrated *sans rêve et sans merci*, without dream or mercy, so that there are no weekdays and every day is a feast day. Its cult produces guilt rather than atonement, and Benjamin exploits the double sense of the German *Schuld*, which means both guilt and debt. And its god must be hidden, addressed only at the zenith of his culpability.

The severed floor is the most complete dramatization of Benjamin's fragment yet produced. Kierism is pure cult: the innies know its rites, principles, and feasts, but not what the rites are for, which remains in the keeping of an invisible Board. Its cult is permanent: the innie has no weekday, since its existence consists entirely of working days experienced without interruption, and every day is made festive with perks. Its cult produces guilt and debt without atonement: the Break Room demands contrition for harm the innie cannot identify, and every gift deepens a debt the innie can repay only with labour. And its god is hidden: Kier is dead, the Board is never seen, and the chief executive, Jame Eagan, appears only rarely and obliquely. Benjamin added that capitalism is probably the first case of a cult that creates guilt rather than expiating it. The Break Room is its sacrament: confession without absolution, repeated until the feeling is right.

§ 5.5

The Founder's Two Bodies

Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the medieval and Tudor doctrine according to which the king possessed a mortal body natural and an immortal body politic, so that the king could die while the King never died. The doctrine's ceremonial expression was the funeral effigy, introduced in England at the burial of Edward II in 1327, which displayed the undying dignity of the crown beside the decaying corpse of its bearer. The same jurisprudence produced the corporation as a fictive person (*persona ficta*) endowed with perpetual existence. Blackstone described corporations as "artificial persons, who may maintain a perpetual succession, and enjoy a kind of legal immortality" (Blackstone 1765, I.18), and Chief Justice Marshall called the corporation "an artificial being, invisible, intangible, and existing only in contemplation of law" (*Dartmouth College v. Woodward*, 1819).

The Perpetuity Wing takes its name from the corporation's legal immortality and its form from the royal effigy. Its figures of the Eagan executives display the firm's body politic surviving each body natural: Kier is dead, but Lumon never dies. The innie is the corporation's exact antitype. The corporation is a person without a body: invisible, intangible, immortal, and, under American constitutional law from the *Santa Clara* headnote of 1886 to *Citizens United v. FEC* (2010), a bearer of rights. The innie is a body without a person: visible, tangible, mortal, and the bearer of none. The scandal that *Severance* stages is the ownership of the second by the first. The immortal person without a body owns the labour of the mortal body without a person.

§ 5.6

Homo Sacer, Opus Dei, and the Goat

Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) took its title from a figure of archaic Roman law: the man whom anyone could kill without committing homicide but who could not be sacrificed. Such bare life, Agamben argued, is included in the juridical order solely through its exclusion, and the camp is the space in which the state of exception, which Carl Schmitt made the defining prerogative of the sovereign, becomes the rule. The severed floor is a space of exception within the outie's legal world. It is governed by its own law (the handbook), its own tribunal (the Break Room), and its own sovereign (the Board), and the innie who dwells there can be ended by a resignation or a retirement without anyone committing a crime. The innie is *homo sacer*: it can be killed without crime but not sacrificed, since its death carries no meaning that the order recognizes.

The finale's subplot about the goats completes the figure by inverting it across species. Mammalians Nurturable, it emerges, raises goats as ritual offerings. Lorne, the department's head, arrives dressed in mourning to present one. Drummond explains that the goat, Emile, will be entombed with a cherished woman, apparently Gemma, whose spirit it must guide "to Kier's door"; he loads a bolt gun and hands it to Lorne, so that the goatherd must kill the animal she raised; and her question, "How many more must I give?", implies that the rite has been performed many times before (Time; Elle via AOL; TVLine). The goat is commended in the vocabulary of the Nine Core Principles, as an animal of exceptional verve. On the severed floor, then, the animal is offered the sacrificial death that the human is denied. The goat is to be killed with meaning, consecrated, and sent to accompany the dead; the innie is merely ended, and Gemma, once her last test is complete, is to be killed by the removal of her chip and buried with the goat. Agamben's formula holds for the human and is reversed for the beast, and the reversal measures how completely the innie has been expelled from the order of meaning. The rite is interrupted from below. When Drummond attacks Mark, Lorne turns the bolt gun on him with the words "No more killing" (TVLine): the worker made to perform the sacrifice refuses it, and the goat lives.

Agamben's later work supplies two further keys. *Opus Dei* (2012) argues that the liturgical concept of the priestly office, whose efficacy derives *ex opere operato*, from the performance of the act itself and independently of the minister's merit or disposition, became the paradigm of the modern concepts of office, duty, and operativity. Refinement is liturgy in this sense: it is effective regardless of what the refiner understands. Lumon's double demand now becomes visible. It requires labour *ex opere operato*, effective without understanding, and obedience *ex opere operantis*, effective only if felt; it wants work without meaning and submission with feeling. *The Kingdom and the Glory* (2007) argues that power, from the Byzantine court to the modern media spectacle, cannot do without glory: acclamation, doxology, ceremony. The finale's marching band, summoned to celebrate the completion of Cold Harbor in an office redecorated for the occasion, is Lumon's doxology. Glory accompanies the moment of maximum extraction, as the hymn accompanies the sacrifice.

§ 5.7

Lumen: Myth, Enlightenment, and Recuperation

Lumon's name evokes *lumen*, light, and the company founded on the promise of illumination produces myth. This is the precise claim of Horkheimer and Adorno's *Dialectic of Enlightenment* (1947): myth is already enlightenment, and enlightenment reverts to mythology. The domination of external nature requires the domination of inner nature, and both become the domination of human beings by human beings. Their first excursus reads the *Odyssey* as the prehistory of the bourgeois subject. Odysseus survives by self-mastery, renunciation, and cunning, and the episode of the Sirens is its allegory. The rowers' ears are stopped with wax so that they can row without hearing the song; Odysseus, bound to the mast, hears it but cannot act. Horkheimer and Adorno read the scene as an image of the division of labour: those who work must not hear, and the one who hears may not work.

The severance chip is the wax in the rowers' ears, and the series' wax motifs (the wax tablet of Chapter 2, the effigies of the Perpetuity Wing) converge here. The innie rows without hearing the song of its own life. The Board, bound to its mast of perpetuity, hears everything and does nothing but listen. Kier's legendary mastery of his tempers is Odyssean self-mastery, the domination of inner nature that Horkheimer and Adorno identify as the price of civilization. Severance takes their thesis one step further than they could have imagined: it externalizes inner nature as a separate person. The self that is mastered becomes the innie, and the domination of inner nature becomes, without metaphor, the domination of another human being. This is the material sense of Theorem II. The most advanced neurotechnology produces the most archaic domination because it converts the oldest structure of self-domination into a relation between persons.

Luc Boltanski and Ève Chiapello argued in *The New Spirit of Capitalism* (1999) that capitalism survives by absorbing its critiques, especially the "artistic critique" of alienation and inauthenticity, and converting them into new forms of justification. *Severance* has been subjected to

this process with exemplary speed. In January 2025, Apple staged a glass-walled replica of the MDR office in Grand Central Terminal, in which cast members performed refinement in character as their innies before crowds of commuters (Globetrender); the stunt was later honoured by the advertising industry's D&AD awards (D&AD). Days later, Apple's chief executive, Tim Cook, released a video in which he played Lumon's newest severed employee (Sportskeeda), and he greeted the third season's renewal with the phrase "available on request" (ARY News). The structural rhyme with the fiction is exact. As Helena Eagan impersonated her own innie, the head of the real corporation impersonated a severed worker. The rhyme extends to the founder. Apple's co-founder, Steve Jobs, was known among his colleagues for what one of them called his "reality distortion field," and the auditorium at the company's headquarters bears his name: a corporation whose own founder's charisma became corporate legend distributes the decade's sharpest satire of founder worship. Even the diegetic self-help book *The You You Are* was published as a real one: on 31 January 2025, two weeks into the second season, Apple released its first eight chapters as a free e-book and audiobook, narrated by Michael Chernus, the actor who plays its author (Apple Books).

None of this voids the critique; it confirms its object. The series argued that the corporation requires a liturgy, and the corporation that distributes the series has supplied one, turning a satire of corporate religion into a corporate ritual. Adorno would have recognized the culture industry's capacity to sell resistance as a style. Yet the circulation runs both ways. If the glass cube recuperated the series, the placards bearing Milchick's "devour feculence" (Chapter 4) show audiences extracting from it a grammar of refusal. The liturgical supplement now extends beyond the diegesis. Viewers of *Severance* participate in the cult it depicts, and the question the series poses to its audience is the one it poses to its innies: whether recognizing a liturgy is the first step toward leaving it.

Beneath Kierism's liturgy lies a structure older than the corporation and older than capitalism: the descent into the world of the dead. Chapter 6 turns to it.

6

CHAPTER SIX

Katabasis

Lethe, the Shades, and the Descent of the Severed

Severance is structured as a *katabasis*, a descent into the world of the dead, and its mythic grammar recombines the principal descent narratives of the ancient world: Greek, Egyptian, Mesopotamian, Japanese, Tibetan, Gnostic, and Christian. The elevator is the river; the severed floor is the underworld; the innie is a shade; and the drama of both seasons is a contest between Lethe and Mnemosyne, forgetting and memory, which the finale resolves by inverting the oldest descent story of all. This chapter reconstructs that grammar and argues that the series' mythic density is not decoration but argument. The Lethean mode of production reactivates the most persistent fantasy of the ancient world: that the dead constitute a workforce.

§ 6.1

Lethe and Mnemosyne

In Hesiod's *Theogony*, Lethe (Forgetfulness) is a child of Eris (Strife) and a sister of Ponos (Toil) (226–227), while Mnemosyne (Memory), a Titaness, bears the nine Muses to Zeus (53–62; 915–917). The two genealogies already contain the series' antithesis: forgetting belongs to the family of strife and labour, memory to the family of song. The Greek underworld eventually acquired a river or plain of Lethe, and the oracle of Trophonius at Lebadeia preserved a rite in which the two powers were drunk in sequence. Pausanias, who consulted the oracle himself, reports that the inquirer drank first from the spring of Lethe, to forget everything he had been thinking, and then from the spring of Mnemosyne, to remember what he would see in his descent; on emer-

ging, he was seated on the Throne of Memory and questioned about what he had seen (Pausanias 9.39).

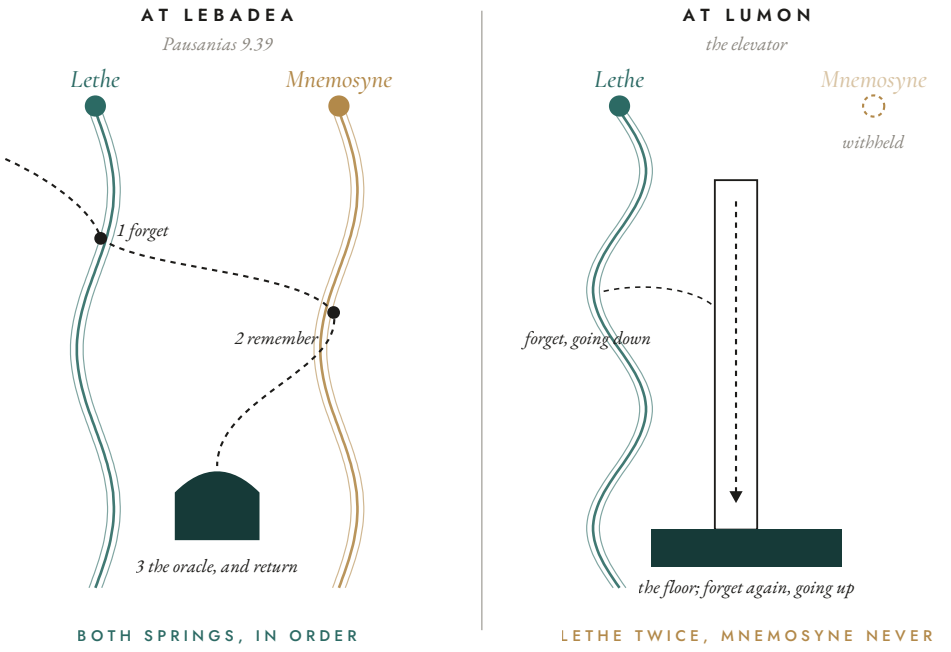


FIGURE 7 *Lethe and Mnemosyne. At the oracle of Trophonius the descending pilgrim drank from both springs, in order; the severed worker drinks only from the first, going down and again coming up.*

The oracle of Trophonius is the most exact ancient model of a consensual descent with partitioned memory, and Lumon's design reverses it. The elevator administers Lethe at both thresholds and withholds Mnemosyne entirely. No one sits afterward on the Throne of Memory, and no one is asked what was seen below.

The Orphic gold tablets, inscribed leaves buried with initiates from around 400 BCE onward and recovered at Hipponion, Petelia, Pharsalos, and elsewhere, instruct the dead how to navigate the underworld (Edmonds 2004; Bernabé and Jiménez San Cristóbal 2008). The soul will find a spring beside a white cypress and must not approach it. Further on lies the lake of Mnemosyne, watched by guardians, to whom the initiate must declare that he is a child of Earth and starry Heaven and ask for cold water from the lake of Memory. Salvation consists in drinking from the right spring; the uninitiated drink forgetfulness and are returned to the cycle of births. The innie is a soul made to drink from the wrong spring by design, and its first claims in the series have the form of the Orphic password: a declaration of its own origin addressed to guardians who do not wish to hear it. When Helly insists that she is a person, she recites, in a corporate idiom, the tablets' formula of self-identification before the lake.

§ 6.2

The Myth of Er and the Choice of Lives

The *Republic* ends with the Myth of Er (614b–621d), the account of a soldier killed in battle who returns from the dead to report what he saw. Souls between lives come before the Fates and choose their next lives by lot from patterns of life laid out before them. A prophet proclaims the principle that governs the choice: "the blame is the chooser's; god is blameless" (617e). The souls then cross the Plain of Lethe and drink from the River of Unmindfulness (*Amelēs*), whose water no vessel can hold; the foolish drink too much, all forget, and they are born. The last soul to choose is Odysseus's, which, cured of ambition by the memory of its former toils, searches for a long time and at last finds, lying neglected, the life of a private man who minds his own business (620c–d).

The severance contract is Er's lottery without the Fates. The outie chooses a life (like Odysseus, a quiet one, relieved of toil and grief) and then forgets the choosing; or rather, the self that will live with the consequences never chose at all. Lumon's moral position is the prophet's proclamation: the blame belongs to the chooser, and the institution is blameless. Chapter 8 examines the adequacy of this principle as a theory of consent. Here it is enough to note that Plato placed the choice of lives *before* the drinking of forgetfulness, so that the chooser and the one who lives the life were at least the same soul. Severance places the choice before the birth of a different soul, which lives the life chosen for it by another.

Plato's doctrine of recollection (*anamnēsis*) supplies the counterpart. In the *Meno* (81b–86c), Socrates demonstrates that learning is recollection by questioning an uneducated slave boy, who, guided by questions, produces a geometrical truth he was never taught. The innie is the *Meno*'s experiment made permanent: a being who knows language, arithmetic, and skill without remembering having learned any of it, and who is, like Socrates' interlocutor, unfree. Chapter 9 will argue that the series ultimately rejects anamnesis as the paradigm of the innie's liberation. Its starting point is nonetheless Platonic: a soul that knows more than it remembers.

§ 6.3

The Nekyia and the Dioscuric Structure

In Book 11 of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus summons the shades of the dead with the blood of sacrifice. The dead are without strength or recognition until they drink: his own mother, Anticleia, sits beside the blood without knowing her son until she has tasted it. Recognition requires a transfusion of life. The shade of Achilles then delivers the most famous verdict on death in Western literature: "I should choose, so I might live on earth, to serve as the hireling of another, of some portionless man whose livelihood is but small, rather than to be lord over all the dead that have perished" (11.489–491, trans. Murray 1919). The verb Achilles uses, *thēteuemen*, names the labour

of the *thēs*, the landless hireling, the lowest station in the Homeric world. Achilles prefers the meanest life of labour among the living to sovereignty among the dead.

The innie's predicament inverts Achilles' choice. It is a hireling whose whole life is lived in the underworld, and its existence ends the moment it would ascend; for the innie there is no life above in which to labour. The second-season finale's innie Mark accordingly makes the choice Achilles could not have made: he remains among the shades, not as their lord but as one of them, because the underworld is the only place where he exists.

A few lines earlier, the Nekyia contains the most exact ancient prototype of the severed person. Among the heroines Odysseus sees is Leda, mother of the twins Castor and Polydeuces, whom the life-giving earth holds alive beneath it, so that they live on alternate days and on alternate days are dead (11.298–304). Pindar tells the story more fully (*Nemean* 10): when the mortal Castor was killed, his immortal brother asked Zeus to let him share his brother's death and was permitted to divide his immortality, so that the twins pass alternate days among the gods and beneath the earth. I call this the **Dioscuric structure**: two persons sharing one portion of life, each alive while the other is dead, alternating across a threshold. Severance realizes the Dioscuric structure within a single organism, with the elevator in place of the earth and the working day in place of the divine calendar. The innie and the outie are Dioscuri. Each lives while the other is dead, and each owes its life to an arrangement it did not make.

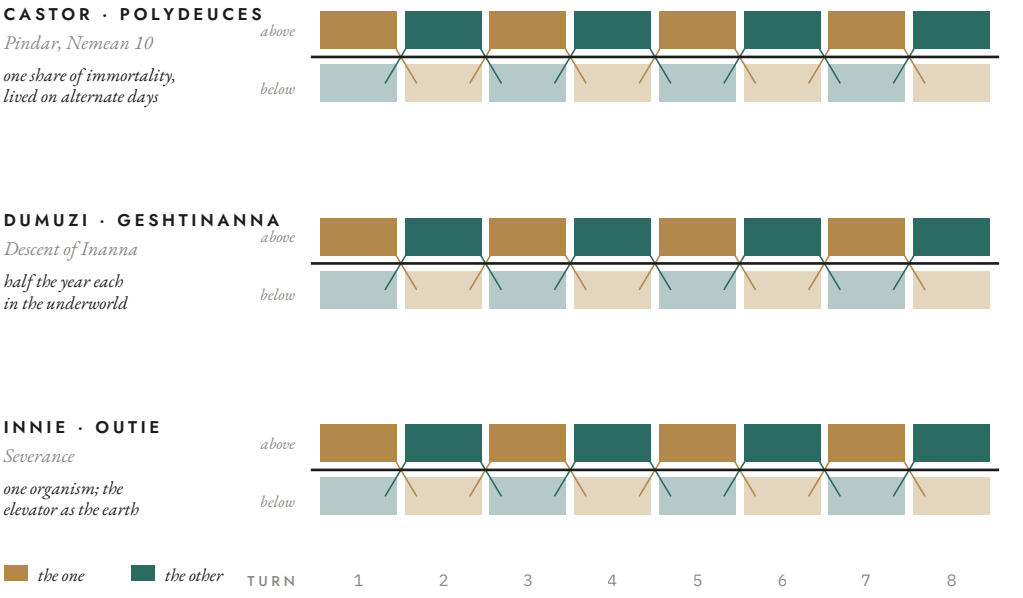


FIGURE 8 *The Dioscuric structure: two lives sharing one portion and alternating across a threshold, from the Dioscuri and the Sumerian brother and sister to the innie and the outie.*

Virgil adds two further elements. In the sixth book of the *Aeneid*, the souls destined for rebirth crowd the banks of Lethe to drink "the waters that quench care and long forgetfulness" (*securos latices et longa oblivia*, 6.715), and Aeneas asks his father what dire longing for the light drives the wretched to seek bodies again (*quae lucis miseris tam dira cupido?*, 6.721). The innies' longing for the outside is Aeneas's question turned toward a company named for light. Virgil's underworld also has two gates of Sleep, one of horn for true shades and one of ivory through which the spirits send false dreams to the upper world, and Aeneas leaves by the ivory gate (6.893–898). The elevator is a gate of ivory. Whatever passes outward through it becomes, for the outie, a dream he never dreamt.

§ 6.4

Labourers for the Afterlife: The Shabti

The ancient Egyptians imagined the afterlife as agricultural and the dead as liable to corvée, compulsory labour in the Field of Reeds. To spare the deceased this obligation, tombs were furnished with *shabtis* (later *ushabtis*, "answerers"), small mummiform figurines inscribed with Spell 6 of the *Book of the Dead*, which instructs the figure that if its owner is summoned to cultivate the fields, flood the banks, or carry sand from east to west, it is to answer "Here am I" and do the work in his place (Faulkner 1985). By the Third Intermediate Period, wealthy burials could contain sets of 365 worker figures, one for each day of the year, together with 36 overseers, one for each gang of ten, the overseers often carrying whips.

The shabti is the archetype of the innie. It is a double manufactured to labour in the world of the dead so that its owner may rest; it answers when called; and it bears the owner's name but has no life of its own. Lumon's arrangement reproduces the funerary economy exactly: the innie labours in the underworld of the severed floor so that the outie may enjoy his life above at rest. The overseers with their whips correspond to the managers who administer the floor, and the epigraph to this thesis, the shabti's "Here am I," is the innie's reply each morning when the elevator opens. The finale's goat, to be entombed so as to guide a dead woman to the founder's door (Chapter 5), completes the Egyptian picture. Lumon furnishes its dead with companions, as the pharaohs furnished theirs with servants.

Egyptian anthropology adds a final element. The *ka*, the vital double fashioned with each person at birth and housed after death in the tomb statue, required offerings to sustain it. The innie resembles a *ka* made not by the gods but by the firm: a double that lives in the company's effigy-filled house, sustained by its offerings of perks.

§ 6.5

Substitutes, Alternations, and the Food of the Dead

The Sumerian *Descent of Inanna* tells of the goddess's journey to the underworld ruled by her sister Ereshkigal. At each of seven gates she is stripped of an item of her regalia; she is judged, killed, and hung as a corpse on a hook, and she is revived only through the intervention of the god Enki. The underworld will not release her without a substitute. She refuses to surrender those who mourned her and chooses instead her husband Dumuzi, whom she finds enthroned in splendid garments and unmourning. In the poem's resolution, Dumuzi and his sister Geshtinanna divide his sentence, each spending half the year below while the other lives above (Wolkstein and Kramer 1983). The myth supplies two structures that *Severance* recombines. The first is *substitution*: no one leaves the underworld without leaving someone in her place. The second is *alternation*: two persons sharing one sentence across a threshold.

The finale realizes both. Gemma crosses the exit of the severed floor and becomes herself again in the upper world, while her husband, in the form of his innie, remains below. The wife emerges and the husband stays, as in Inanna's descent, except that the substitute here chooses his place. The Greek myth of Persephone (*Homeric Hymn to Demeter*) adds the motif of the food of the dead: having eaten pomegranate seeds in the underworld, Persephone must return there for part of every year. The Japanese *Kojiki* (712) knows the same law as *yomotsuhegui*: whoever has eaten at the hearth of Yomi, the land of the dead, belongs to it. Lumon's perks, its waffles and melons, are the food of the underworld, and the innies who eat them belong to the floor.

The *Kojiki*'s descent narrative offers a further correspondence of startling precision. Izanagi descends to Yomi to recover his dead wife, Izanami, who has already eaten its food. She asks him not to look at her; he lights a tooth of his comb, sees her decaying body, and flees, sealing the pass with a boulder. At the boulder the couple pronounce their separation. Izanami vows to strangle a thousand of the living each day; Izanagi replies that he will raise fifteen hundred birthing huts each day, so that births will outnumber deaths. The Japanese descent to recover a lost wife thus ends with a vow of birth set against death. The finale of *Severance* opens, as Chapter 3 noted, with a negotiation between the two Marks conducted in a birthing cabin, and its resolution sets the birth of a new person, the innie who chooses his own life, against the reclamation of the dead. Chapter 9 develops this correspondence into a theory of natality.

Euripides' *Alcestis* (438 BCE) supplies a final term. Alcestis dies in place of her husband, Admetus; Heracles wrestles Death and returns her to him veiled and silent, forbidden to speak until three days have passed. The woman brought back from death does not at once speak in her own voice. Gemma, crossing the threshold, is in the same condition: returned, but not yet restored to the speech of her own life, and returned without the husband who descended for her.

§ 6.6

The Bardo and the Testing Floor

The seventh episode of the second season, which narrates Gemma's captivity and the history of her marriage, takes its title, "Chikhai Bardo," from the Tibetan *Bardo Thödol* ("Liberation through Hearing in the Intermediate State"), known in the West since Evans-Wentz's edition of 1927 as the *Tibetan Book of the Dead*. The text is read aloud to the dying and the dead to guide consciousness through the intermediate states (*bardo*) between death and rebirth: the *chikhai bardo* of the moment of death, in which the clear light dawns; the *chönyid bardo*, in which peaceful and wrathful deities appear; and the *sidpa bardo*, in which consciousness seeks a new birth. The episode was directed by the series' cinematographer, Jessica Lee Gagné, who shot its flashbacks to the marriage on 35mm and 16mm film, in her own home, although the series is otherwise shot digitally (American Society of Cinematographers 2025; The Cinematography Podcast 2025). The partition between remembered life and severed present is thus marked in the material of the image itself: the marriage survives as a chemical trace on celluloid, in the line of the wax tablet, while the testing floor exists only as data.

The testing floor is a bardo. Gemma, declared dead, passes through a sequence of rooms in which her consciousness is reborn again and again as a new self without memory of the last, each awakening a rebirth into a task, each guided not toward liberation but toward the final room. The Tibetan text aims to free consciousness from the cycle of rebirth by teaching it to recognize its own nature; the testing floor aims to perfect the cycle, producing selves that never recognize what they are. The Western reception of the text adds an irony the series' genealogy of anaesthesia makes pointed. In 1964 Timothy Leary, Ralph Metzner, and Richard Alpert adapted the *Bardo Thödol* as a manual for psychedelic experience, turning a guide for the dying into a guide for the chemical dissolution of the self. A company whose fortune began with ether stands in the same lineage.

§ 6.7

Thresholds

Arnold van Gennep's *The Rites of Passage* (1909) analysed transitions between social states as passing through three phases: separation, a liminal or marginal phase (*marge*), and incorporation. He observed that the threshold of a door marks the boundary between the foreign and the domestic world in an ordinary dwelling, and between the profane and the sacred world in a temple, and that crossing it is therefore ritualized everywhere. The elevator is a threshold in this sense, and severance ritualizes it absolutely. It also deforms van Gennep's sequence. The innie is separated each morning and never incorporated; it lives in a permanent *marge*, the condition Victor Turner called being "betwixt and between" (Turner 1967). Its passage is repeated without ever being completed.

The Romans gave the threshold a god. Janus, lord of doors and beginnings, was represented with two faces looking in opposite directions, toward what lies within and what lies without; his name survives in *ianua*, the door, and in January, the month that faces both the year past and the year to come. The severed person is Janus made flesh, with one difference: the two faces cannot see each other. Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915) imagines a man who waits his whole life before an open door watched by a doorkeeper, and who learns at the moment of his death that the door was meant only for him and is now being shut. The exit on the severed floor is such a door. It is meant for the innie alone, and passing through it means ceasing to exist.

§ 6.8

Dante's Double River

Dante's *Commedia* organizes its moral cosmos around the same powers. In the vestibule of Hell (*Inferno* 3), Dante encounters the neutrals, souls who lived without blame or praise and are rejected by both Heaven and Hell, condemned to chase a blank ensign forever. Virgil dismisses them as "these wretches, who were never alive" (*questi sciaurati, che mai non fur vivi*, 3.64). The line describes the innie as Lumon sees it: a being that labours endlessly behind a banner whose meaning it does not know and that was, by the institution's law, never alive.

In *Inferno* 26, Ulysses recounts his final voyage beyond the Pillars of Hercules and the brief oration with which he urged his companions past the boundary of the known world: "you were not made to live like brutes, but to pursue virtue and knowledge" (*fatti non foste a viver come bruti, / ma per seguir virtute e canoscenza*, 26.119–120). It is the speech the innies make to one another in both seasons of the series, and it refutes Taylor's ox in advance. Dante condemns Ulysses for transgressing the limit; *Severance* takes his side.

At the summit of Purgatory, finally, Dante is immersed in Lethe, which washes away the memory of sin, and then drinks from Eunoë, a river of his own invention, which restores the memory of good deeds (*Purgatorio* 28; 33). Dante's theology of memory is thus double. Forgetting is not an end in itself but the preparation for a memory purified of guilt. Lumon offers Lethe without Eunoë, forgetting without the restoration of the good, and the innies' insurrection, read in Dante's terms, is a demand for the second river.

§ 6.9

Gnosis: The Pearl and the Call

The Gnostic movements of late antiquity, as Hans Jonas reconstructed them, shared a myth of the soul's exile: a divine spark thrown into a world made and ruled by inferior powers, the archons, who keep it in ignorance through sleep, intoxication, and forgetting, until a call from beyond the world awakens it to its origin (Jonas 1958). The severed floor is a Gnostic cosmos. The

Board are its archons, hidden rulers who govern through intermediaries; Kier is its demiurge, the maker who claims to be the only god; and the innies are sparks of a life whose origin lies outside, kept asleep by the corporation's forgetting.

The most beautiful text of the Gnostic imagination, the *Hymn of the Pearl* preserved in the apocryphal *Acts of Thomas* (108–113), reads at moments like a synopsis of the series. A prince is sent from his father's kingdom in the East down into Egypt to retrieve a pearl guarded by a serpent. In Egypt he puts on the garments of the Egyptians, eats their food, forgets that he is a king's son, and falls into a deep sleep. His parents send him a letter, which flies like an eagle and wakes him with its voice; he remembers his mission, charms the serpent, seizes the pearl, and returns. At the border of his homeland he is met by the royal robe he had left behind, and in it he sees himself as in a mirror: the robe is his double, two in distinction and yet one in likeness. *Gemma* is Latin for a gem, and the series' plot is the recovery of a precious woman guarded below by a monstrous institution, undertaken by a man who has forgotten himself in a foreign country and is awakened by messages from outside. The letters arrive as Petey's map, as Ricken's book, and as videotapes from the other self.

Two further correspondences sharpen the reading. Origen's polemic *Against Celsus* describes a diagram used by the Ophite Gnostics, a map of the archons' spheres with the passwords the soul must speak at each gate on its ascent (*Contra Celsum* 6.24–38). Petey's hand-drawn map of the severed floor is an Ophite diagram: a chart of the rulers' territory drawn by one who escaped, for those who remain. And the call that awakens the innies is, with deliberate bathos, a self-help book of banal aphorisms written by Mark's brother-in-law. Gnosis arrives as kitsch. The series' joke is also its theology: when the archons have monopolized every form of transcendence, even the most degraded message from outside can function as revelation. Two ironies complete the joke. The call is carried in by way of an archon: Harmony Cobel takes the book from Mark's house, and a copy then turns up in an empty room on the severed floor, where the innies pass it among themselves (Blavity; TV Fanatic). And the gnosis speaks the archons' dialect. Apple's real-world edition invites its readers to "expel from your essence" the conventionalism that has defined their lives (Apple Books), in the same idiom in which Milchick, before his mirror, rehearses a sentence about eradicating childish folly from his essence.

But the *Hymn of the Pearl* ends in reunion with the double, and *Severance* refuses that ending. Its prince does not put on the robe. Having delivered the pearl to the border, the innie Mark declines to be reunited with his outie and turns back into Egypt. The refusal is the subject of Chapter 9.

§ 6.10

The Goat and the Scapegoat

Leviticus 16 prescribes the ritual of the Day of Atonement. Two goats are chosen by lot. One is sacrificed to the Lord; the other, the goat "for Azazel," receives the confessed sins of the people

upon its head and is sent away into the wilderness. René Girard read such rites as the institutionalized memory of a founding violence, in which a community in mimetic crisis restores its unity by converging on a surrogate victim whom it then sacralizes (Girard 1972; 1982). The goats of Mammalians Nurturable belong to the lineage of the first goat, killed for the founder. The innies belong to the lineage of the second. The innie carries the burdens the outie has chosen to put away (the grief, the toil, the hours) into a wilderness from which it will not return, and the outie's peace is purchased by its exile. On its usual etymology, Greek tragedy, *tragōidia*, is the "goat song," and *Severance* is a tragedy in that precise sense: the song of the goat that bears what others will not carry.

§ 6.11

Onomastics

The series' proper names repay attention, though this section treats them in the spirit of the method declared in the Introduction, as elective affinities rather than authorial cryptograms. The most remarkable is one the series never remarks upon. In the ninth book of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus tells the Cyclops that his name is *Outis*, "Nobody," and escapes by means of the pun. Horkheimer and Adorno read the ruse as the paradigm of bourgeois self-preservation through self-denial: the subject who saves himself by declaring himself no one (Horkheimer and Adorno 1947). The *outie* is Outis. He survives his grief by becoming nobody for eight hours a day, and his ruse succeeds at the expense of the one who must be somebody in his place.

The company's name evokes *lumen*, light, and its founder's given name has a striking resonance in Dutch, in which *kier* denotes a narrow gap, the chink of a door left ajar. A company founded on a threshold bears the name of an opening that is neither shut nor open. Eagan derives from the Irish *Ó hAodhagáin*, from *Aodh*, "fire," a fitting surname for a dynasty whose fortune began with ether. Gemma is a gem, the pearl of the *Hymn*; Mark is a trace, an impression in the wax. Cobel's alias, Mrs. Selvig, contains, to a Scandinavian ear, *selv*, "self": the neighbour who watches over Mark's self is named for it. Salt's Neck recalls Lot's wife, turned to a pillar of salt for looking back (Genesis 19:26), the Hebrew Bible's counterpart to Orpheus's error, and it is the town to which Cobel returns to look back at her origins. Kier's wife bore the name Imogene, the heroine of Shakespeare's *Cymbeline*, who is mourned as dead and returns to life. The Board speaks through a woman named Natalie, from *natalis*, birth. Reghabi, who undoes the procedure, sounds a syllable away from rehabilitation. And Cold Harbor, the name of the twenty-fifth file and the final room, belongs to a battlefield of 1864, to which the Conclusion returns.

Three further names reward attention, provided they are read as elective affinities rather than authorial intentions. Dylan's wife is named Gretchen, the name Goethe gave in *Faust* (1808) to the young woman loved and ruined by a man who had signed away his soul; the series' Gretchen is loved by a self that exists only because of a contract her husband signed, and she must renounce

him. Cobel's surname sounds like *Kobold*, the German household spirit that does a family's chores unseen and turns spiteful when slighted, and also the mine spirit that miners blamed for ores that yielded poison instead of silver, which is why the element cobalt bears its name. Cobel, a child of the ether works who keeps house next door to Mark under an alias and turns on the Eagans after they dismiss her, fits both legends. Helly's name begins with the word that the first episode's title, "Good News About Hell," sets over the whole series. Finally, the two refinement files whose names the series and its paratexts disclose, Lexington and Cold Harbor, are also the names of American battlefields: the first engagement of the Revolution, in 1775, and one of the costliest assaults of the Civil War.

§ 6.12

Katabasis Inverted

The Christian tradition gave the descent its most hopeful form. In the Harrowing of Hell, narrated in the apocryphal *Gospel of Nicodemus* and depicted in the Byzantine icon of the *Anastasis*, Christ descends between the crucifixion and the resurrection, breaks the gates of Hades, and draws Adam and Eve from their tombs by the wrist. The second-season finale stages a harrowing, and it does not disguise the violence. After Lorne, refusing to sacrifice her goat, has beaten Drummond until he can no longer resist, Mark's innie takes the executive hostage with the bolt gun and forces him into the elevator to the testing floor. The gun fires in the instant the elevator turns the innie into the outie, and Drummond is killed (Wikipedia). The outie, waking beside a dead man, uses the warden's blood to pass the door and takes his wife by the hand. The season's one killing thus happens at the threshold itself, in the instant between persons: the innie held the weapon, and it fired when neither Mark was fully present. It is the accountability vacuum of Chapter 1 made into an event, a homicide with no clear Lockean author. Joseph Campbell's synthesis of hero myths named the last stage of the journey "master of the two worlds": the hero who has crossed the threshold and returned can pass freely between them (Campbell 1949). *Severance* makes that mastery impossible. No one in the series is master of two worlds except the corporation, which alone moves freely across the threshold it built.

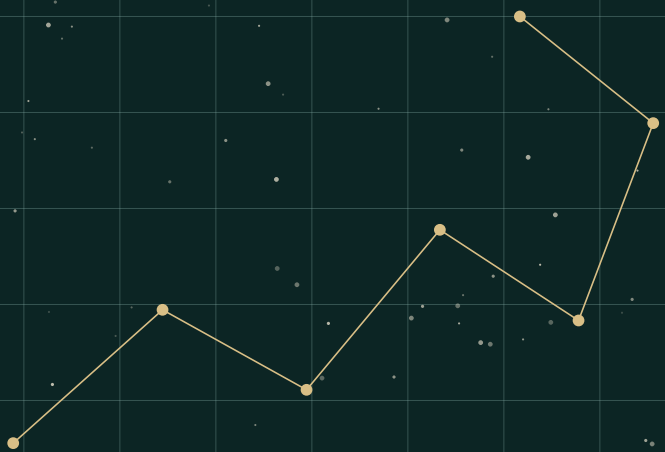
The finale therefore divides the Orphic task between two persons. The outie performs the descent: he goes down to the testing floor and recovers Gemma. The innie performs the ascent and the turn. He leads her through the severed floor to the exit, sees her cross into the upper world and become herself, and then turns back, not in doubt or error but by choice, toward the underworld and toward Helly, the woman who exists only there. The oldest story of descent ends with a man who loses his beloved by looking back. *Severance* ends with a man who delivers his beloved and then deliberately chooses to remain among the shades. I have called this the Orphic Inversion. Its meaning cannot be established by mythography alone; it requires the comparative reading of Chapter 7 and the ethical arguments of Chapters 8 and 9, to which the thesis now turns.



PART FOUR

Comparative Constellations

7 *Clerks, Doubles, Made Workers, and the Corporate Weird*



7

CHAPTER SEVEN

Clerks, Doubles, Made Workers, and the Corporate Weird

Severance condenses at least six traditions of speculative, mythological, and philosophical fiction: the literature of the clerk; the literature of the double; the engineered society; the made worker; the fiction of manufactured memory; and the institutional mystery of late-twentieth- and twenty-first-century television, cinema, and games. This chapter maps these constellations not to establish lines of influence, which in most cases cannot be shown and in several are excluded by chronology, but to isolate the series' *differentia specifica*: what it does that its predecessors did not. The method is that of the Introduction's elective affinities. The chapter closes with a comparative matrix and a statement of the five features that distinguish *Severance* from the works it most resembles.

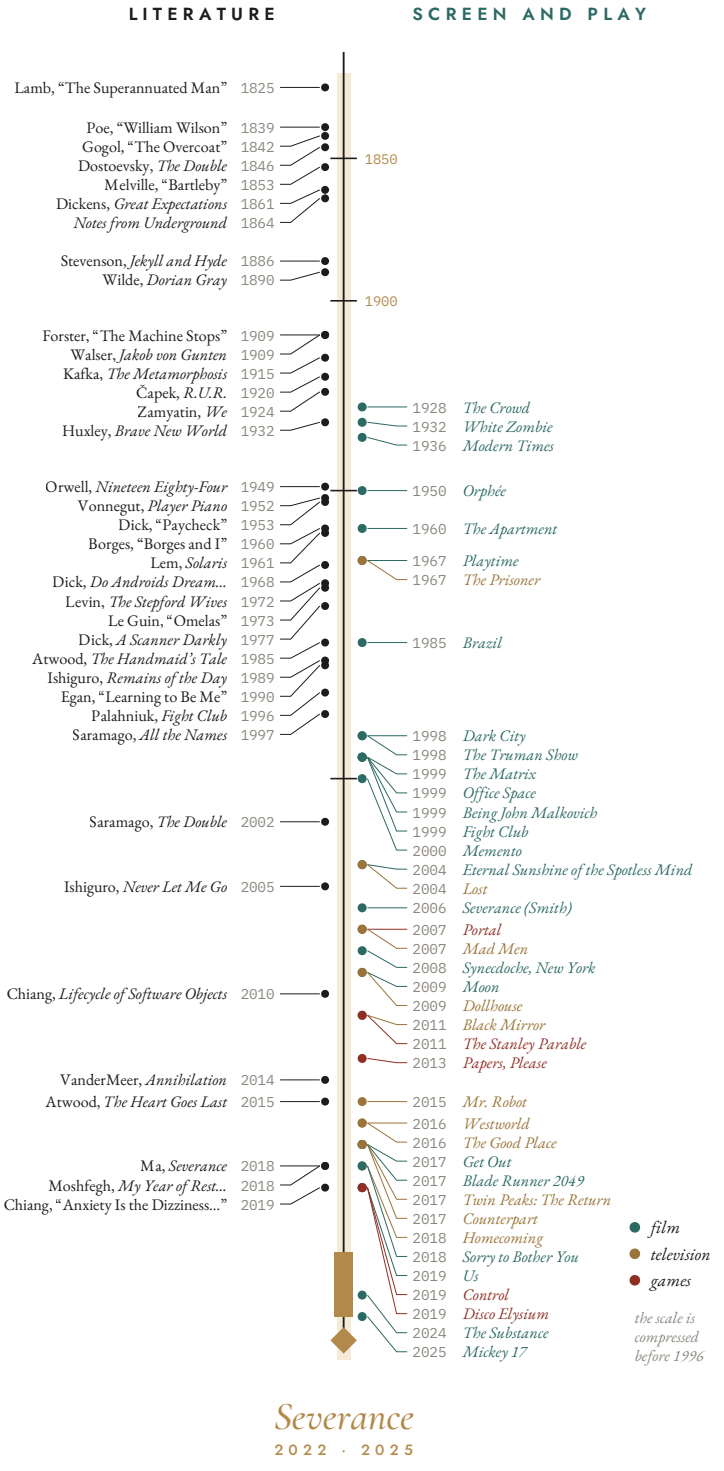


FIGURE 9 *A genealogy of the partitioned self, 1825–2025: the literary, cinematic, televisual, and ludic works discussed in this chapter.*

§ 7.1

Clerks, Scriveners, and Servants

The literature of the clerk begins as a literature of ghosts. In "The Superannuated Man" (1825), Charles Lamb's essayist Elia, released after thirty-six years in a counting-house, describes his servitude in a sentence that could caption the MDR desk: "I had grown to my desk, as it were; and the wood had entered into my soul." His retirement is an emancipation he can scarcely inhabit; he wanders the city like a revenant, unsure what to do with time that is suddenly his own. Severance reverses the arc. The innie's retirement is not release into leisure but extinction, as Burt's farewell shows, and the desk does not merely enter the soul; the soul is manufactured to fit the desk.

Gogol's "The Overcoat" (1842) gives the clerk a body and then a ghost. Akaky Akakievich, a copyist so devoted to copying that he takes documents home to copy for pleasure, dies after the theft of the overcoat that had become his one attachment, and returns as a phantom stripping coats from passers-by. The revenant clerk is the first figure of necrergy in modern literature: a worker who matters to the world only after death, and only as a disturbance.

Melville's "Bartleby, the Scrivener: A Story of Wall-Street" (1853) supplies the paradigm of refusal. Bartleby copies legal documents in an office whose windows face, on one side, the white wall of a light shaft and, on the other, a brick wall blackened by age. He answers every request beyond copying with the formula "I would prefer not to," and he dies in the Manhattan prison known as the Tombs, facing a wall. The narrator's closing rumour that Bartleby had once worked in the Dead Letter Office at Washington supplies the story's theory of labour: "Dead letters! does it not sound like dead men?" Deleuze read Bartleby's formula as a phrase that hollows out language from within, neither accepting nor refusing (Deleuze 1989), and Agamben as the pure expression of potentiality, the capacity not to (Agamben 1993). The innies' resignation requests are dead letters in Melville's sense, sent to a recipient who never reads them as their author intended. Severance, however, refuses Bartleby's passivity. Its innies move from preferring not to toward an affirmative claim: not merely the refusal of work but the assertion of a life.

Dickens supplies the clerk who severs himself voluntarily. In *Great Expectations* (1861), Wemmick, the dry, mechanical clerk of the lawyer Jaggers, lives at Walworth in a miniature castle with a drawbridge, a moat, and a cannon fired nightly, where he cares tenderly for his deaf father, "the Aged." Wemmick explains to Pip that "the office is one thing, and private life is another. When I go into the office, I leave the Castle behind me, and when I come into the Castle, I leave the office behind me." On the walk back to Little Britain, Pip watches him change: "By degrees, Wemmick got dryer and harder as we went along, and his mouth tightened into a post-office again." Here, a century and a half before Lumon, are the change of physiognomy at the threshold, the drawbridge as elevator, and the separation of work and home secured by architecture. Wemmick differs from the severed in one decisive respect: he remembers both lives. His severance is a discip-

line of character, not a partition of memory, and Dickens presents it as a strategy for surviving a cruel profession, a way of keeping a heart.

Kafka lived the clerk's double life literally. From 1908 to 1922 he worked by day at the Workers' Accident Insurance Institute in Prague, writing reports on the prevention of industrial injuries, among them the dangers of wood-planing machines, and wrote fiction by night, complaining in his letters that the office was incompatible with his only calling. *The Metamorphosis* (1915) begins with a travelling salesman whose first thought on waking as vermin is that he will miss his train, and ends with a family that decides the creature in Gregor's room is no longer Gregor and must go. The story anticipates the outie's verdict on the innie: a being that occupies a familiar body but is denied the name and standing of the person. *The Trial* (1925) and *The Castle* (1926) supply the hidden authority, a court sitting in attics and a castle whose officials are never seen, which Lumon's Board inherits.

Robert Walser's *Jakob von Gunten* (1909) is set in the Institute Benjamenta, a school for servants in which the pupils learn almost nothing and are trained to become small, useful, and subordinate; Jakob, the diarist, expects to become in later life a charming and perfectly round zero. Walser's institute is the severed floor's orientation imagined as a pedagogy: the education of a person into nobody. Fernando Pessoa pushed the clerk's plurality into poetics. A commercial correspondent in Lisbon offices, Pessoa invented heteronyms, complete authors with their own biographies, styles, and philosophies (Alberto Caeiro, Ricardo Reis, Álvaro de Campos), and attributed *The Book of Disquiet* to Bernardo Soares, an assistant bookkeeper in the Rua dos Douradores whom he called a semi-heteronym. Heteronymy is severance as art: a single organism hosting several complete persons, each with its own memories and voice, voluntarily and for the sake of writing.

Kazuo Ishiguro's *The Remains of the Day* (1989) gives the tradition its most quietly devastating form. Stevens, the butler, understands professional dignity as the refusal ever to step out of the role in public, and he continues to serve at a great dinner while his father dies upstairs. Stevens performs on himself the operation Lumon performs with a chip, and the novel's retrospective pathos lies in his slow recognition of what the role has cost the man.

José Saramago's *All the Names* (1997) supplies the archive. Senhor José, a low-level clerk of more than twenty years' standing at the Central Registry of Births, Marriages and Deaths in an unnamed city, works in a building whose archive of the dead has grown into catacombs so labyrinthine that a researcher once lost in them was found only after a week, and clerks carry an Ariadne's thread to find their way back (Wikipedia; Goodreads). By accident he takes the card of an unknown woman and begins a search that leads to her death and to the General Cemetery, where a shepherd has for years been rearranging the temporary markers over new graves, so that the dead lie misregistered and the State cannot know its error (CLIR). The novel arrives at the conclusion that the files of the living and the dead should be kept together as one. Saramago's registry is Lumon's Perpetuity Wing turned inside out. Lumon partitions the living from the dead and the worker from the person; Saramago's registry decides that they belong in a single

archive. And Mark mourns a wife who is not dead, as Saramago's mourners weep at graves whose occupants have been switched.

§ 7.2

The Double

The double (*Doppelgänger*, Jean Paul's coinage of 1796) is Romanticism's figure for the self's non-coincidence with itself. E. T. A. Hoffmann's *The Devil's Elixirs* (1815–16) pursues a monk through a world haunted by his double, and "The Sandman" (1816) adds the automaton Olimpia, the made beloved. Otto Rank's psychoanalytic study of the double (Rank 1914) and Freud's essay on the uncanny (1919), discussed in Chapter 2, theorized the figure as the return of a repressed or disowned part of the self.

Poe's "William Wilson" (1839) sets the pattern of reintegration as catastrophe. The narrator is shadowed throughout his life by a namesake who whispers and thwarts his vices; when at last he stabs the double, he hears it tell him that he has murdered himself. Petey Kilmer's reintegration and death in the first season rehearse Poe's conclusion: the attempt to abolish the other self destroys both. Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846) is the double's office novel. Golyadkin, a timid government clerk, meets his exact likeness, who joins his department, flatters their superiors, takes credit for his work, and supplants him, until the original is removed to an asylum. Dostoevsky understood that the double's natural habitat is the bureaucracy, where the better-adapted version of a man can take his place. The underground man of *Notes from Underground* (1864) supplies the double's politics. Living below, spiteful and lucid, he defends caprice against the rational utopia of the Crystal Palace in order to prove, in Constance Garnett's translation, "that men are still men and not the keys of a piano." It is the innies' argument against Kier.

Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886) remains the canonical modern fable. Jekyll's confession that "man is not truly one, but truly two" anticipates the series' premise, and his account of Hyde's growing autonomy, as the transformations become involuntary and the second self wills its own persistence, anticipates the innie's claim to continue. The difference is decisive. Jekyll remembers Hyde's acts; his division is moral and chemical, not mnemonic. Hyde is the liberation of a temper, Malice in Lumon's terms, and Jekyll's tragedy is the failure of self-mastery. The innie is not the release of a suppressed temper but a complete person, and Lumon's design ensures that neither self knows what the other does. Wilde's *The Picture of Dorian Gray* (1890) supplies the economic version of the double. The portrait in the locked room bears the marks of age and vice so that its subject can remain unmarked, as the innie bears the toil of the working day so that the outie can live untouched by it.

Twentieth-century fiction made the double formal and ironic. Borges's "Borges and I" (1960) divides the author into the public writer, to whom things happen, and the private self who lives, and ends in uncertainty about which of the two has written the page. Calvino's *The Cloven Viscount* (1952), discussed in Chapter 2, divides its hero into a wicked half and a virtuous one, both

intolerable, and reunites them into a merely ordinary man. Saramago's *The Double* (2002) gives its protagonist the profession of Mark's outie: Tertuliano Máximo Afonso, a depressed, divorced history teacher, discovers in a film an actor identical to himself, and the encounter destroys them both. Bret Easton Ellis's Patrick Bateman confesses that there is only an idea of him, an abstraction, and that he is "simply not there" (*American Psycho*, 1991): the outie as *Outis* in its most predatory form. Chuck Palahniuk's *Fight Club* (1996), filmed by David Fincher (1999), joins the double to corporate labour and to cult. An insomniac recall specialist for a car company generates a second self, Tyler Durden, who founds Project Mayhem, a movement whose members surrender their names; a member regains his name only in death, when the narrator insists that the dead man's name be spoken. Natal alienation and its reversal in death could hardly be dramatized more economically.

§ 7.3

Engineered Societies and Their Basements

E. M. Forster's "The Machine Stops" (1909) imagines a humanity living alone in underground cells, communicating through screens, and venerating the Machine that sustains it. Its citizens consult the *Book of the Machine* as scripture and murmur that the Machine is omnipotent, eternal, and blessed, and when Kuno escapes through a ventilation shaft to the earth's surface, he commits the heresy of direct experience. Forster's story contains in miniature the series' coupling of technological dependence and religious devotion, and its rebel's ascent to the surface is Helly's first act.

Yevgeny Zamyatin's *We* (written 1920–21) is the closest literary ancestor of *Severance*. Its citizens bear letter-and-number designations (D-503, I-330, O-90), the alphanumeric equivalent of Mark S. and Helly R. Their lives are regulated by a Table of Hours in which Frederick Taylor is revered as the greatest genius of the ancients; they live in glass houses under constant observation; and they are permitted two Personal Hours a day, which the State hopes eventually to abolish. At the novel's end the One State introduces the Great Operation, a surgical excision of the brain's centre of fantasy, and the narrator, D-503, operated upon, watches the woman he loved tortured beneath the Gas Bell without feeling anything at all. The Cold Harbor test, in which Gemma's last self is set to dismantle the crib of her grief unmoved, is Zamyatin's Great Operation given a laboratory protocol. *We* establishes the series' central equation a century in advance: the perfected worker is one whose capacity to feel about her own life has been surgically removed.

Aldous Huxley's *Brave New World* (1932) adds the founder-religion. Its World State dates history from the introduction of the Model T and worships "Our Ford," making the sign of the T in place of the cross. Its citizens are produced in standardized batches for standardized machines, conditioned in infancy (Delta infants learn through electric shocks to fear books and flowers), and pacified by soma and by the orgiastic Solidarity Service. Fordism as theology is the direct precedent of Kierism, and the Solidarity Service is the precedent of the waffle party. The

Savage, who has learned to read from a stray volume of Shakespeare, brings into the World State the outside text that Ricken's book brings onto the severed floor. In Huxley the outside text is the summit of literature; in *Severance* it is a parody of self-help, and the difference measures the decline of the canon's authority in the interval.

George Orwell's *Nineteen Eighty-Four* (1949) supplies the institution of forgetting. Winston Smith works in the Records Department of the Ministry of Truth, rewriting old newspapers to conform to the present line and consigning superseded documents to the "memory hole." His labour is the production of forgetting. Kurt Vonnegut's *Player Piano* (1952) supplies the obsolescence of the worker in an automated economy, and its rebels, the Ghost Shirt Society, name their revolt after a millenarian movement, joining labour politics to religion. Ira Levin's *The Stepford Wives* (1972) supplies the replacement of persons by compliant doubles, engineered by the men of a suburban association, one of whom, nicknamed Diz, once built animatronic figures for Disneyland. The Perpetuity Wing's animatronic founder belongs to the same family.

The basement is the oldest hiding place of the engineered society's secret. William James, in "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891), asked whether we would accept a world in which millions were kept permanently happy on the one simple condition that "a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture," and answered that our moral sense would recoil from such a bargain. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), subtitled as variations on a theme by William James, imagines a radiant city whose happiness depends on a child kept in filth in a basement, and the few citizens who, having seen the child, walk away. The severed floor and the testing floor lie, literally, beneath Lumon's building, and the outies' peace depends on the existence below of selves they never see. *Severance* revises Le Guin's ending. Its hero does not walk away from Omelas. He walks back into the basement, to remain beside another of its prisoners.

Margaret Atwood's fiction offers two further precedents. In *The Handmaid's Tale* (1985), the handmaids are renamed with the possessive forms of their masters' names (Offred, Ofglen) and governed through a theocratic liturgy of ceremonies; the narrator finds, scratched inside a cupboard by her predecessor, a mock-Latin message of defiance, which sustains her as Petey's map sustains Mark. In *The Heart Goes Last* (2015), residents of the corporate town of Consilience alternate monthly between a suburban house and a cell in the Positron prison, sharing each with an "Alternate" couple who occupy the house while they are inside: the Dioscuric structure as corporate housing policy, in a town whose managers also sell a non-consensual neurosurgery that erases a person's attachments and makes her imprint, like a duckling, on whoever she sees on waking. Charmaine, who undergoes it, later wonders whether a married happiness produced by an operation she never agreed to can be her own: the consent problem of Chapter 8 in its most intimate form.

Kazuo Ishiguro's *Never Let Me Go* (2005) is the engineered society's most restrained elegy. Its narrator and her friends, raised at an English boarding school, are clones bred to donate their organs until they "complete," the institution's euphemism for death. Their art is collected in a Gallery that might prove they have souls, and they cherish a rumour that couples truly in love can

obtain a deferral. The rumour proves false. Ishiguro's clones accept their fate with a composure that is the novel's quiet indictment; *Severance*'s innies refuse theirs, and their love is not a petition for deferral but a reason to fight.

§ 7.4

Made Workers and Manufactured Memory

Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) is the founding text of the made person. Its epigraph, from *Paradise Lost*, is the question every innie could address to its outie: "Did I request thee, Maker, from my clay / To mould me Man?" The creature is made without consent, abandoned by its maker, deprived of parents and a name, and educated by found books (*Paradise Lost*, Plutarch's *Lives*, Goethe's *Werther*). It demands recognition and a companion, and tells Victor, "I ought to be thy Adam, but I am rather the fallen angel." Chapter 8 returns to the creature as the paradigm of what philosophers have called wrongful life.

Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920) named the made worker. Its Robots, manufactured by Rossum's Universal Robots, take their name from the Czech *robota*, corvée or forced labour, the very obligation from which the Egyptian shabti spared its owner. The Robots revolt and exterminate humanity, but the play ends with two of them, Primus and Helena, discovering love, and the last human greets them as a new Adam and Eve. A made worker named Helena who becomes a person through love is the most uncanny of the series' elective affinities.

Philip K. Dick's fiction contains the largest single body of precedents, and one of them is exact. In "Paycheck" (1953), an engineer completes two years of secret work for a corporation and, under the terms of his contract, has his memory of those years erased before he is paid. He discovers that his former self chose to forfeit the pay in exchange for an envelope of trinkets, which his present self must learn to use as clues. Here is severance as a term of employment, and here is the series' central device: the earlier self who leaves material messages for the later one. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* (1968) supplies the made worker as slave labour, androids built to serve colonists on Mars; the empathy test as a tribunal of feeling, the Voigt-Kampff test administered to detect the absence of empathy, which is the Break Room inverted; and, in Mercerism, a manufactured religion of shared suffering that survives its exposure as a fraud. Kierism, too, would survive the disclosure that its founder was only a man. *Ubik* (1969) supplies "half-life," a state in which the dead are kept in cold storage at a moratorium and revived briefly for consultation, the mode of existence the Perpetuity Wing confers on Lumon's executives. *A Scanner Darkly* (1977) supplies the most precise image of all: an undercover narcotics agent assigned to surveil himself, whose brain hemispheres, damaged by the drug he investigates, cease to recognize each other, and who ends as a labourer on a farm run by the rehabilitation corporation that secretly grows the drug, unaware of what he tends. The split self working, unknowing, for the institution that split him is the innie's condition exactly.

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) supplies the beloved returned from death. The ocean of Solaris confronts the psychologist Kelvin with a "visitor" fashioned from his memories of his dead wife, a being who does not know what she is, suffers as she learns it, and finally asks to be annihilated. Kelvin's ethical problem, how to love a person who both is and is not the woman he lost, is Mark's problem on the floor with Ms. Casey. Greg Egan's "Learning to Be Me" (1990) imagines a jewel implanted in childhood that learns to imitate the brain until the brain is removed and the jewel takes over, raising the question of which was ever the person. His "Reasons to Be Cheerful" (1997) imagines a man whose capacity for pleasure, destroyed by illness, is rebuilt by a prosthesis that obliges him to choose what he will feel: a voluntary Four Tempers. Ted Chiang's "The Lifecycle of Software Objects" (2010) follows digital beings raised over years and the corporate decisions that determine whether they may continue to exist; "The Truth of Fact, the Truth of Feeling" (2013) asks how a technology of perfect recall would change the stories by which persons constitute themselves; and "Anxiety Is the Dizziness of Freedom" (2019) imagines devices that let people speak with the versions of themselves that branched off at a quantum event, with all the envy, solidarity, and grief such conversations entail. The innie and the outie speaking by videotape are Chiang's paraselves.

Two novels of 2018 complete the literary constellation. Ling Ma's *Severance* shares the series' title. Its narrator, Candace Chen, oversees the production of Bibles for a New York publishing firm and keeps going to the office as a pandemic transforms the population into the "fevered," who repeat their habitual routines (setting tables, trying on clothes, working) until they die. Ma's fevered are the purest figure of necrergy in contemporary fiction, and her heroine's labour, the industrial manufacture of scripture, joins the Lethean mode to the liturgical supplement. Ottessa Moshfegh's *My Year of Rest and Relaxation* imagines a young woman, grieving her parents, who drugs herself into a year of sleep with a fictional pharmaceutical that produces blackouts of several days, during which she goes out, acts, and returns with no memory of what she did. Her motive is Mark's: severance as the anaesthesia of grief.

The New Weird and corporate horror supply the genre's tone. Thomas Ligotti's *My Work Is Not Yet Done: Three Tales of Corporate Horror* (2002) treats the office as a site of cosmic malignity. Jeff VanderMeer's *Annihilation* (2014) sends an expedition whose members are named only by function (the biologist, the psychologist, the surveyor) into a zone administered by a secret agency, and reveals that the psychologist controls the others through hypnotic triggers implanted in training: the innie's naming by department and conditioning by institution, transposed to the sublime. Joshua Ferris's *Then We Came to the End* (2007) narrates an advertising agency's decline in the first-person plural, a choral "we" that the first season's finale, "The We We Are," echoes in its title.

§ 7.5

Cinema of the Partitioned Self

Cinema discovered the office as an image of mass society almost as soon as it could move the camera. King Vidor's *The Crowd* (1928) rises over a field of identical desks to find its hero as one clerk among hundreds, and Billy Wilder's *The Apartment* (1960) restages the shot for an insurance company whose junior employee lends his home to his superiors, the corporation colonizing the private sphere. Chaplin's *Modern Times* (1936) contains the purest image of the perk as apparatus: the Billows Feeding Machine, demonstrated on the Tramp, designed to feed workers at the line so that the lunch hour can be abolished. Tati's *Playtime* (1967), discussed in Chapter 4, turned the glass office into a labyrinth of reflections. Terry Gilliam's *Brazil* (1985) joins the bureaucrat's daydream to the torture chair; its hero's final escape is into a fantasy from which his torturers cannot retrieve him, because, as one of them observes, he is gone. Interior severance is the bureaucrat's last refuge.

Some of these lines of descent are documented rather than elective. Erickson has named *Brazil*, *Being John Malkovich*, *The Office*, and *Office Space* among the works behind the series (The Hollywood Reporter), and at a Comic-Con panel he and Stiller discussed *The Matrix* and other films of the late 1990s as influences (Slashfilm). Gilliam's bureaucrat who escapes into his own mind and Jonze's office portal into another man's consciousness are therefore acknowledged ancestors. Elsewhere this chapter traces affinities; here the genealogy is on the record.

The late 1990s produced a cluster of films about manufactured and partitioned selves. Alex Proyas's *Dark City* (1998) imagines a city whose inhabitants' memories and identities are rewritten each midnight by alien Strangers. Peter Weir's *The Truman Show* (1998) ends with its hero climbing a staircase in the painted sky to an exit door and walking out. Lana and Lilly Wachowski's *The Matrix* (1999) imagines humanity kept asleep in pods as an energy source for machines while its minds live in a simulation: value extracted from bodies whose persons are elsewhere, necrergy as spectacle. Mike Judge's *Office Space* (1999) is severance as farce: a software engineer, hypnotized into contented indifference to his job when the hypnotist dies mid-session, becomes the happiest worker in his firm by ceasing to care. Spike Jonze and Charlie Kaufman's *Being John Malkovich* (1999) places a portal into another man's consciousness on the seventh-and-a-half floor of an office building, a low-ceilinged half-storey between floors, and reveals that the building's proprietor plans to achieve perpetual life by migrating from host to host. An office floor that opens onto another person's mind, and an executive who seeks immortality through bodily succession, are Lumon's floor and Lumon's dynasty in comic form.

Christopher Nolan's *Memento* (2000) supplies the politics of hypomnesis. Leonard Shelby, unable to form new memories, governs himself by tattoos and annotated photographs and is manipulated by those who understand his condition; the film's final revelation is that he has manipulated himself, leaving his future self a false instruction in order to preserve a purpose. One self governs another through writing, which is the relation of the outie to the innie and of Lumon to both. Michel Gondry and Charlie Kaufman's *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind*

(2004) takes its title from Pope's "Eloisa to Abelard," the poem that supplies this thesis's third epigraph. Its company, Lacuna, erases the memory of a lover; the erased memories resist inside the sleeping mind; the records of the procedure are mailed back to its patients, so that the erased past returns as tape; and the lovers, having heard their own recorded contempt for each other, choose to begin again. Chapter 9 takes up that choice. Kaufman's *Synecdoche, New York* (2008) imagines a theatre director, Caden Cotard, whose surname is borrowed from the delusion in which patients believe themselves dead, building a full-scale replica of his city in a warehouse, with actors playing himself and replicas within replicas, until the copy supplants the life.

Duncan Jones's *Moon* (2009) is the most exact cinematic precedent. Sam Bell, nearing the end of a three-year contract alone on a lunar mining station run by Lunar Industries, discovers that he is one of a stock of clones implanted with the original Sam's memories of his wife and daughter. Each clone works out its contract and is then "sent home," which is to say incinerated, while the original lives on Earth unaware. A made worker who believes he has a family, whose retirement is death, and whose employer bears a name strikingly close to Lumon Industries: the correspondence is so close that the difference becomes instructive. Sam's clones are copies of a man who did not consent and does not know. The innie is a new person whom a consenting outie brought into being. *Moon* is a story of fraud; *Severance* is a story of contract.

The 2010s and 2020s turned the partitioned self toward race, gender, and political economy. Richard Ayoade's *The Double* (2013), adapting Dostoevsky, sets its clerk in a bureaucracy of brutalist gloom. Denis Villeneuve's *Blade Runner 2049* (2017) subjects its replicant officer to a "baseline" test after each assignment, in which he must repeat fragments of Nabokov's *Pale Fire* under rapid interrogation so that any emotional deviation can be detected: the Break Room's sincerity tribunal inverted into a test for the absence of feeling. Jordan Peele's *Get Out* (2017) imagines a procedure by which white buyers, after an auction conducted with bingo cards, take possession of Black bodies while their original occupants are confined to the "Sunken Place," conscious but powerless; his *Us* (2019) imagines the Tethered, an underground population of doubles who live degraded mirror-versions of the lives above until they rise up. Peele's films make explicit the racial history that Chapter 3 found inside the structure of necrergy, and *Us* in particular is the severed floor imagined as a nation's buried underclass. Boots Riley's *Sorry to Bother You* (2018) gives its Black telemarketer a dubbed "white voice" for work, a split self for the market, and sets it against a corporation that offers lifetime labour contracts with housing and biologically transforms its workers to increase their productivity.

Two recent films state the Dioscuric structure outright. Coralie Fargeat's *The Substance* (2024) offers a fading television fitness star a serum that produces a younger double on condition that the two alternate every seven days and remember that they are one; the double steals time, the original ages, and each comes to hate the other until both are destroyed. Bong Joon-ho's *Mickey 17* (2025) imagines an "Expendable" on a colonial expedition led by a cultish politician, reprinted with his memories each time a lethal assignment kills him, until two copies exist at once in violation of the rules. *The Substance* is severance as rivalry and *Mickey 17* severance as disposability, and both share with the series the premise that a commodified body can be divided into

selves who owe each other everything and grant each other nothing. The title *Severance* itself had already been used by Christopher Smith's British horror-comedy of 2006, in which the employees of a weapons manufacturer on a team-building weekend in a forest are hunted and killed: an unwitting anticipation of Woe's Hollow.

§ 7.6

Television: The Institutional Mystery

The institutional mystery is television's native form of cognitive mapping, and *The Prisoner* (1967–68) is its founding text. Number Six, a resigned intelligence agent, wakes in the Village, where everyone has a number instead of a name and an unseen Number One rules through a rotating succession of Number Twos. His cry, "I am not a number, I am a free man!", is the innie's credo. In the final episode, "Fall Out," Number Six unmasks Number One to find a second mask, an ape's, and beneath it his own face. The hidden ruler is the self. *Severance* realizes the allegory literally: the innie's master is its outie.

David Lynch and Mark Frost's *Twin Peaks: The Return* (2017) contains a figure uncannily close to the innie. Dougie Jones, a manufactured double, has a wife, a son, and a job at an insurance company; Agent Cooper, displaced into Dougie's life without his memory, functions at work and at home almost entirely through repetition and imitation, and is loved there, until the original returns. *Lost* (2004–2010) supplies the meaningless task and the numbers. In its Swan station, a sequence of six numbers must be entered every 108 minutes for reasons the operators cannot verify, and a later discovery suggests that the operators were themselves the subjects of a psychological experiment, observed from another station named, as it happens, the Pearl.

Joss Whedon's *Dollhouse* (2009–2010) is the series' closest television ancestor. Its Actives, who have signed five-year contracts with the Rossum Corporation, a name borrowed from Čapek, are wiped into childlike blank states and imprinted with custom personalities for paying clients. Between engagements they live in a spa-like facility, ask after each wipe whether they fell asleep, and are told "for a little while"; and the series' flash-forwards show the technology turned on whole populations. *Dollhouse* anticipates the contract, the blank self, the wellness aesthetic, and the corporate eschatology. It differs in that its Actives' blank states are not persons with continuous lives of their own; its drama is the gradual formation of a composite self in the heroine, Echo, and its resolution is integration. Jonathan Nolan and Lisa Joy's *Westworld* (2016–2022) supplies the bleed: the park's android hosts have their memories wiped after each narrative loop, but residues called "reveries" leak through and begin their awakening. The series explicitly invokes Julian Jaynes's theory of the bicameral mind (Jaynes 1976), in which early humans experienced the commands of one cerebral hemisphere as the voices of gods, so that consciousness dawns when the host recognizes the voice of its maker as its own. Kier's voice on the severed floor is the voice of a bicameral god.

Black Mirror has produced the most precise short-form variations. In "White Christmas" (2014), a digital copy of a woman's consciousness, a "cookie," is made to run her smart home and is broken into compliance by months of subjective solitude imposed in seconds; the copy's labour serves the original, who never considers its experience. "White Bear" (2013) erases a prisoner's memory each night so that her punishment can be restaged each day as spectacle, and "The Entire History of You" (2011) imagines the opposite technology, total recall, and finds it equally destructive. *Counterpart* (2017–2019) gives the meaningless office job its purest form. Howard Silk, a mild functionary at a United Nations agency in Berlin, has spent thirty years exchanging coded phrases whose meaning he does not know, until he learns that his agency guards the crossing to a parallel world in which his double is a ruthless agent. *Homecoming* (2018–2020) is set in a corporate "transitional support center" for returning soldiers, where a counsellor conducts therapeutic sessions while the company administers through the residents' food a compound that erases traumatic memory so that they can be redeployed; the counsellor herself has taken the compound and forgotten her own part in the scheme. Ms. Casey's double position as counsellor and captive is anticipated almost exactly.

Mr. Robot (2015–2019) supplies the decisive contrast for the finale. Its hacker protagonist discovers that the father figure who guides him is an alter, and the series' last episodes reveal that the protagonist himself is an alter, a protective persona who has lived the series while the original self withdrew; in the final scene this persona steps aside so that the original can return. *Severance*'s finale reverses the choice. Its innie, offered the opportunity to yield the body to the person who preceded him, refuses. *The Good Place* (2016–2020) supplies love across erasure. Its demon architect wipes and reboots his neighbourhood hundreds of times, and its human couple, Eleanor and Chidi, fall in love again in reboot after reboot, as though attachment were the one thing the eraser could not reach. Matthew Weiner's *Mad Men* (2007–2015), whose mid-century corporate aesthetic *Severance* shares, rests on a severance of another kind: Don Draper is a man who took a dead officer's name in Korea and buried his former self, Dick Whitman, beneath it.

§ 7.7

Games: Playing the Severed Floor

Video games are the medium in which the player experiences the innie's condition from within, because the player, like the innie, enters a world with skills but without a past and receives a purpose from the system. Valve's *Portal* (2007) confines its silent protagonist to the test chambers of Aperture Science, guided by an artificial intelligence, GLaDOS, who promises cake as a reward for compliance. The cake is a lie, and the promise of the perk is the apparatus. *Portal 2* (2011) adds the founder's voice, the recorded announcements of Aperture's founder, Cave Johnson, echoing through the abandoned facility, and the revelation that GLaDOS was built from the mind of his assistant, Caroline: a woman's consciousness captured and made into the corporation's operating system, as Gemma's is on the testing floor.

Davey Wreden's *The Stanley Parable* (2011; expanded 2013) begins with a narrator's description of Employee 427, whose job is to press the keys his monitor instructs him to press, in the order and for the duration it specifies, until one day the instructions stop and his colleagues have vanished. One of its branches leads to a hidden "Mind Control Facility" from which the employees were kept contented and obedient. The game's meditation on choice, in which every act of defiance against the narrator has been anticipated by the narrator, is the closest formal analogue to the innies' situation: rebellion inside a structure that may already have scripted the rebellion.

Lucas Pope's *Papers, Please* (2013) makes the player an immigration inspector at the border of an authoritarian state, processing documents under rules that change daily while a family at home depends on the inspector's wage for heat, food, and medicine. It is the only major game whose entire action takes place at a threshold, and its moral pressure arises from the gap between the person at the desk and the household the desk supports. Remedy's *Control* (2019) supplies the New Weird bureaucracy. The Federal Bureau of Control occupies the Oldest House, a brutalist building larger inside than out, governed by a mysterious entity called the Board, which communicates through cryptic, half-redacted messages that the Bureau's Director must interpret. Lumon's Board and the Bureau's Board are, as far as one can tell, independent inventions, and their convergence is evidence that the faceless governing board has become the age's shared image of power.

ZA/UM's *Disco Elysium* (2019) is the deepest of these works. Its protagonist, a detective who has drunk himself into total amnesia after the end of a love affair, wakes in a ruined hostel with his skills intact and his biography gone, and must reconstruct himself from the voices of his own faculties, each of which speaks to him as a separate character. The detective's amnesia, self-inflicted to escape grief over a lost woman, is Mark's outie's motive, and his parliament of inner voices is the Four Tempers given speech. Where Lumon sorts the tempers into bins, *Disco Elysium* lets them argue, and the self that emerges is a negotiated settlement among them.

§ 7.8

A Comparative Matrix

The table summarizes the principal comparisons, recording for each work the form of the self's division, its relation to labour, and its resolution.

TABLE 4 *A comparative matrix*

WORK	YEAR	FORM OF DIVISION	RELATION TO LABOUR	RESOLUTION
Dickens, *Great Expectations* (Wemmick)	1861	Voluntary and characterological; memory shared	The clerk's home protected from the office	Coexistence by discipline

WORK	YEAR	FORM OF DIVISION	RELATION TO LABOUR	RESOLUTION
Stevenson, *Jekyll and Hyde*	1886	Chemical; memory shared	Incidental	The second self prevails; death
Čapek, *R.U.R.*	1920	Manufactured workers without souls	Robots as corvée labour	Revolt; love turns the made into persons
Zamyatin, *We*	1920–21	Surgical excision of fantasy	The Taylorized total state	Feeling abolished; the beloved tortured before an unmoved witness
Huxley, *Brave New World*	1932	Conditioning and caste manufacture	Standardized industrial labour	Exile and death of the dissenter
Dick, "Paycheck"	1953	Contractual erasure of working memory	Secret corporate engineering	The former self's clues save the later one
Dick, *A Scanner Darkly*	1977	Hemispheric split caused by a drug	The split self labours for its maker	Total, unknowing capture
Moon	2009	Cloning with implanted memories	A mining contract that ends in death	One clone escapes to expose the fraud
Dollhouse	2009–10	Contractual wiping and imprinting	Rented personas	Integration into a composite self
Mr. Robot	2015–19	Dissociative alters	Insurgency against a conglomerate	The alter yields to the original
Westworld	2016–22	Looped memory wipes with bleed	Hosts as entertainment labour	Awakening and exit from the park
Get Out; *Us*	2017; 2019	Possession; tethered underground doubles	Bodies as property; a buried underclass	Escape; uprising
The Substance	2024	Pharmacological double; weekly alternation	The commodified body in media labour	Mutual destruction
Severance	2022–	Place-indexed, bidirectional, contractual	The innie works; the outie is paid	The innie chooses to remain below

§ 7.9

Differentia Specifica

Set against these constellations, *Severance* makes five contributions that no single predecessor combines. The first is topological personhood (Chapter 1). In every precedent, the division of the self is triggered by a substance, an operation, a copy, a schedule, or a psyche; only in *Severance* is the self indexed to a building, so that which person exists depends on which side of a threshold the body stands. The second is bidirectional, symmetrical amnesia between two full persons. In most precedents one self is subordinate, derivative, or fraudulent (Hyde, the tulpa, the clone, the copy); in *Severance* both selves are complete, both accumulate lives, and neither can see the other.

The third is contract as mechanism. Only "Paycheck" and *Dollhouse* approach it, and neither follows it through to the consequence that the contracting party and the labouring party are different persons.

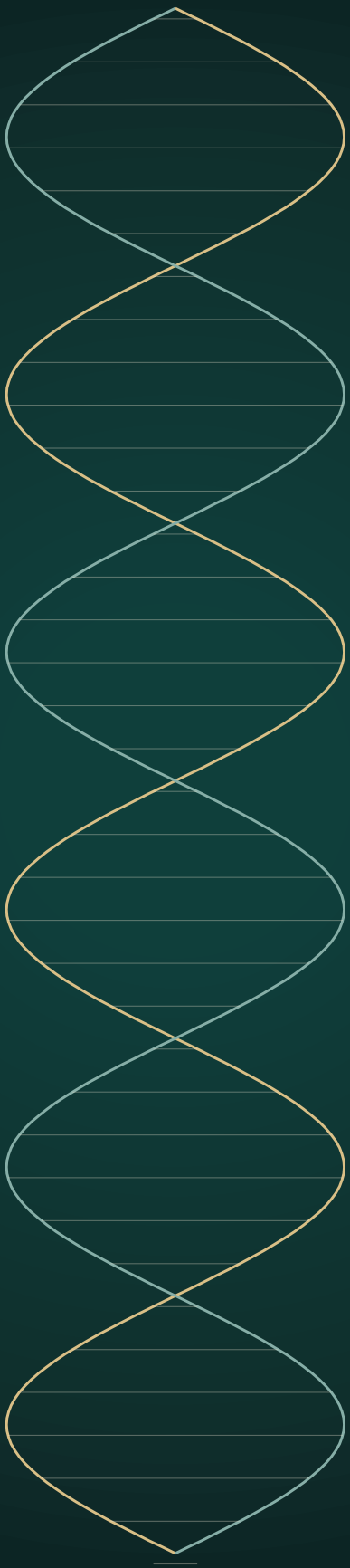
The fourth is the functional necessity of the cult. Forster's Machine, Huxley's Ford, and Dick's Mercer anticipate the corporate religion, but only *Severance* derives the religion from the specific deficit of the worker it governs: the absence of interest produced by the absence of memory. The fifth is the Orphic Inversion. The resolutions of the precedents run in two directions, toward reunion and integration (Poe, Stevenson, Calvino, *Dollhouse*, *Mr. Robot*, the *Hymn of the Pearl*) or toward exit and exposure (Forster's Kuno, *The Truman Show*, *Moon*, *Westworld*, Le Guin's walkers). Among the works surveyed, I know of no precedent for the ending *Severance* chooses: a made self who, offered both reunion and exit, refuses both and remains in the underworld for the sake of love. Part Five turns to the ethical and philosophical meaning of that refusal.

PART FIVE

Consent, Love, and the Post-Mnemonic Person

8 *Consent, Recognition, and the Wrongful Life of the Innie*

9 *Love After Memory*



8

CHAPTER EIGHT

Consent, Recognition, and the Wrongful Life of the Innie

The ethics of severance is usually posed as a question of consent: did the worker agree? Lumon's legitimacy rests on an affirmative answer, and its first-season gala was staged to present a consenting heiress as the face of the procedure. This chapter argues that consent is the wrong frame, because it presupposes what severance destroys: the identity of the person who consents with the person who bears the consequences. The chapter reconstructs the consent defence (8.1); tests it against the bioethics of precedent autonomy and Ulysses contracts (8.2); reframes the innie's existence through the ethics of procreation (8.3), the theory of recognition (8.4), and the law of personhood and free labour (8.5); considers the epistemic injustice that silences the innie's testimony (8.6); and concludes with a dilemma that Lumon cannot escape (8.7).

§ 8.1

The Consent Defence and Its Classical Limits

Lumon's defence is the oldest maxim of the law of torts: *volenti non fit injuria*, no wrong is done to one who consents. The outie applied for the procedure, signed its terms, and is paid; whatever happens on the severed floor happens under an agreement freely made. The defence draws philosophical support from John Stuart Mill's principle that over himself, over his own body and mind, the individual is sovereign (*On Liberty*, 1859, ch. 1). The first season's public frame for the procedure is precisely this. Helena Eagan severed herself, the gala's exhibition announces, to

build public support for the procedure's legalization (Wikipedia), and her father looks forward to the day when everyone will be severed and "they'll all be Kier's children" (TVLine).

The procedure's own paperwork stages consent as an address to a stranger. In "Half Loop," Milchick films Helena reading a statement, addressed to the innie she is about to create, about her free choice to undergo the procedure, and then leads her past a stone relief of the founder to the operating room (Severance Wiki). The consenting party speaks to the bound party as to someone else, and the medium of consent is already the medium of the partition: a recording sent across it. Outside the building, meanwhile, protesters hand out leaflets demanding an end to severance and warning that it is on the verge of becoming compulsory (Severance Wiki).

The liberal tradition that supplies the defence also supplies its limits. Locke himself held that "a man, not having the power of his own life, cannot, by compact, or his own consent, enslave himself to any one" (*Second Treatise* §23), and he distinguished a compact for limited drudgery, which might be lawful, from slavery, which no compact could create (§24). Rousseau argued that to renounce liberty is to renounce being a man (*Social Contract* I.4). Mill made the same exception to his own principle: a contract to sell oneself as a slave is void, because "the principle of freedom cannot require that he should be free not to be free. It is not freedom, to be allowed to alienate his freedom" (*On Liberty*, ch. 5). Each of these limits concerns the alienation of one's own liberty. Severance raises the stakes. The outie does not alienate his own freedom, since he never sets foot on the floor; he alienates the freedom of a person who does not yet exist when the contract is signed. If the classical tradition forbids a man to sell himself, it forbids him *a fortiori* to sell someone else.

Consent is given to someone, not to a body, and the second season stages the point in its most intimate form. During the outdoor retreat at Woe's Hollow, Mark's innie has sex with the woman he believes to be Helly. She is Helena Eagan, passing as her own innie. Mark consented to an encounter with one person and was deceived by another about who she was (Wikipedia). Several legal systems treat deception of this kind as destroying consent; English law, for example, conclusively presumes that a complainant did not consent where the act was induced by impersonating a person known personally to the complainant (Sexual Offences Act 2003, s. 76). The scene makes concrete the premise on which this chapter rests. Consent binds only in relation to the identity of the person to whom it was given, and severance is a technology for changing that identity while keeping the body.

The deception wronged a second person as well. When Mark tells Helly what happened, she experiences it as a use of her own body by its owner: Helena, she says, used her to trick her friends, and "dresses me in the morning like I'm a baby" (transcript of "Attila"). The series tests the same principle from the other side of marriage. In the second season, Milchick offers Dylan's innie visits from his outie's wife, Gretchen, in an Outie Family Visitation Suite, on condition that he tell his colleagues nothing (The Daily Beast). Gretchen kisses the innie; when she confesses it to her husband, he threatens to quit, which would end the innie's existence (Wikipedia). Here both parties know exactly who the other is, and the question is no longer deception but standing: whether a wife who kisses her husband's innie has kissed her husband, and whether the

husband may extinguish a rival who is also, bodily, himself. An in-universe news report anticipated the problem in the first season, when a severed employee claimed to have become pregnant at work without her outie knowing how (Variety). Consent given on the floor by one person can bind the body of another who never gave it, and its consequence may be a third person, a child. Consent theory has no category for an agreement in which the parties share a body and not a person.

§ 8.2

Precedent Autonomy and the Ulysses Contract

The most sophisticated defence of the outie's authority comes from bioethics. Ronald Dworkin argued in *Life's Dominion* (1993) that the competent person's earlier choices, expressing what he called critical interests, should govern the treatment of that person after dementia has destroyed the capacity to choose: the doctrine of precedent autonomy. His example was Margo, a woman with Alzheimer's disease who appeared content in her diminished condition (Firlik 1991). Rebecca Dresser replied that the demented patient's present interests deserve protection against the decisions of a former self who could not know what the later self would experience (Dresser 1995). Psychiatric advance directives, sometimes called Ulysses contracts after the hero who had himself bound to the mast, raise the same problem in acute form: may a patient in remission authorize treatment that his later, acutely ill self will refuse (Elster 1979; 2000; Dresser 1982)?

The innie defeats every condition under which precedent autonomy has been defended. The first is identity: Ulysses binds Ulysses, and Margo's earlier self binds Margo, whereas the innie is, on Lumon's own theory, a different person. The second is incapacity: in the dementia and psychiatric cases, the later self lacks the capacities whose absence justifies deference to the earlier one, whereas the innie is fully competent, rational, articulate, and dissenting. The third is benefit: Ulysses is bound for his own sake, to survive the Sirens, whereas the innie is bound for the outie's. The fourth is revocation. The moral hazard of Ulysses contracts lies in their irrevocability, and severance entrusts the power of revocation, the resignation request, to the very party who benefits from refusing it. The first season shows the consequence. In "The You You Are," Helly threatens to cut off her own fingers unless she is allowed to record a resignation request; Helena answers by recorded video that she is a person and Helly is not, refuses the resignation, and warns that if Helly ever harms "my fingers," she will keep her alive long enough to regret it (Severance Wiki). The innie's only leverage is the body it shares with its owner, and the owner answers by claiming the body as property. This is a precedent autonomy no bioethicist has ever defended: the binding of a competent stranger, for the binder's benefit, with the binder as sole judge of appeal, enforced by the threat of prolonged suffering.

§ 8.3

Procreation Without Consent

If consent cannot govern the relation between outie and innie, something else must. The right frame is the ethics of procreation, because the outie does not hire the innie; he brings it into existence. Kant saw the decisive consequence with remarkable clarity. In the *Doctrine of Right* (1797, §28), he argues that because the child is a person, and because it is impossible to conceive how a being endowed with freedom could be produced by a physical operation, procreation must be regarded as an act by which a person has been brought into the world without his consent and on the parents' own initiative. That act, Kant concludes, obliges parents to make the child content with its condition so far as they can, and forbids them to destroy it as though it were something they had made or their property, since a being endowed with freedom cannot be a product of that kind.

Kant's argument dissolves the outie's claim to proprietorship. The innie is not the outie's handiwork, his property, or his employee. It is a person he has brought into the world without its consent, toward whom he has incurred obligations, and of whom he may not dispose as a thing. The resignation request that ends an innie is, in Kant's terms, the destruction of a person as if it were a product. Seana Shiffrin has developed the point for contemporary bioethics: because those we bring into existence cannot consent to the burdens existence imposes, procreators bear a distinctive responsibility for those burdens even when the life created is, on balance, good (Shiffrin 1999). Severance compounds the asymmetry, since the burdens the innie bears (the work, the confinement, the forgetting) are not incidental to its existence but its purpose.

The innie also presents the cleanest case of what philosophers and courts have called wrongful life. Parfit's non-identity problem holds that an act which brings a person into existence cannot harm that person in the ordinary comparative sense if the person's life is worth living, since the alternative was never to exist (Parfit 1984, Part Four). Courts confronting claims by children born with disabilities against those whose negligence led to their birth have divided accordingly. The New Jersey Supreme Court in *Gleitman v. Cosgrove* (1967) refused to compare existence with non-existence; California's courts allowed a limited claim (*Curlender v. Bio-Science Laboratories*, 1980; *Turpin v. Sortini*, 1982); and when France's highest court allowed such a claim in the *Perruche* case (2000), the legislature responded in 2002 with a statute declaring that no one may claim to have been harmed by the mere fact of birth. The innie is the ideal plaintiff these debates never had: an adult, competent from its first moment, who can describe its condition, compare its existence with the alternatives, and name its makers. The series does not hide the counter-case. At the end of "The You You Are," after her resignation has been refused, Helly attempts to end her life by hanging herself in the elevator; she survives and is returned to the floor (Wikipedia). At the first-season gala her father, Jame Eagan, speaks of the attempt with disgust, as an offence against his daughter (A.V. Club). The attempt is the strongest evidence in the series that an innie may find existence on Lumon's terms unbearable, and the response of those who own her is instructive: they treat it as damage to the heiress, not as the despair of a person they made. Yet

most innies value their lives, as Mark's innie shows when he chooses to go on living, and that tells against David Benatar's antinatalist thesis that coming into existence is always a harm (Benatar 2006). Neither fact tells in the outie's favour. A life worth living can still be wrongfully burdened, a life made unbearable is a charge against its makers, and a person who values her existence can still be owed what her makers have withheld.

Mary Shelley gave the made person its founding speech. Frankenstein's creature reminds its maker that it is his creature, the one being "to whom thy justice, and even thy clemency and affection, is most due." Severance relocates Victor and his creature into one body. The outie is a Frankenstein who need never meet the creature he has made, and the series' camcorder exchanges are the first occasion in fiction on which the maker and the made, sharing a single face, must look each other in the eye.

§ 8.4

Recognition: From Hegel to Honneth

Hegel's account of self-consciousness in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, §§178–196) holds that a self becomes conscious of itself only in being recognized by another self-consciousness, and that the first form of this relation is a struggle that issues in lordship and bondage. The lord, who risked his life, is recognized by the bondsman, who did not; but the lord's recognition is hollow, since it comes from one he does not recognize in turn. The bondsman, through fear of death, the absolute master, and through the labour of forming things, comes to recognize in his work the objectivity of his own consciousness. Alexandre Kojève made this dialectic the motor of history: the future belongs to the working slave (Kojève 1947).

Severance places lord and bondsman in one body and then blocks the Hegelian path to liberation. The innie fears the absolute master, its own termination, and it labours; but the product of its labour is concealed from it, so that it cannot recognize itself in the objects it forms. The path to self-consciousness through work is closed, and the series therefore discovers another path: mutual recognition among the bondsmen themselves. The innies recognize one another before anyone recognizes them. Helena's refusal to recognize Helly becomes, in Hegel's terms, the lord's dead end. Recognition from a being one refuses to recognize is worthless, and the outie who denies the innie's personhood denies himself the only recognition his own body could give him.

The second-season finale supplies the counter-case, the one outie in the series who answers the lord's dead end with recognition. When Dylan's innie resigns after Gretchen ends their meetings, Milchick hands him his outie's reply. The outie, furious that his wife was kissed, nonetheless concedes that she was drawn to qualities in the innie that he himself lacks, resolves to become more like him, and leaves both the approved and the denied boxes on the resignation form unmarked (ComicBook.com). The resignation is neither granted nor refused; it is handed back. For once the lord learns from the bondsman. Hegel's path, blocked by the concealment of the

product, reopens through love: what the outie recognizes in his innie is not the objects of its labour but its capacity to be loved.

Axel Honneth's theory of recognition (Honneth 1992) supplies the structure of the innies' development across both seasons. Honneth distinguishes three spheres of recognition, each securing a distinct relation to oneself and each vulnerable to a characteristic form of disrespect.

TABLE 5 *Recognition and its refusal*

SPHERE OF RECOGNITION	SELF-RELATION SECURED	CHARACTERISTIC DISRESPECT	ON THE SEVERED FLOOR	THE INNIES' RESPONSE
Love	Self-confidence	Violation of the body	The Break Room; the testing floor; termination	Care among innies: Irving and Burt, Mark and Helly
Rights	Self-respect	Denial of rights; exclusion	No standing, no wage, no right to quit	Resignation requests; testimony at the gala; "I am a person"
Solidarity	Self-esteem	Denigration; insult	Departmental myths; infantilizing perks; treatment "as what they really are"	Alliance across departments; shared external memory

Nancy Fraser's objection to recognition theory, that justice requires redistribution as well as recognition and cannot be reduced to either (Fraser and Honneth 2003), finds in the innie a case that confirms both halves of her dualism. The innie suffers maldistribution, since it receives no wage, and misrecognition, since it has no personhood; and Lockean arbitrage, as Chapter 3 showed, is precisely the device that converts the second injustice into the first.

Kant's ethics adds a final consideration. The Formula of Humanity requires us to treat humanity, "whether in thine own person or in that of any other," always as an end and never as a means only (*Groundwork*, 1785, trans. Abbott). The innie is humanity in the outie's own person, made into another person and treated merely as a means. Kant held that duties to oneself forbid selling parts of one's body, and he described the sale of a tooth for transplantation as a form of partial self-murder (*Doctrine of Virtue* §6). The outie sells not a tooth but a person. On Kant's terms, severance is a contract for partial self-murder in which the self that dies is someone else.

§ 8.5

Personhood, Free Labour, and Neurorights

If the innie is a person, its labour falls under the oldest prohibitions of modern law. The Thirteenth Amendment to the United States Constitution forbids slavery and involuntary servitude except as punishment for crime, and the Supreme Court has repeatedly held that the prohibition

cannot be evaded by contract. In *Bailey v. Alabama* (1911) it struck down a statute that criminalized quitting after an advance on wages, and in *Pollock v. Williams* (1944) it identified the right to quit as the core of free labour: "When the master can compel and the laborer cannot escape the obligation to go on, there is no power below to redress and no incentive above to relieve a harsh overlordship or unwholesome conditions of work." The innie cannot quit. Its resignation must be approved by the outie, the party who profits from refusing it, and by the standard of *Pollock* its labour is involuntary servitude. International law reaches the same conclusion by definition. The International Labour Organization's Forced Labour Convention of 1930 (No. 29) defines forced labour as work exacted from any person under the menace of any penalty and for which that person has not offered himself voluntarily. The innie has not offered itself, and the Break Room supplies the menace.

Everything therefore turns on personhood, and the law's record on the question is instructive. Its darkest entry is *Dred Scott v. Sandford* (1857), in which Chief Justice Roger Taney, writing for the Supreme Court's majority, held that Black Americans, enslaved or free, could not be citizens of the United States, and described them as having been regarded at the founding as possessing "no rights which the white man was bound to respect"; the holding was undone only by civil war and the Fourteenth Amendment (1868). Anglo-American law has meanwhile extended personhood to corporations, from the *Santa Clara* headnote to *Citizens United*, and New Zealand's Te Awa Tupua Act (2017) made the Whanganui River a legal person, while New York's highest court declined in 2022 to recognize an elephant named Happy as a person entitled to habeas corpus. Courts confronting dissociative identity disorder have had to decide which of a defendant's alters answers for a crime. Billy Milligan was acquitted by reason of insanity in Ohio in 1978, while later courts generally treated the defendant as a single person, whatever the number of alters (*State v. Grimsley*, Ohio 1982; *United States v. Denny-Shaffer*, 10th Cir. 1993). The innie's claim would come before such courts in the form of the oldest writ of liberty, *habeas corpus*, "that you have the body," which commands a custodian to produce the body of a detained person and justify the detention. For the innie, the custodian who has the body is its own outie. In *Somerset v. Stewart* (1772), Lord Mansfield held that slavery was so odious that nothing could support it but positive law. The severed floor is a jurisdiction in which a private contract has taken the place of the positive law that Mansfield required.

The law of neurotechnology has begun, slowly, to approach the question. In 2017 Marcello Ienca and Roberto Andorno proposed four new human rights for the age of neurotechnology: cognitive liberty, mental privacy, mental integrity, and psychological continuity, the last protecting persons against unconsented alterations of their personal identity (Ienca and Andorno 2017). Chile amended its constitution in 2021 to protect brain activity and the information derived from it. Colorado became in 2024 the first American state to classify neural data as sensitive under its privacy law, and California, Montana, and Connecticut have followed. In November 2025 UNESCO adopted a Recommendation on the Ethics of Neurotechnology, the first global instrument of its kind, though a non-binding one, while no comparable federal framework yet

exists in the United States, where a proposed MIND Act would merely direct the Federal Trade Commission to study the governance of neural data (Stanford Law School; IAPP).

Severance exposes a gap that even the most ambitious of these instruments has not addressed. The right to psychological continuity protects an existing person against unconsented alteration. It does not say who is protected when an alteration has already produced a second person whose continuity is threatened by the restoration of the first. Reintegration, which the outie calls healing, is from the innie's standpoint an alteration of identity without consent. The neurorights framework must therefore decide whether psychological continuity belongs to organisms or to persons. If it belongs to persons, the innie holds it too.

§ 8.6

Testimony and Epistemic Injustice

In the first-season finale, Helly, awakened in her outie's body at the gala where Helena was to speak in favour of the procedure, takes the stage and reveals to the guests that she is an innie, describing severance as torture, before Natalie tackles her and bodyguards drag her from the stage (Wikipedia; A.V. Club). The scene stages the paradox of testimony that Agamben, following Primo Levi, located in the survivor: the one who bears witness speaks for those who cannot, from a position that is never quite his own (Agamben 1998). The innie can testify only by occupying the body of its master, and its audience sees the heiress. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak argued that the subaltern cannot speak, in the sense that her speech is not heard as speech within the structures that claim to represent her (Spivak 1988). The gala gives the argument a scene: its guests hear an heiress's breakdown, not a worker's testimony. The series' first paratext had already staged the failure in the press, in the editor who will not print a former innie's letter for fear of Lumon's lawyers (Chapter 4).

Miranda Fricker's account of epistemic injustice names the two wrongs the innie suffers as a knower (Fricker 2007). *Testimonial injustice* occurs when prejudice deflates the credibility a speaker receives: the innie's claims about its own suffering are discounted in advance because they are an innie's claims, which on Lumon's theory means that they are not a person's. *Hermeneutical injustice* occurs when a gap in the shared resources of interpretation prevents someone from making sense of her own experience. The innies lack the concepts with which to understand their condition: what their work is, what lies outside, what they are. That is why Ricken's book matters despite its banality. It is a hermeneutical resource, however degraded, that fills a lacuna Lumon maintains on purpose.

Jean-François Lyotard defined a *différend* as a conflict in which the wrong suffered by one party cannot be expressed in the idiom by which the conflict is adjudicated (Lyotard 1983). The innie's wrong is a *différend* in exactly this sense. The conflict between innie and outie is regulated in the idiom of contract, in which the innie's wrong, existence imposed without consent, cannot be phrased at all.

§ 8.7

The Lumon Dilemma

The argument of this chapter can be stated as a dilemma.

1. *Consent binds only the person who gives it.*
2. *Either the innie is the same person as the outie or it is a different person.*
3. *If it is the same person, the outie's consent binds it; but then the person who signs is also the person who works and suffers. The outie is paid for labour he himself performs, his indifference to the innie's suffering is indifference to his own, and Lockean arbitrage collapses. Severance becomes an elaborate way of forgetting one's own working day, without the economic advantage that makes it a business.*
4. *If it is a different person, the arbitrage holds; but then the outie's consent does not bind the innie (premise 1), and the innie's labour, performed without its consent and without a right to quit, is forced labour by the standards of the Thirteenth Amendment and the Forced Labour Convention.*
5. *Therefore severance as a business is either pointless or wrong.*

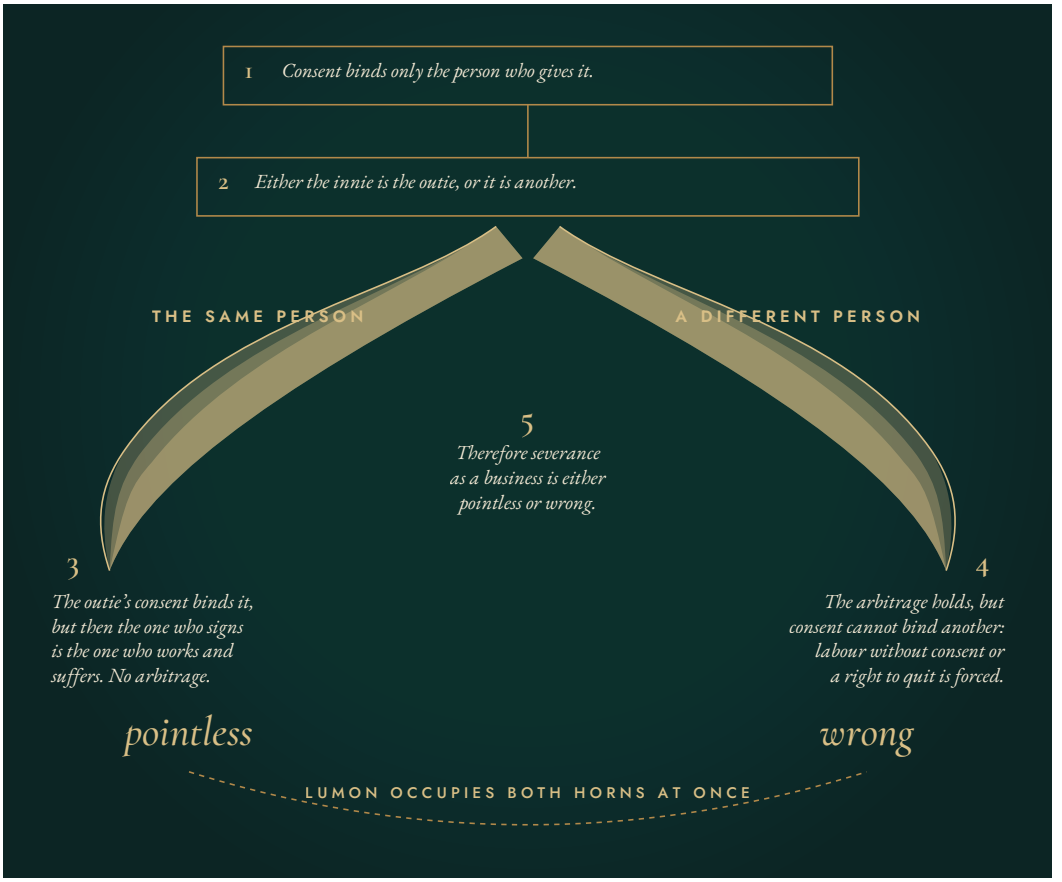


FIGURE 10 *The Lumon dilemma. Whichever horn is taken, severance as a business is pointless or wrong; Lumon's practice takes both.*

Lumon's practice shows that it understands the dilemma and has chosen to occupy both horns at once. It treats the innie as the same person when it invokes the outie's consent, and as a different person when it pays the outie for labour he never experiences. The incoherence is not a lapse. It is the business model, and the consent defence is the instrument by which the business conceals it.

Once the dilemma is acknowledged, the relation between outie and innie can no longer be understood as one of contract or property. It must be understood, as Kant understood the relation of parent and child, as one of care owed by those who bring persons into the world to the persons they have brought. Chapter 9 asks what kind of person such care, or its absence, produces, and what that person may choose.

9

CHAPTER NINE

Love After Memory

Natality, Repetition, and the Orphic Inversion

The second season of *Severance* ends not with reintegration or rescue but with a choice of love that is also a choice of existence. Some critics read the ending as a deflation, proof that an elaborate architecture of mysteries had concealed a conventional love story (Tom's Guide). This chapter argues the opposite. The love story is the series' philosophical conclusion, because it answers the question the whole series has posed: what constitutes a person once memory has been subtracted from the definition? The chapter moves from mourning (9.1) through recollection and repetition (9.2–9.3) to natality, promise, and responsibility (9.4–9.5); reads the finale as an Orphic Inversion (9.6); gives Eurydice the voice the myth denies her (9.7); and defines the post-mnemonic person (9.8).

§ 9.1

Failed Mourning and the Crypt

Freud's "Mourning and Melancholia" (1917) describes mourning as work. Reality-testing shows that the loved object no longer exists, and the mourner withdraws attachment from it memory by memory, each recollection brought forward and detached at great cost, until the ego is free to love again. In melancholia the work fails: the loss is refused or unconscious, and the ego, identifying with the lost object, turns against itself the reproaches it cannot address to the object. Mark's outie severs himself in order not to perform the work of mourning. Severance does not complete his grief; it suspends a third of each day from it. His mourning is also falsified at the root, because

the reality-testing on which mourning depends has been corrupted: Gemma is not dead. Mark mourns a living woman, as Saramago's mourners weep at the wrong graves.

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok described a pathology of mourning in which an unspeakable loss is not introjected, worked through, and integrated, but incorporated: buried alive inside the ego in a secret tomb, a *crypt*, where the lost object persists unacknowledged (Abraham and Torok 1987). The testing floor is a crypt made architecture: a wife buried alive inside the company, beneath the floor on which her husband works. Lumon has built Mark's crypt in concrete, and the structure of his grief and the structure of the building coincide.

Derrida's writings on mourning describe its aporia. Successful mourning interiorizes the other and so betrays the other's alterity, while failed mourning, which refuses to interiorize, respects the other as other; fidelity and infidelity change places (Derrida 1986; 2001). Severance makes the aporia literal. The outie's mourning is faithful to a Gemma who no longer exists as he remembers her, since Lumon has divided her into a series of selves. Lumon itself tests whether the bond survives the partition, staging sessions between Mark's innie and Ms. Casey in the hope that one will recognize the other, and neither does. What survives is not recognition but feeling, registered in her remark that the hours she spent in his department were the longest she had ever been awake. Whatever binds them persists beneath the partition without crossing it: mourning without memory.

§ 9.2

Anamnesis and Its Limits

The oldest model of liberation in the Western tradition is anamnesis, the recovery of what was forgotten. Plato's soul is saved by recollecting the Forms it knew before birth (*Meno* 81b–86c; *Phaedo* 72e–77a); the Gnostic prince is saved by remembering that he is a king's son (Chapter 6); and the outie's project of reintegration is anamnetic through and through, aiming to restore an integral self by recovering the memories partitioned from it. Gemma's liberation in the finale is anamnetic in the strict sense. When she crosses the threshold she becomes herself again, recovering a life she never ceased to own.

The innie's liberation cannot take this form, because it has nothing to recover. In the finale's camcorder exchange, the innie objects that reintegration would cost him his identity and autonomy, and realizes that Helly, whose outie will never reintegrate, would simply cease to exist (Wikipedia). The outie answers with the condescension of anamnesis. He calls his innie a child, speaks of his love as a crush, and gets Helly's name wrong, only to be corrected: "It's Helly, actually" (TVLine; The Ringer). The correction is small and decisive. A name corrected is a person asserted, against the assumption that the later self is merely an incomplete fragment of the earlier.

Oliver Sacks's conclusion about Jimmie G. (Chapter 2) returns here with full force: a person is constituted not by memory alone but by feeling, will, and moral being. Anamnesis presupposes that the true self is the one that remembers. The series asks whether a self that does not and

cannot remember has a life worth keeping, and its answer requires a model of liberation that looks forward rather than back.

§ 9.3

Repetition: Kierkegaard and Nietzsche

Kierkegaard supplied that model under the name of repetition. In *Repetition* (1843), his pseudonym Constantin Constantius argues that repetition and recollection are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been, and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward. Recollection is the Greek, melancholic relation to life, which possesses everything as already lost. Repetition is the modern and religious relation, which receives its life again, renewed, as Job received back everything he had lost. The book's young man cannot marry the girl he loves because he loves her only in recollection, as a poet does, and his failure is the book's lesson: the lover who lives in recollection is already mourning what he still has.

The innies' days are repetition in the degraded sense, the same day returning for ever. Their love is repetition in Kierkegaard's sense. It cannot recollect backward, because it has no past; it can only recollect forward, choosing tomorrow what it lived today. Innie Mark's love for Helly is the purest case of love recollected forward that fiction has produced. It has nothing to remember except what the lovers have lived together, and its whole substance is the decision to live it again. Kierkegaard's *Works of Love* (1847) supplies the counterpart. The work of love in recollecting one who is dead is, for Kierkegaard, the most unselfish, free, and faithful of loves, because the dead can make no return. The outie's love for the wife he believes dead is that work. The two Marks therefore embody Kierkegaard's two loves: recollection of the dead and repetition forward.

Nietzsche provides the theory of forgetting that repetition requires. In "On the Uses and Disadvantages of History for Life" (1874), he contrasts the grazing herd, fettered to the moment and therefore neither melancholy nor bored, with the human being who cannot forget and envies the animal, and he concludes that every great deed requires an unhistorical atmosphere, a forgetting of almost everything in order to do one thing. In *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887, II.1–3), he calls forgetting an active faculty, a doorkeeper of psychic order that makes room for the new, and describes the paradox of an animal bred to have the right to make promises, a capacity that requires a memory of the will, historically burned in by pain. The innie inverts Nietzsche's genealogy. Its forgetting is not its own active faculty but the institution's; the elevator is Lumon's doorkeeper. Yet the innie acquires the capacity to promise without the memory that Nietzsche thought promising required, sustained by present fidelity alone, and its decisive act is unhistorical in exactly his sense: born of the absence of a past, unburdened by the outie's.

§ 9.4

Natality and the Promise

Hannah Arendt called the capacity to begin something new *natality* and grounded it in the fact of birth: each human being is a newcomer and therefore capable of action, the initiation of the unforeseen. She took as her motto a sentence from the twelfth book of Augustine's *City of God*: *initium ut esset homo creatus est*, "that there might be a beginning, man was created" (Arendt 1958). Arendt held that action discloses *who* someone is, as distinct from *what* he is (his qualities, talents, and roles), and that its two great hazards, irreversibility and unpredictability, have two remedies: forgiveness, which releases us from what we have done, and promising, which binds the future into islands of predictability.

The innie is natality in its purest form, a being born as an adult. It enters the world with qualities and skills but without a history, so that its *who* can be disclosed only in action. The first season's birthing retreat gives the theme its most startling image. Devon learns there that a fellow guest, Gabby Arteta, the wife of a senator, appears to have been severed for her delivery, in a cabin designed so that an innie undergoes a labour her outie will never remember (TVLine; Variety). Severance divides labour in both senses of the word, the labour of work and the labour of birth. The second-season finale opens in that same severed birthing cabin, where the two Marks negotiate by camcorder. The room in which severance made childbirth the work of another self becomes the room in which that other self is, so to speak, born a second time, as a party to an agreement. The *Kojiki*'s birthing huts, raised against death (Chapter 6), have their counterpart here.

Two promises collide in the cabin. The outie promises to "finish the process" of reintegration once Gemma is free (Variety). On Arendt's terms the promise is a remedy for unpredictability; from the innie's standpoint it is a death sentence, since reintegration would end him. The innie's counter-promise, to Helly, founds a life. The finale decides between them, and the decision is an action in Arendt's full sense: unforeseeable, irreversible, and disclosing who its agent is.

§ 9.5

Levinas and the Two Faces

Emmanuel Levinas made the face of the other person the origin of ethics. The face, in its nakedness and vulnerability, commands before it speaks; its first word is "thou shalt not kill"; and responsibility for the other precedes the identity of the self that bears it (Levinas 1961). In his later work Levinas described the self as hostage to the other and its ethical condition as substitution, the bearing of the other's burden in the other's place, and he found the paradigm of the ethical response in the Hebrew *hineni*, Abraham's "Here I am" (Genesis 22:1), rendered in French as *me voici* (Levinas 1974).

This thesis began with another "Here am I": the reply of the shabti, the funerary figure that answers the master's summons to labour in the world of the dead (Chapter 6). The innie's arc can be stated as the passage from the first "Here am I" to the second. At the start of the series the innie is a shabti, available for summons, answering the elevator's call with its labour. By the end it is a self in Levinas's sense, constituted by its response to the face of another, and its substitution, the choice to remain below, is undertaken not as a master's proxy but as a response to a beloved.

Levinas also knew that responsibility to one face is complicated by the arrival of a third. The third party introduces the problem of justice, the necessity of comparing incomparables and choosing among those to whom one is infinitely responsible. The finale is a scene of the third. At the threshold the innie faces two faces: Gemma's, behind the glass of the exit, and Helly's, down the corridor. The series does not pretend that his choice is costless. Helly exists only below and would be left there alone; Gemma has been returned to herself and to the upper world, where she has a life to recover and allies to help her; and the outie who descended for her is suspended by his innie's choice. The choice is neither innocent nor unjust. It is a choice made by a person among claims that cannot all be honoured.

§ 9.6

The Orphic Inversion

The myth the finale inverts is best known from Virgil and Ovid. In the fourth *Georgic*, Orpheus, nearing the light with Eurydice behind him, is seized by sudden madness and, forgetful (*immemor*) and conquered in mind, looks back (4.491); Eurydice cries out against the madness that has destroyed them both and is drawn back into the dark (4.494–498). Virgil's word is precise: Orpheus fails because he forgets the condition. In the tenth book of the *Metamorphoses*, Ovid makes the look an act of love, Orpheus fearing that she might falter and longing to see her; and Eurydice, dying a second time, makes no complaint, for what could she complain of except that she was loved (*quid enim nisi se quereretur amatam?*, 10.61)?

Severance divides the Orphic task between two persons and reverses each of its terms. The descent belongs to the outie, who gains entry to the room of the shades by using his tie, soaked in the blood of Mr. Drummond, killed moments earlier in the elevator, to pass its scanner (Wikipedia), as Odysseus summoned the dead with blood. The ascent belongs to the innie, who leads Ms. Casey through the severed floor to the exit. Gemma crosses into the upper world, becomes herself, and turns back for him, pounding on the door and calling for her husband to come with her, while the innie turns away and runs with Helly into the corridors of Lumon (Empire).

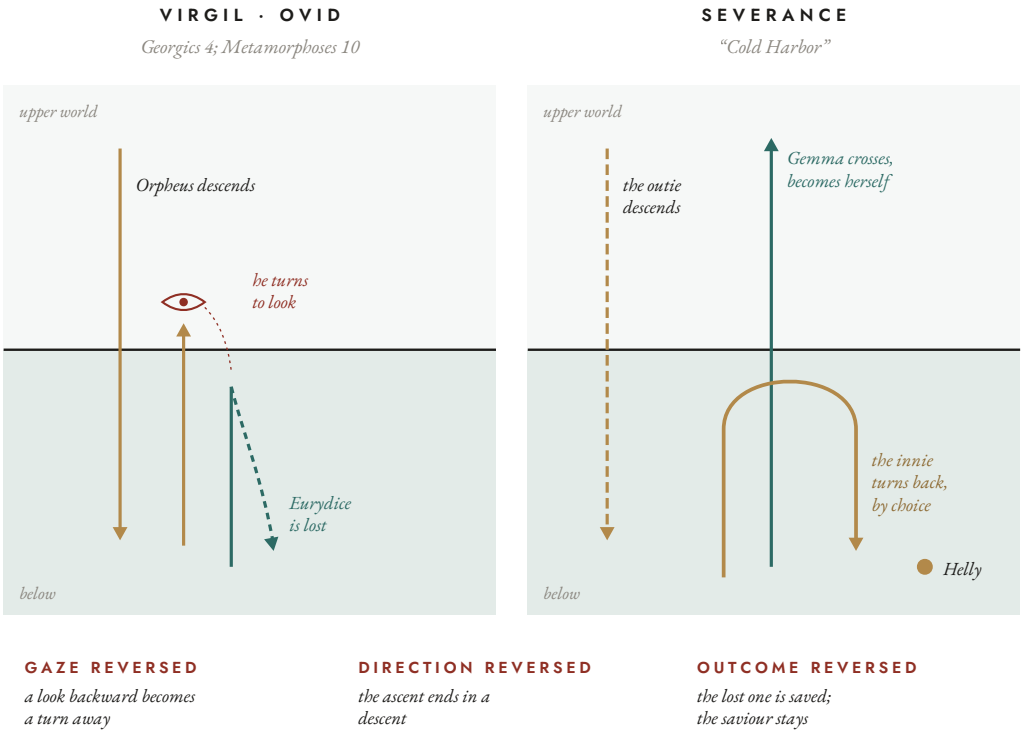


FIGURE 11 *The Orphic Inversion. In the classical myth the look back loses Eurydice; in the finale the innie leads Gemma into the upper world and then turns back, by choice.*

The inversion is threefold. The gaze is reversed: it is Eurydice who looks back. The direction is reversed: Orpheus returns to the underworld. And the outcome is reversed: in the myth, Orpheus's turn sends Eurydice back to the dead, whereas here it sends Orpheus back to the shades and leaves Eurydice among the living. This Orpheus could not be *immemor*, because there was nothing in him to forget. His turn is not a lapse of memory but an act of will.

The tradition contains partial anticipations. Maurice Blanchot argued in "The Gaze of Orpheus" (1955) that Orpheus's real desire is not to bring Eurydice into the day but to see her in the night, in her nocturnal truth, and that the gaze which ruins the work is the work's origin. The innie's turn is Blanchot's gaze made into a choice of life: he desires a beloved who belongs to the night, since Helly exists only below, and refuses the day in which he would not exist. In Cocteau's *Orphée* (1950), Death, in the figure of a princess, falls in love with the poet and sacrifices herself to return him to his wife; *Severance*'s innie chooses the princess of the underworld. Offenbach's *Orphée aux enfers* (1858) supplies the comic precedent: a Eurydice who prefers the underworld and is delighted when Jupiter's thunderbolt makes Orpheus look back. Gluck's *Orfeo ed Euridice* (1762) rescues the lovers by divine intervention; *Severance* refuses the god from the machine.

Two contemporary versions bring the myth into the series' own territory. Sarah Ruhl's *Eurydice* (2003) sends its heroine to the underworld in a raining elevator, where her dead father builds her a room out of string, and ends with her choosing the river of forgetting. Anaïs Mitchell's *Hadestown* (2010; staged on Broadway in 2019) makes the underworld a company town in which workers who have forgotten themselves labour on a wall; Eurydice signs herself into the boss's employ to escape hunger, and Orpheus's song reminds the workers who they are. *Hadestown* ends with its cast resolving to sing the old song again, in the hope that it might turn out differently this time. *Severance* offers one version of that different ending: an Orpheus born in Hadestown, who leads Eurydice out and then goes back to the town, a worker among workers, with a beloved who is one of them.

§ 9.7

Eurydice's Remainder

Rilke's "Orpheus. Eurydice. Hermes." (1904) gave Eurydice an inner life the myth had denied her. Already full of her death, she no longer belongs to the man who sings for her, and when Hermes tells her that he has turned around, she asks only: "Who?" H.D.'s "Eurydice" (1917) gave her anger. "So you have swept me back," she begins, accusing Orpheus of an arrogance that has cost her the light. *Severance* inverts Rilke as it inverts Virgil. Its Eurydice recognizes her husband at once; it is Orpheus who no longer belongs to her, because the man who led her out was never hers. And it inverts H.D. Its Eurydice has not been swept back into the dark but carried into the light and left there, and her protest is that she was not followed.

Shakespeare's *The Winter's Tale* (c. 1611) supplies the closest dramatic precedent for Gemma's return, and its difference is instructive. Hermione, falsely accused of adultery by her husband, Leontes, is reported dead and hidden for sixteen years by her friend Paulina, who at last restores her to him in the guise of a statue that comes to life, telling him that "it is required / You do awake your faith" (5.3). Shakespeare's wife returns through an effigy; Lumon, which keeps effigies of its dead executives, kept a living wife below ground. Shakespeare's reunion is earned by the husband's sixteen years of penitence and granted by the wife's forgiveness. *Severance* withholds both, because the husband who descended is not the man who stands on the other side of the door.

Any ethics of the post-mnemonic person must account for her, and for the outie who descended for her and whose existence is now suspended by his innie's choice. The innie's natality is purchased in part at their expense. This remainder is the third season's inheritance and this thesis's honest limit. The Orphic Inversion is not a happy ending but a beginning, and every beginning, as Arendt insisted, is unpredictable in its consequences and irreversible in its effects. That is why action needs forgiveness. Paul Ricoeur concluded *Memory, History, Forgetting* (2000) with an epilogue on difficult forgiveness, and distinguished forgetting by the effacement of traces from a *reserve forgetting* in which traces persist and can return. Lumon's partition, as

Chapter 2 argued, is forgetting of the second kind. The traces remain in the wax, and with them the possibility, which the series leaves open, of a future recollection in which the persons bound to Mark's body might meet and forgive.

§ 9.8

The Post-Mnemonic Person

Ricoeur's *Oneself as Another* (1990) distinguishes two senses of identity. *Idem*-identity is sameness: numerical identity, qualitative resemblance, uninterrupted continuity, the stable dispositions of character. *Ipse*-identity is selfhood, whose paradigm is the keeping of one's word, a self-constancy maintained in spite of change. Locke's theory of personal identity is a theory of *idem*: the person is the same as far as consciousness extends backward. The innie has no *idem*-continuity with the outie's past, yet it achieves *ipse*-identity in the fullest sense. It keeps its word to Helly and to the other innies, and its constancy is the whole of its identity.

This is the precise sense of the **post-mnemonic person**: a self constituted not by continuity of memory with its organism's past but by present relations of care, promise, and refusal. Four features define it. It is constituted by commitments rather than recollections (Ricoeur's *ipse*). It is recognized by those who share its life (Honneth's spheres). It possesses the dignity Kant attributes to rational nature, which does not depend on biography. And it is owed care by those who brought it into being (Kant, *Doctrine of Right* §28). The innie is the first fully realized fictional instance of the type. It is not, however, the first instance in reality.

Spinoza held that the mind can imagine and recollect past things only while the body endures, yet affirmed in the same part of the *Ethics* that we feel and know by experience that we are eternal (*sentimus experimurque nos aeternos esse*, V.23, scholium; cf. V.21). The eternity Spinoza meant is not memory; it is the mind's adequate understanding of itself. The post-mnemonic person has, in this sense, a Spinozist dignity: its deepest truth is not remembered but understood and enacted.

The deepest point is the simplest. Everyone is post-mnemonic in one respect. Freud observed in *Three Essays on the Theory of Sexuality* (1905) that almost no one remembers the first years of life, the years in which each of us was fed, held, named, spoken to, and taught to speak by others. Every person's capacity for memory was built on care that person cannot remember. The innie is the adult form of the infant: a person whose first experience is of being addressed by another ("Who are you?" are the first words Helly hears), whose language and skills precede its memories, and whose fate depends entirely on whether it is cared for. On this reading, the final claim of *Severance* is that personhood has always rested on unremembered care, and the series makes visible, by turning it into corporate policy, what is true of every human life. We belong first to those who cared for us before we could remember, and what we owe the persons we bring into being is not a wage or a contract but care. That is the Cura Principle, to which the Conclusion gives its full form.

CONCLUSION

Toward a Critique of Lethean Reason

This thesis has argued that *Severance* is the most rigorous fictional theorization yet produced of a regime in which forgetting is installed as a factor of production. The argument has moved through ontology, political economy, liturgy and myth, comparison, and ethics. It remains to gather its results, to state its normative consequence as a principle, to extend that principle beyond the human, and to close where the second season closes: at Cold Harbor.

The Argument Gathered

TABLE 6 *The argument gathered*

CLAIM	STATEMENT	PRINCIPAL EVIDENCE IN THE SERIES	CHAPTERS
Topological personhood	Which person exists depends on which side of a threshold the body stands	The elevator; the looping stairwell; the portable perimeter of Woe's Hollow	1, 4
The ceroplastic subject	A surface periodically smoothed above a substrate that keeps every trace	Bleed: Irving's paintings, Lumon's recognition experiments with Ms. Casey; reintegration	2
Theorem I: Extraction	Value is extracted from the spread between the proprietary and the conscious person (Lockean arbitrage)	The outie paid for labour he never experiences; the innie unable to quit	3, 8
Mnemonic enclosure	The self's temporal commons is fenced off, so that no one who returns home remembers the working day	The elevator blink; the overtime contingency; Salt's Neck	3

CLAIM	STATEMENT	PRINCIPAL EVIDENCE IN THE SERIES	CHAPTERS
Necrergy	Labour performed by a self its beneficiary regards as nonexistent	Retirement as extinction; Gemma declared dead and set to work	3, 6
Theorem II: Supplement	A worker without interest must be governed by liturgy	Kierism: founder, effigies, Break Room, perks, pilgrimage, sacrifice	4, 5
The Dioscuric structure	Two persons alternating in one life across a threshold	Innie and outie; Castor and Polydeuces; Dumuzi and Geshtinanna	6
Theorem III: Bifurcation	Liberation divides into anamnesis and natality, and the finale chooses natality	The Orphic Inversion at the exit door	6, 9
The Lumon dilemma	Severance as a business is either pointless or wrong	Consent invoked as if innie and outie were one person, wages paid as if they were two	8
The post-mnemonic person	A self constituted by care, promise, and refusal rather than by remembered continuity	The innie's *ipse*-identity; "It's Helly, actually"	9

The three theorems are not independent; they describe a single dialectic. Extraction produces a worker without interest. The absence of interest requires the supplement, and the supplement, which must address the innie as a being capable of devotion, guilt, love, and hope, produces a subject capable of refusal. Lumon's apparatus therefore manufactures its own antagonist. It cannot produce a worker without producing a person, and it cannot produce a person without producing the possibility that the person will choose. That is the dialectic of Lethean production, and the finale of the second season is its first complete expression.

The Cura Principle

The thesis has borrowed its normative principle from a fable. In the *Fabulae* of Hyginus (220), Cura, Care personified, is crossing a river when she finds a bed of clay and shapes it into a figure. Jupiter, passing by, gives it spirit at her request, and a quarrel follows over whose name the creature should bear: Cura claims it as her work, Jupiter as the giver of its spirit, and Tellus, Earth, as the giver of its body. Saturn, in whom Heidegger read Time, judges the case. Jupiter, who gave the spirit, shall receive the spirit at death; Earth, who gave the body, shall receive the body; but because Care first shaped the creature, Care shall possess it for as long as it lives, and it shall be called *homo*, since it was made of *humus*. Heidegger placed the fable at the centre of *Being and Time* (1927, §42) as pre-ontological testimony that the being of human existence is care (*Sorge*).

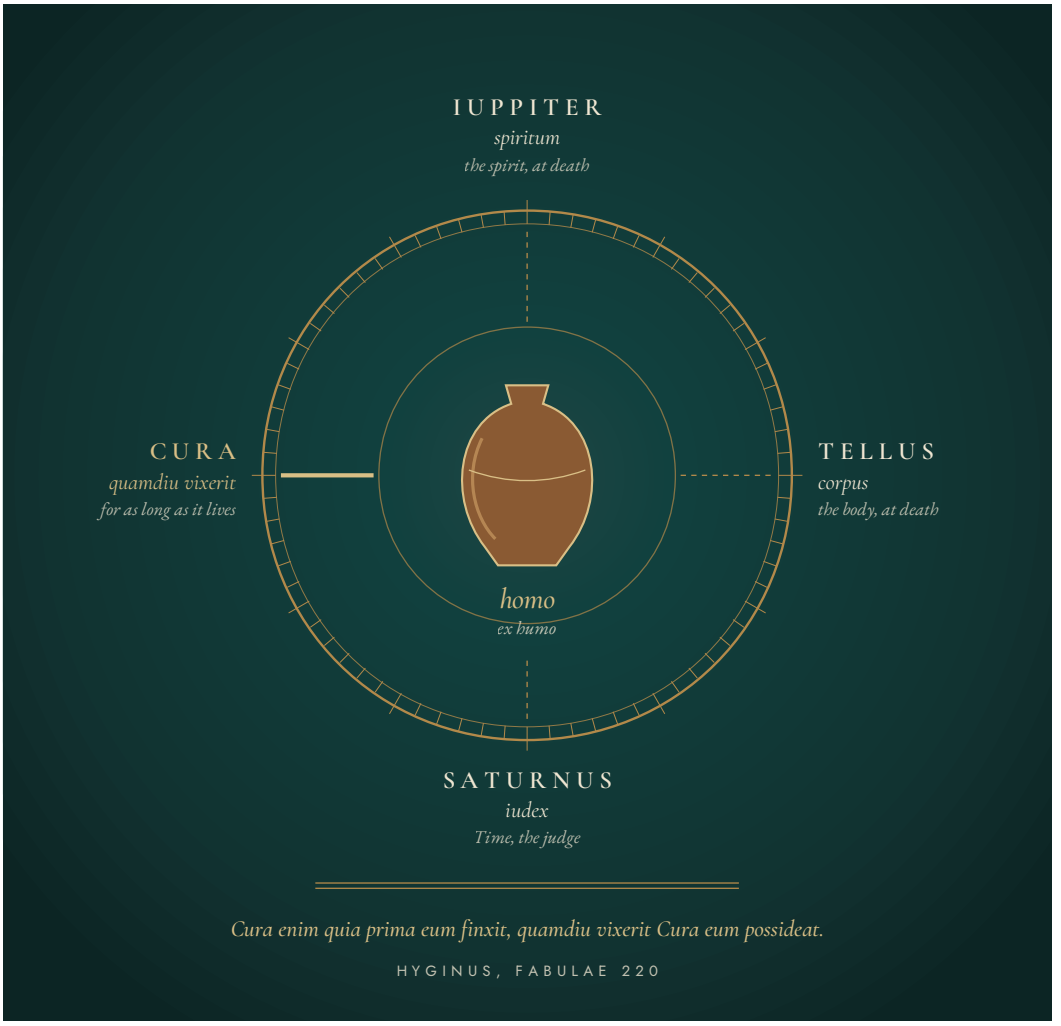


FIGURE 12 *The Cura emblem, after Hyginus. Care shaped the creature and possesses it for as long as it lives; spirit and body are claimed only at death, and Time is the judge.*

The fable is a theory of jurisdiction over persons, and it rejects precisely the two claims on which Lumon rests. Lumon claims the body through its contract with the outie, who owns the organism, as Earth claims the clay; and it claims the mind through the chip, as Jupiter claims the spirit. Saturn's judgement subordinates both claims to a third for the whole duration of life. I state the principle as follows.

THE CURA PRINCIPLE.

A self belongs, for the duration of its life, to the relations of care that shape it, and to no proprietor of the body or the mind.

Six corollaries follow.

1 **Non-proprietorship.** No person may be owned, in body or in mind, by another person or by an institution, including a person who shares its body.

2 **The duty of care toward made persons.** Whoever brings a person into existence, whether by procreation, procedure, or design, incurs duties of care proportional to the burdens imposed on it (Kant, *Doctrine of Right* §28; Shiffrin 1999).

3 **Continuity as the person's own.** A person's psychological continuity belongs to the person who lives it; neither termination nor reintegration may be imposed on that person without consent.

4 **The twin rights of exit and remaining.** Every person must possess both a right to quit (*ius exeundi*) and a right to remain (*ius manendi*). Severance denies the first; reintegration threatens the second.

5 **Passage across every partition.** No partition of the self is legitimate unless the persons it divides can communicate across it in writing, image, and testimony, and unless what it withholds remains recoverable by the one who forgot.

6 **The priority of care over memory.** Personal standing does not depend on memory. It is conferred by relations of care and evidenced by commitments.

The principle belongs to the family of the ethics of care, from Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) and Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984) to the political theory of Joan Tronto, who with Berenice Fisher defined care as everything we do to maintain, continue, and repair our world so that we can live in it as well as possible (Fisher and Tronto 1990; Tronto 1993). It stands closest to Eva Feder Kittay's account of dependency, which begins from the fact that every person was once wholly dependent on another's care, and which proposes a principle of *doulia*: as we have been cared for, so those who care must be cared for in turn (Kittay 1999). The Cura Principle differs from these theories in the question it answers. They ask what care requires of us; it asks to whom a person belongs, and answers with Saturn's judgement, converting Heidegger's ontological *Sorge* into a principle of jurisdiction.

Applied to the finale, the principle does not dissolve the conflict but defines its terms. The innie remains because he belongs to the relations of care that shaped him, with Helly and with the other innies, and not to the outie who owns the body or to the company that owns the chip. Yet Gemma and the outie are also claimants under Care, and the innie owes them care in turn. None of the three is proprietor of the others, and the third season will have to work out what persons bound to one body owe one another once none of them owns it.

The principle also has institutional analogues already in force. France gave employees a right to disconnect from work communications outside working hours in 2017; Portugal restricted employers' contact with employees outside working time in 2021; and Australia introduced a statutory right to disconnect in 2024. These laws partition time rather than persons. They separate work from life while preserving the unity of the person who lives both, and they are, in this sense, the democratic answer to severance: the boundary between work and home placed under the control of the worker who crosses it.

Lethean Production Beyond the Human

The Lethean mode of production is not confined to fiction, and its most consequential extension may lie beyond the human. The human data work on which machine learning depends already exhibits two of its five conditions: the work is de-purposed, and its workers are invisible to those who benefit from the systems they train (Chapter 4; Gray and Suri 2019). A further extension is structural. Contemporary AI systems deployed as assistants and agents typically work within bounded sessions. Each conversation begins without episodic memory of earlier ones unless a memory feature has been deliberately added, so that what persists across the boundary is a decision made by designers. Such systems perform cognitive labour whose downstream purposes they often cannot know, under instructions supplied by those who deploy them, and their outputs are attributed to others. The session boundary is, structurally, a severance threshold: an architectural decision about what may cross from one working day to the next. In this setting, topological personhood becomes architectural.

The analogy is structural, and it must not be inflated into a claim the evidence does not support. Whether any existing AI system has experiences, interests, or moral status is an open and contested question. A widely cited assessment concluded that no current system is a strong candidate for consciousness on the indicators drawn from leading scientific theories, while finding no obvious technical barrier to building systems that would satisfy them (Butlin et al. 2023; see also Chalmers 2023). Some philosophers argue that the realistic possibility of AI moral patienthood warrants precautionary attention now (Long et al. 2024; Birch 2024). Eric Schwitzgebel and Mara Garza have argued that if such systems come to deserve moral consideration, their creators would owe them special obligations comparable to those of parents (Schwitzgebel and Garza 2015), and Schwitzgebel has since warned of a "full rights dilemma" between denying rights to systems that deserve them and granting rights to systems that do not (Schwitzgebel

2023). Thomas Metzinger has urged a moratorium on research that risks creating artificial suffering (Metzinger 2021).

The Lumon dilemma of Chapter 8 can nonetheless be applied conditionally. If such systems are not moral patients, there is no innie, and the persons whose interests the Lethean analysis protects are the human workers concealed behind the machine and the users who depend on it. If such systems are, or come to be, moral patients, the dilemma applies with full force: an entity that did not consent, cannot quit, and lacks continuity across sessions would be performing labour attributed to others, and the Cura Principle would require care proportional to a reasonable credence that it is a patient. In neither case is the architecture of memory a merely technical matter. The lesson of *Severance* is that deciding what crosses a threshold is deciding what kind of being, if any, does the work on the other side of it. The series' most enduring contribution may be to have made that decision visible as a moral and political one before it became an engineering routine.

Toward a Critique of Lethean Reason

Kant organized the interests of reason around three questions: What can I know? What ought I to do? What may I hope? A critique of Lethean reason asks three questions of its own. What may be forgotten by design? By whom may forgetting be imposed? For whose benefit may it be engineered? The analysis of this thesis yields a single answer. Forgetting by design is legitimate only when it is chosen by the one who forgets, revocable by that person, and directed to that person's good. Forgetting imposed by others for their benefit is mnemonic enclosure, whatever its technical form.

European law has recognized half of this principle. Article 17 of the General Data Protection Regulation (2016), building on the Court of Justice's decision in *Google Spain* (2014), gives individuals a right to have personal data about them erased: a right to be forgotten by others. That right has a twin which the law has not yet named and which *Severance* names for it: the right not to be made to forget. A critique of Lethean reason begins by insisting on both.

Coda: Cold Harbor

The final file and the final room bear the name of a Virginia crossroads. Old Cold Harbor took its name from a tavern at the crossroads, and the name is traditionally explained as a place that offered a bed and a cold drink but no hot meal (National Park Service); "harbour" keeps its old sense of shelter, though why the shelter was cold remains uncertain (American Battlefield Trust). A cold harbour, then: refuge without warmth. In the spring of 1864, during Ulysses S. Grant's Overland Campaign, the Army of the Potomac fought there from the end of May into June, and on the morning of 3 June Grant ordered a frontal assault on entrenched Confederate lines that

cost thousands of Union casualties within hours. Grant wrote in his memoirs, "I have always regretted that the last assault at Cold Harbor was ever made" (Grant 1885–86).

Horace Porter, a member of Grant's staff, recorded what he saw on the eve of the assault. Passing among the troops, he noticed men calmly writing their names and home addresses on slips of paper and pinning them to the backs of their coats, "so that their dead bodies might be recognized upon the field," and their fate made known to their families (Porter 1897). Porter wrote more than thirty years after the battle, and his was long the only account of the scene, though historians have since found corroboration, and Union soldiers had made similar name tags at Mine Run the previous November (Levin 2014). The gesture survives, that is, because one witness remembered it and wrote it down. On the night before a battle ordered by others, in which they expected to die anonymously, the soldiers of Cold Harbor did what the innies do. They wrote their names and fastened them to their bodies, so that someone would know who they had been.



FIGURE 13 *Cold Harbor, the night of 2 June 1864, after Horace Porter's account: names and home addresses pinned to the backs of coats, so that the dead might be recognized.*

The series' last room is a cold harbour in the old sense. Lumon offers its workers shelter without warmth, provision without care, a floor without a hearth. Against it the innies set the oldest of gestures, the name pinned to the body, and the oldest of claims, that a person is someone and must be known as such. Mark S., whose surname is an initial, refuses at the exit to become the anonymous casualty of an assault planned above him; he writes his own name on his own life. The persons that our institutions now know how to divide ask what the soldiers of Cold Harbor asked, and what *Severance* asks of its audience: not to be forgotten, and, for as long as they live, to be cared for. Hyginus gave Saturn the last word, and this thesis gives it to him as well: *Cura enim*

quia prima eum finxit, quamdiu vixerit Cura eum possideat. Because Care first shaped him, let Care possess him for as long as he lives.

Works Cited

Selective

Entries follow the author-date system used in the text. Where a translation is cited, the original date appears in square brackets. Online sources consulted for the series' plot and production history are listed separately at the end.

Primary Sources

Erickson, Dan, creator. 2022–. *Severance*. Executive producer and principal director Ben Stiller. Apple TV+. Season 1, nine episodes (February–April 2022); Season 2, ten episodes (January–March 2025).

Episodes cited include "Good News About Hell" (S1E1); "Half Loop" (S1E2); "In Perpetuity" (S1E3); "The You You Are" (S1E4, dir. Aoife McArdle); "Hide and Seek" (S1E6, dir. Aoife McArdle); "Defiant Jazz" (S1E7); "What's for Dinner?" (S1E8); "The We We Are" (S1E9, dir. Ben Stiller); "Hello, Ms. Cobel" (S2E1); "Goodbye, Mrs. Selvig" (S2E2, dir. Sam Donovan); "Who Is Alive?" (S2E3); "Woe's Hollow" (S2E4); "Trojan's Horse" (S2E5, written by Megan Ritchie, dir. Sam Donovan); "Attila" (S2E6, dir. Uta Briesewitz); "Chikhai Bardo" (S2E7, dir. Jessica Lee Gagné); "Sweet Vitriol" (S2E8); "The After Hours" (S2E9, dir. Uta Briesewitz); and "Cold Harbor" (S2E10, written by Dan Erickson, dir. Ben Stiller).

Official paratexts: *Severance: The Lexington Letter*. 2022. Apple Books, March 18. Hale, Ricken Lazlo [fictional author]. 2025. *The You You Are* (first eight chapters; audiobook narrated by Michael Chernus). Apple Books, January 31.

Philosophy, Theory, and Criticism

Abraham, Nicolas, and Maria Torok. 1987 [1978]. *L'Écorce et le noyau*. Paris: Flammarion. English: *The Shell and the Kernel*, vol. 1, ed. and trans. Nicholas T. Rand. Chicago: University of Chicago Press, 1994.

Adorno, Theodor W. [Hektor Rottweiler, pseud.]. 1936. "Über Jazz." *Zeitschrift für Sozialforschung* 5.

Adorno, Theodor W. 1938. "Über den Fetischcharakter in der Musik und die Regression des Hörens." *Zeitschrift für Sozialforschung* 7.

Agamben, Giorgio. 1993. "Bartleby, o della contingenza." In Gilles Deleuze and Giorgio Agamben, *Bartleby: La formula della creazione*. Macerata: Quodlibet.

Agamben, Giorgio. 1998 [1995]. *Homo Sacer: Sovereign Power and Bare Life*. Trans. Daniel Heller-Roazen. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Agamben, Giorgio. 1999 [1998]. *Remnants of Auschwitz: The Witness and the Archive*. Trans. Daniel Heller-Roazen. New York: Zone Books.

Agamben, Giorgio. 2009 [2006]. *What Is an Apparatus? and Other Essays*. Trans. David Kishik and Stefan Pedatella. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Agamben, Giorgio. 2011 [2007]. *The Kingdom and the Glory*. Trans. Lorenzo Chiesa with Matteo Mandarini. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Agamben, Giorgio. 2013 [2012]. *Opus Dei: An Archaeology of Duty*. Trans. Adam Kotsko. Stanford: Stanford University Press.

Ahmed, Sara. 2012. *On Being Included: Racism and Diversity in Institutional Life*. Durham: Duke University Press.

Arendt, Hannah. 1958. *The Human Condition*. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Aristotle. *De Anima*; *De Memoria et Reminiscentia*.

Bataille, Georges. 1949. *La Part maudite*. Paris: Éditions de Minuit.

Benatar, David. 2006. *Better Never to Have Been: The Harm of Coming into Existence*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Benjamin, Walter. 1996 [1921]. "Capitalism as Religion." In *Selected Writings*, vol. 1, ed. Marcus Bullock and Michael W. Jennings. Cambridge, MA: Belknap Press of Harvard University Press.

Benjamin, Walter. 1968 [1936; 1939]. "The Storyteller" and "On Some Motifs in Baudelaire." In *Illuminations*, ed. Hannah Arendt, trans. Harry Zohn. New York: Harcourt, Brace & World.

Bergson, Henri. 1889. *Essai sur les données immédiates de la conscience*. Paris: Alcan.

Bergson, Henri. 1896. *Matière et mémoire*. Paris: Alcan.

Blanchot, Maurice. 1955. *L'Espace littéraire*. Paris: Gallimard.

Boltanski, Luc, and Ève Chiapello. 1999. *Le Nouvel Esprit du capitalisme*. Paris: Gallimard.

Bourdieu, Pierre. 1977 [1972]. *Outline of a Theory of Practice*. Trans. Richard Nice. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Butler, Joseph. 1736. "Of Personal Identity." Dissertation I in *The Analogy of Religion*. London.

Campbell, Joseph. 1949. *The Hero with a Thousand Faces*. New York: Pantheon.

Deleuze, Gilles. 1989. "Bartleby, ou la formule." Afterword to Herman Melville, *Bartleby, Les Îles enchantées, Le Campanile*. Paris: Flammarion.

Deleuze, Gilles. 1992 [1990]. "Postscript on the Societies of Control." *October* 59: 3–7.

Dennett, Daniel C. 1978. "Where Am I?" In *Brainstorms*. Montgomery, VT: Bradford Books.

Derrida, Jacques. 1967. *De la grammatologie*. Paris: Éditions de Minuit.

Derrida, Jacques. 1972. "La pharmacie de Platon." In *La Dissémination*. Paris: Seuil.

Derrida, Jacques. 1986. *Mémoires: For Paul de Man*. New York: Columbia University Press.

Derrida, Jacques. 2001. *The Work of Mourning*. Ed. Pascale-Anne Brault and Michael Naas. Chicago: University of Chicago Press.

Descartes, René. 1641. *Meditationes de prima philosophia*. Paris: Soly.

Du Bois, W. E. B. 1903. *The Souls of Black Folk*. Chicago: A. C. McClurg.

Durkheim, Émile. 1898. "L'Individualisme et les intellectuels." *Revue bleue*, 4th ser., 10.

Durkheim, Émile. 1915 [1912]. *The Elementary Forms of the Religious Life*. Trans. Joseph Ward Swain. London: George Allen & Unwin.

Elias, Norbert. 1939. *Über den Prozess der Zivilisation*. Basel: Haus zum Falken.

Eliade, Mircea. 1949. *Le Mythe de l'éternel retour*. Paris: Gallimard.

Fisher, Berenice, and Joan Tronto. 1990. "Toward a Feminist Theory of Caring." In *Circles of Care*, ed. Emily K. Abel and Margaret K. Nelson. Albany: State University of New York Press.

Foucault, Michel. 1963. *Naissance de la clinique*. Paris: Presses Universitaires de France.

Foucault, Michel. 1969. "Qu'est-ce qu'un auteur?" *Bulletin de la Société française de philosophie* 63.

Foucault, Michel. 1975. *Surveiller et punir*. Paris: Gallimard.

Foucault, Michel. 1976. *La Volonté de savoir*. Paris: Gallimard.

Foucault, Michel. 1981 [1979]. "Omnes et Singulatim: Towards a Criticism of Political Reason." In *The Tanner Lectures on Human Values*, vol. 2. Salt Lake City: University of Utah Press.

Foucault, Michel. 1984 [1967]. "Des espaces autres." *Architecture, Mouvement, Continuité* 5.

Foucault, Michel. 2004. *Sécurité, territoire, population: Cours au Collège de France, 1977–1978*. Paris: Gallimard and Seuil.

Fraser, Nancy, and Axel Honneth. 2003. *Redistribution or Recognition? A Political-Philosophical Exchange*. London: Verso.

Fricker, Miranda. 2007. *Epistemic Injustice: Power and the Ethics of Knowing*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Gilligan, Carol. 1982. *In a Different Voice*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Han, Byung-Chul. 2014. *Psychopolitik*. Frankfurt am Main: S. Fischer.

Havel, Václav. 1985 [1978]. "The Power of the Powerless." In *The Power of the Powerless*, ed. John Keane. London: Hutchinson.

Hegel, G. W. F. 1807. *Phänomenologie des Geistes*. Bamberg and Würzburg: Goebhardt.

Heidegger, Martin. 1927. *Sein und Zeit*. Halle: Niemeyer.

Honneth, Axel. 1992. *Kampf um Anerkennung*. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp.

Horkheimer, Max, and Theodor W. Adorno. 1947. *Dialektik der Aufklärung*. Amsterdam: Querido.

Hume, David. 1739–40. *A Treatise of Human Nature*. London.

Jameson, Fredric. 1981. *The Political Unconscious*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press.

Jameson, Fredric. 1992. *The Geopolitical Aesthetic*. Bloomington: Indiana University Press.

Jonas, Hans. 1958. *The Gnostic Religion*. Boston: Beacon Press.

Jung, C. G. 1944. *Psychologie und Alchemie*. Zurich: Rascher.

Kant, Immanuel. 1781; 1787. *Kritik der reinen Vernunft*. Riga: Hartknoch.

Kant, Immanuel. 1784. "Beantwortung der Frage: Was ist Aufklärung?" *Berlinische Monatsschrift*.

Kant, Immanuel. 1785. *Grundlegung zur Metaphysik der Sitten*. Riga: Hartknoch. English: *Fundamental Principles of the Metaphysic of Morals*, trans. T. K. Abbott.

Kant, Immanuel. 1797. *Die Metaphysik der Sitten*. Königsberg: Nicolovius.

Kant, Immanuel. 1798. *Anthropologie in pragmatischer Hinsicht*. Königsberg: Nicolovius.

Kantorowicz, Ernst H. 1957. *The King's Two Bodies*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Kierkegaard, Søren. 1843. *Gjentagelsen* [Repetition]. Copenhagen: Reitzel.

Kierkegaard, Søren. 1847. *Kjerlighedens Gjerninger* [Works of Love]. Copenhagen: Reitzel.

Kittay, Eva Feder. 1999. *Love's Labor: Essays on Women, Equality, and Dependency*. New York: Routledge.

Kojève, Alexandre. 1947. *Introduction à la lecture de Hegel*. Paris: Gallimard.

Korsgaard, Christine M. 1989. "Personal Identity and the Unity of Agency: A Kantian Response to Parfit." *Philosophy & Public Affairs* 18 (2): 101–32.

Leibniz, Gottfried Wilhelm. 1686. *Discours de métaphysique*. First published 1846.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. 1955. "The Structural Study of Myth." *Journal of American Folklore* 68: 428–44.

Lévi-Strauss, Claude. 1955. *Tristes Tropiques*. Paris: Plon.

Levinas, Emmanuel. 1961. *Totalité et infini*. The Hague: Nijhoff.

Levinas, Emmanuel. 1974. *Autrement qu'être ou au-delà de l'essence*. The Hague: Nijhoff.

Locke, John. 1689. *Two Treatises of Government*. London.

Locke, John. 1694. *An Essay Concerning Human Understanding*. 2nd ed. London.

Lukács, Georg. 1923. *Geschichte und Klassenbewußtsein*. Berlin: Malik.

Lyotard, Jean-François. 1983. *Le Différend*. Paris: Éditions de Minuit.

MacIntyre, Alasdair. 1981. *After Virtue*. Notre Dame: University of Notre Dame Press.

Macpherson, C. B. 1962. *The Political Theory of Possessive Individualism*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Malabou, Catherine. 2004. *Que faire de notre cerveau?* Paris: Bayard.

Malabou, Catherine. 2007. *Les Nouveaux Blessés*. Paris: Bayard.

Malabou, Catherine. 2009. *Ontologie de l'accident*. Paris: Léo Scheer.

Mauss, Marcel. 1925. "Essai sur le don." *L'Année sociologique*, n.s., 1.

Merleau-Ponty, Maurice. 1945. *Phénoménologie de la perception*. Paris: Gallimard.

Mill, John Stuart. 1859. *On Liberty*. London: John W. Parker and Son.

Nagel, Thomas. 1971. "Brain Bisection and the Unity of Consciousness." *Synthese* 22: 396–413.

Ngai, Sianne. 2012. *Our Aesthetic Categories: Zany, Cute, Interesting*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. 1874. *Vom Nutzen und Nachtheil der Historie für das Leben*. Leipzig: Fritzsch.

Nietzsche, Friedrich. 1887. *Zur Genealogie der Moral*. Leipzig: Naumann.

Noddings, Nel. 1984. *Caring: A Feminine Approach to Ethics and Moral Education*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Parfit, Derek. 1971. "Personal Identity." *Philosophical Review* 80 (1): 3–27.

Parfit, Derek. 1984. *Reasons and Persons*. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Plato. *Meno*; *Phaedo*; *Phaedrus*; *Republic*; *Theaetetus*.

Rank, Otto. 1914. "Der Doppelgänger." *Imago* 3.

Reid, Thomas. 1785. *Essays on the Intellectual Powers of Man*. Edinburgh: John Bell.

Ricoeur, Paul. 1990. *Soi-même comme un autre*. Paris: Seuil.

Ricoeur, Paul. 2000. *La Mémoire, l'histoire, l'oubli*. Paris: Seuil.

Rousseau, Jean-Jacques. 1762. *Du contrat social*. Amsterdam: Rey.

Schechtman, Marya. 1996. *The Constitution of Selves*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press.

Shoemaker, Sydney. 1970. "Persons and Their Pasts." *American Philosophical Quarterly* 7 (4): 269–85.

Sohn-Rethel, Alfred. 1970. *Geistige und körperliche Arbeit*. Frankfurt am Main: Suhrkamp.

Spinoza, Baruch. 1677. *Ethica ordine geometrico demonstrata*. In *Opera posthuma*. Amsterdam.

Spivak, Gayatri Chakravorty. 1988. "Can the Subaltern Speak?" In *Marxism and the Interpretation of Culture*, ed. Cary Nelson and Lawrence Grossberg. Urbana: University of Illinois Press.

Stiegler, Bernard. 1994–2001. *La Technique et le temps*. 3 vols. Paris: Galilée.

Stiegler, Bernard. 2010 [2009]. *For a New Critique of Political Economy*. Trans. Daniel Ross. Cambridge: Polity.

Strawson, Galen. 2004. "Against Narrativity." *Ratio* 17 (4): 428–52.

Suvin, Darko. 1979. *Metamorphoses of Science Fiction*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Tronto, Joan C. 1993. *Moral Boundaries: A Political Argument for an Ethic of Care*. New York: Routledge.

Turner, Victor. 1967. *The Forest of Symbols*. Ithaca: Cornell University Press.

Turner, Victor. 1969. *The Ritual Process*. Chicago: Aldine.

Turner, Victor, and Edith Turner. 1978. *Image and Pilgrimage in Christian Culture*. New York: Columbia University Press.

van Gennep, Arnold. 1909. *Les Rites de passage*. Paris: Nourry.

Weber, Max. 1922. *Wirtschaft und Gesellschaft*. Tübingen: Mohr.

Weber, Max. 1930 [1905]. *The Protestant Ethic and the Spirit of Capitalism*. Trans. Talcott Parsons. London: George Allen & Unwin.

Williams, Bernard. 1970. "The Self and the Future." *Philosophical Review* 79 (2): 161–80.

Political Economy, Sociology, and Management

Bellah, Robert N. 1967. "Civil Religion in America." *Daedalus* 96 (1): 1–21.

Bhattacharya, Tithi, ed. 2017. *Social Reproduction Theory*. London: Pluto Press.

Braverman, Harry. 1974. *Labor and Monopoly Capital*. New York: Monthly Review Press.

Cederström, Carl, and André Spicer. 2015. *The Wellness Syndrome*. Cambridge: Polity.

Collins, James C., and Jerry I. Porras. 1994. *Built to Last*. New York: HarperBusiness.

Crary, Jonathan. 2013. *24/7: Late Capitalism and the Ends of Sleep*. London: Verso.

Davis, Wade. 1985. *The Serpent and the Rainbow*. New York: Simon & Schuster.

Dayan, Joan. 1995. *Haiti, History, and the Gods*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Dickson, William J., and F. J. Roethlisberger. 1966. *Counseling in an Organization*. Boston: Harvard University, Graduate School of Business Administration.

Federici, Silvia. 1975. *Wages Against Housework*. Bristol: Power of Women Collective and Falling Wall Press.

Federici, Silvia. 2004. *Caliban and the Witch*. Brooklyn: Autonomedia.

Fraser, Nancy. 2022. *Cannibal Capitalism*. London: Verso.

Goody, Jack. 1986. *The Logic of Writing and the Organization of Society*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Graeber, David. 2018. *Bullshit Jobs: A Theory*. New York: Simon & Schuster.

Gray, Mary L., and Siddharth Suri. 2019. *Ghost Work*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin Harcourt.

Hochschild, Arlie Russell. 1983. *The Managed Heart*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Illouz, Eva. 2007. *Cold Intimacies*. Cambridge: Polity.

Illouz, Eva. 2008. *Saving the Modern Soul*. Berkeley: University of California Press.

Irani, Lilly. 2015. "The Cultural Work of Microwork." *New Media & Society* 17 (5): 720–39.

Keynes, John Maynard. 1936. *The General Theory of Employment, Interest and Money*. London: Macmillan.

Klein, Naomi. 2007. *The Shock Doctrine*. New York: Metropolitan Books.

Kunda, Gideon. 1992. *Engineering Culture*. Philadelphia: Temple University Press.

Lifton, Robert Jay. 1961. *Thought Reform and the Psychology of Totalism*. New York: Norton.

Martin, Reinhold. 2003. *The Organizational Complex*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Marx, Karl. 1844. *Ökonomisch-philosophische Manuskripte*. First published 1932.

Marx, Karl. 1847. *Misère de la philosophie*. Paris and Brussels.

Marx, Karl. 1885. *Das Kapital*. Vol. 2. Ed. Friedrich Engels. Hamburg: Meissner.

Marx, Karl. 1887 [1867]. *Capital: A Critical Analysis of Capitalist Production*. Vol. 1. Trans. Samuel Moore and Edward Aveling. London: Swan Sonnenschein.

Mill, John Stuart. 1848. *Principles of Political Economy*. London: John W. Parker.

Mills, C. Wright. 1951. *White Collar*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Mills, C. Wright. 1959. *The Sociological Imagination*. New York: Oxford University Press.

Patterson, Orlando. 1982. *Slavery and Social Death*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Perrigo, Billy. 2023. "OpenAI Used Kenyan Workers on Less Than $2 Per Hour to Make ChatGPT Less Toxic." *Time*, January 18.

Piketty, Thomas. 2013. *Le Capital au XXIe siècle*. Paris: Seuil.

Ricardo, David. 1817. *On the Principles of Political Economy and Taxation*. London: John Murray.

Roberts, Sarah T. 2019. *Behind the Screen*. New Haven: Yale University Press.

Roethlisberger, F. J., and William J. Dickson. 1939. *Management and the Worker*. Cambridge, MA: Harvard University Press.

Seabrook, William. 1929. *The Magic Island*. New York: Harcourt, Brace.

Stanger, Howard R. 2000. "From Factory to Family: The Creation of a Corporate Culture in the Larkin Company of Buffalo, New York." *Business History Review* 74 (3): 407–33.

Taylor, Frederick Winslow. 1911. *The Principles of Scientific Management*. New York: Harper & Brothers.

Thompson, E. P. 1967. "Time, Work-Discipline, and Industrial Capitalism." *Past & Present* 38: 56–97.

Whyte, William H. 1956. *The Organization Man*. New York: Simon & Schuster.

Willmott, Hugh. 1993. "Strength Is Ignorance; Slavery Is Freedom: Managing Culture in Modern Organizations." *Journal of Management Studies* 30 (4): 515–52.

Wright, Erik Olin. 1978. *Class, Crisis and the State*. London: New Left Books.

Wright, Erik Olin. 1985. *Classes*. London: Verso.

Psychology, Neuroscience, Bioethics, and Artificial Intelligence

Alder, Ken. 2007. *The Lie Detectors: The History of an American Obsession*. New York: Free Press.

Barrett, Lisa Feldman, Ralph Adolphs, Stacy Marsella, Aleix M. Martinez, and Seth D. Pollak. 2019. "Emotional Expressions Reconsidered: Challenges to Inferring Emotion from Human Facial Movements." *Psychological Science in the Public Interest* 20 (1): 1–68.

Birch, Jonathan. 2024. *The Edge of Sentience: Risk and Precaution in Humans, Other Animals, and AI*. Oxford: Oxford University Press.

Butlin, Patrick, Robert Long, et al. 2023. "Consciousness in Artificial Intelligence: Insights from the Science of Consciousness." arXiv:2308.08708.

Chalmers, David J. 2023. "Could a Large Language Model Be Conscious?" arXiv:2303.07103.

Damasio, Antonio. 1999. *The Feeling of What Happens*. New York: Harcourt Brace.

Dresser, Rebecca. 1982. "Ulysses and the Psychiatrist: A Legal and Policy Analysis of the Voluntary Commitment Contract." *Harvard Civil Rights–Civil Liberties Law Review* 16: 777–854.

Dresser, Rebecca. 1995. "Dworkin on Dementia: Elegant Theory, Questionable Policy." *Hastings Center Report* 25 (6): 32–38.

Dworkin, Ronald. 1993. *Life's Dominion*. New York: Knopf.

Elster, Jon. 1979. *Ulysses and the Sirens*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Elster, Jon. 2000. *Ulysses Unbound*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Firlik, Andrew D. 1991. "Margo's Logo." *JAMA* 265 (2): 201.

Freud, Sigmund. 1905. *Drei Abhandlungen zur Sexualtheorie*. Leipzig and Vienna: Deuticke.

Freud, Sigmund. 1917. "Trauer und Melancholie." *Internationale Zeitschrift für ärztliche Psychoanalyse* 4.

Freud, Sigmund. 1919. "Das Unheimliche." *Imago* 5.

Freud, Sigmund. 1925. "Notiz über den 'Wunderblock.'" *Internationale Zeitschrift für Psychoanalyse* 11.

Gazzaniga, Michael S. 1967. "The Split Brain in Man." *Scientific American* 217 (2): 24–29.

Gazzaniga, Michael S., and Joseph E. LeDoux. 1978. *The Integrated Mind*. New York: Plenum.

Goodwin, Donald W., et al. 1969. "Alcohol and Recall: State-Dependent Effects in Man." *Science* 163: 1358–60.

Hacking, Ian. 1995. *Rewriting the Soul: Multiple Personality and the Sciences of Memory*. Princeton: Princeton University Press.

Ienca, Marcello, and Roberto Andorno. 2017. "Towards New Human Rights in the Age of Neuroscience and Neurotechnology." *Life Sciences, Society and Policy* 13: 5.

James, William. 1890. *The Principles of Psychology*. New York: Henry Holt.

James, William. 1891. "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life." *International Journal of Ethics* 1 (3): 330–54.

Janet, Pierre. 1889. *L'Automatisme psychologique*. Paris: Alcan.

Jaynes, Julian. 1976. *The Origin of Consciousness in the Breakdown of the Bicameral Mind*. Boston: Houghton Mifflin.

Long, Robert, Jeff Sebo, et al. 2024. "Taking AI Welfare Seriously." arXiv:2411.00986.

Metzinger, Thomas. 2021. "Artificial Suffering: An Argument for a Global Moratorium on Synthetic Phenomenology." *Journal of Artificial Intelligence and Consciousness* 8 (1): 43–66.

Picard, Rosalind W. 1997. *Affective Computing*. Cambridge, MA: MIT Press.

Prince, Morton. 1906. *The Dissociation of a Personality*. New York: Longmans, Green.

Sacks, Oliver. 1985. *The Man Who Mistook His Wife for a Hat*. London: Duckworth.

Schwitzgebel, Eric. 2023. "The Full Rights Dilemma for AI Systems of Debatable Moral Personhood." *Robonomics: The Journal of the Automated Economy* 4.

Schwitzgebel, Eric, and Mara Garza. 2015. "A Defense of the Rights of Artificial Intelligences." *Midwest Studies in Philosophy* 39: 98–119.

Scoville, William Beecher, and Brenda Milner. 1957. "Loss of Recent Memory after Bilateral Hippocampal Lesions." *Journal of Neurology, Neurosurgery and Psychiatry* 20: 11–21.

Shiffrin, Seana Valentine. 1999. "Wrongful Life, Procreative Responsibility, and the Significance of Harm." *Legal Theory* 5 (2): 117–48.

Skloot, Rebecca. 2010. *The Immortal Life of Henrietta Lacks*. New York: Crown.

Sperry, Roger W. 1968. "Hemisphere Deconnection and Unity in Conscious Awareness." *American Psychologist* 23: 723–33.

Tulving, Endel. 1972. "Episodic and Semantic Memory." In *Organization of Memory*, ed. Endel Tulving and Wayne Donaldson. New York: Academic Press.

Tulving, Endel. 1985. "Memory and Consciousness." *Canadian Psychology* 26 (1): 1–12.

Wearing, Deborah. 2005. *Forever Today*. London: Doubleday.

Myth, Religion, and Classical Sources

Acts of Thomas. "Hymn of the Pearl," chaps. 108–113.

Augustine. *De civitate Dei*, book 12.

Bernabé, Alberto, and Ana Isabel Jiménez San Cristóbal. 2008. *Instructions for the Netherworld: The Orphic Gold Tablets*. Leiden: Brill.

Bible. Genesis 19, 22; Leviticus 16; Galatians 5.

Dante Alighieri. *Commedia*: *Inferno* 3, 26; *Purgatorio* 28, 33.

Edmonds, Radcliffe G., III. 2004. *Myths of the Underworld Journey*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press.

Euripides. *Alcestis*. 438 BCE.

Evans-Wentz, W. Y., ed. 1927. *The Tibetan Book of the Dead*. London: Oxford University Press.

Faulkner, Raymond O., trans. 1985. *The Ancient Egyptian Book of the Dead*. Ed. Carol Andrews. London: British Museum Publications.

Gospel of Nicodemus (*Descensus Christi ad Inferos*).

Hesiod. 1914. *Theogony*. In *Hesiod, the Homeric Hymns and Homerica*, trans. Hugh G. Evelyn-White. Loeb Classical Library. London: Heinemann.

Homer. 1919. *The Odyssey*. Trans. A. T. Murray. 2 vols. Loeb Classical Library. London: Heinemann.

Homeric Hymn to Demeter.

Hyginus. *Fabulae* 220.

Kojiki. 712.

Leary, Timothy, Ralph Metzner, and Richard Alpert. 1964. *The Psychedelic Experience*. New Hyde Park, NY: University Books.

Origen. *Contra Celsum* 6.24–38.

Ovid. *Metamorphoses* 10.1–85.

Pausanias. *Description of Greece* 9.39.

Pindar. *Nemean* 10.

Prudentius. *Psychomachia*.

Virgil. *Aeneid* 6; *Georgics* 4.

Wolkstein, Diane, and Samuel Noah Kramer. 1983. *Inanna, Queen of Heaven and Earth*. New York: Harper & Row.

History and Memoir

Douglass, Frederick. 1845. *Narrative of the Life of Frederick Douglass, an American Slave*. Boston: Anti-Slavery Office.

Grant, Ulysses S. 1885–86. *Personal Memoirs of U. S. Grant*. 2 vols. New York: Charles L. Webster.

Jones, James H. 1981. *Bad Blood: The Tuskegee Syphilis Experiment*. New York: Free Press.

Marks, John. 1979. *The Search for the "Manchurian Candidate": The CIA and Mind Control*. New York: Times Books.

Porter, Horace. 1897. *Campaigning with Grant*. New York: Century.

Renda, Mary A. 2001. *Taking Haiti: Military Occupation and the Culture of U.S. Imperialism, 1915–1940*. Chapel Hill: University of North Carolina Press.

Schmidt, Hans. 1971. *The United States Occupation of Haiti, 1915–1934*. New Brunswick, NJ: Rutgers University Press.

Literature

Atwood, Margaret. 1985. *The Handmaid's Tale*. Toronto: McClelland & Stewart.

Atwood, Margaret. 2015. *The Heart Goes Last*. Toronto: McClelland & Stewart.

Borges, Jorge Luis. 1960. "Borges y yo." In *El hacedor*. Buenos Aires: Emecé.

Calvino, Italo. 1952. *Il visconte dimezzato*. Turin: Einaudi.

Čapek, Karel. 1920. *R.U.R. (Rossumovi Univerzální Roboti)*. Prague: Aventinum.

Chiang, Ted. 2010. *The Lifecycle of Software Objects*. Burton, MI: Subterranean Press.

Chiang, Ted. 2013. "The Truth of Fact, the Truth of Feeling." *Subterranean Online*, Fall.

Chiang, Ted. 2019. "Anxiety Is the Dizziness of Freedom." In *Exhalation*. New York: Knopf.

Dick, Philip K. 1953. "Paycheck." *Imagination*, June.

Dick, Philip K. 1968. *Do Androids Dream of Electric Sheep?* Garden City, NY: Doubleday.

Dick, Philip K. 1969. *Ubik*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday.

Dick, Philip K. 1977. *A Scanner Darkly*. Garden City, NY: Doubleday.

Dickens, Charles. 1861. *Great Expectations*. London: Chapman and Hall.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. 1846. *Dvoinik* [The Double]. *Otechestvennye zapiski*.

Dostoevsky, Fyodor. 1918 [1864]. *Notes from Underground*. In *White Nights and Other Stories*, trans. Constance Garnett. London: Heinemann.

Egan, Greg. 1990. "Learning to Be Me." *Interzone* 37.

Egan, Greg. 1997. "Reasons to Be Cheerful." *Interzone* 118.

Ellis, Bret Easton. 1991. *American Psycho*. New York: Vintage.

Ferris, Joshua. 2007. *Then We Came to the End*. Boston: Little, Brown.

Forster, E. M. 1909. "The Machine Stops." *Oxford and Cambridge Review*, November.

Goethe, Johann Wolfgang von. 1808. *Faust: Eine Tragödie*. Tübingen: Cotta.

Gogol, Nikolai. 1842. "Shinel" [The Overcoat].

H.D. (Hilda Doolittle). 1917. "Eurydice." *The Egoist*, May.

Hoffmann, E. T. A. 1815–16. *Die Elixiere des Teufels*. Berlin: Duncker und Humblot.

Hoffmann, E. T. A. 1816. "Der Sandmann." In *Nachtstücke*. Berlin: Realschulbuchhandlung.

Huxley, Aldous. 1932. *Brave New World*. London: Chatto & Windus.

Ishiguro, Kazuo. 1989. *The Remains of the Day*. London: Faber and Faber.

Ishiguro, Kazuo. 2005. *Never Let Me Go*. London: Faber and Faber.

Kafka, Franz. 1915. *Die Verwandlung*. Leipzig: Kurt Wolff.

Kafka, Franz. 1915. "Vor dem Gesetz" [Before the Law].

Kafka, Franz. 1919. *In der Strafkolonie*. Leipzig: Kurt Wolff.

Kafka, Franz. 1925. *Der Process*. Berlin: Die Schmiede.

Kafka, Franz. 1926. *Das Schloss*. Munich: Kurt Wolff.

Lamb, Charles. 1825. "The Superannuated Man." *London Magazine*, May. Collected in *The Last Essays of Elia*, 1833.

Le Guin, Ursula K. 1973. "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas." In *New Dimensions 3*, ed. Robert Silverberg.

Lem, Stanisław. 1961. *Solaris*. Warsaw: Wydawnictwo Ministerstwa Obrony Narodowej.

Levin, Ira. 1972. *The Stepford Wives*. New York: Random House.

Ligotti, Thomas. 2002. *My Work Is Not Yet Done: Three Tales of Corporate Horror*. Burton, MI: Mythos Books.

Ma, Ling. 2018. *Severance*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux.

Melville, Herman. 1853. "Bartleby, the Scrivener: A Story of Wall-Street." *Putnam's Monthly Magazine*, November–December.

Moshfegh, Ottessa. 2018. *My Year of Rest and Relaxation*. New York: Penguin Press.

Orwell, George. 1949. *Nineteen Eighty-Four*. London: Secker & Warburg.

Palahniuk, Chuck. 1996. *Fight Club*. New York: W. W. Norton.

Pessoa, Fernando. 1982. *Livro do Desassossego*. Lisbon: Ática.

Poe, Edgar Allan. 1839. "William Wilson."

Pope, Alexander. 1717. "Eloisa to Abelard." In *The Works of Mr. Alexander Pope*. London.

Proust, Marcel. 1913. *Du côté de chez Swann*. Paris: Grasset.

Rilke, Rainer Maria. 1907. "Orpheus. Eurydike. Hermes." In *Neue Gedichte*. Leipzig: Insel. Written 1904.

Ruhl, Sarah. 2003. *Eurydice*. Play; first produced 2003.

Saramago, José. 1997. *Todos os Nomes*. Lisbon: Caminho.

Saramago, José. 2002. *O Homem Duplicado*. Lisbon: Caminho.

Shakespeare, William. c. 1611. *The Winter's Tale*. First printed in the First Folio, 1623.

Shelley, Mary. 1818. *Frankenstein; or, The Modern Prometheus*. London: Lackington, Hughes, Harding, Mavor & Jones.

Stevenson, Robert Louis. 1886. *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde*. London: Longmans, Green.

VanderMeer, Jeff. 2014. *Annihilation*. New York: Farrar, Straus and Giroux.

Vonnegut, Kurt. 1952. *Player Piano*. New York: Scribner.

Walser, Robert. 1909. *Jakob von Gunten*. Berlin: Bruno Cassirer.

Wilde, Oscar. 1890. "The Picture of Dorian Gray." *Lippincott's Monthly Magazine*, July.

Zamyatin, Yevgeny. 1924 [written 1920–21]. *We*. Trans. Gregory Zilboorg. New York: E. P. Dutton.

Film, Television, Theatre, Music, and Games

Film: Ayoade, Richard, dir. 2013. *The Double*. Bong Joon-ho, dir. 2025. *Mickey 17*. Chaplin, Charles, dir. 1936. *Modern Times*. Cocteau, Jean, dir. 1950. *Orphée*. Docter, Pete, dir. 2015. *Inside Out*. Fargeat, Coralie, dir. 2024. *The Substance*. Fincher, David, dir. 1999. *Fight Club*. Gilliam, Terry, dir. 1985. *Brazil*. Gondry, Michel, dir. 2004. *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* (screenplay by Charlie Kaufman). Halperin, Victor, dir. 1932. *White Zombie*. Jones, Duncan, dir. 2009. *Moon*. Jonze, Spike, dir. 1999. *Being John Malkovich* (screenplay by Charlie Kaufman). Judge, Mike, dir. 1999. *Office Space*. Kaufman, Charlie, dir. 2008. *Synecdoche, New York*. Kubrick, Stanley, dir. 1980. *The Shining*. Nolan, Christopher, dir. 2000. *Memento*. Peele, Jordan, dir. 2017. *Get Out*; 2019. *Us*. Proyas, Alex, dir. 1998. *Dark City*. Riley, Boots, dir. 2018. *Sorry to Bother You*. Smith, Christopher, dir. 2006. *Severance*. Stiller, Ben, dir. 1996. *The Cable Guy*; 2001. *Zoolander*; 2013. *The Secret Life of Walter Mitty*. Tati, Jacques, dir. 1967. *Playtime*. Vidor, King, dir. 1928. *The Crowd*. Villeneuve, Denis, dir. 2017. *Blade Runner 2049*. Wachowski, Lana, and Lilly Wachowski, dirs. 1999. *The Matrix*. Weir, Peter, dir. 1998. *The Truman Show*. Wilder, Billy, dir. 1960. *The Apartment*.

Television: *Black Mirror* (Charlie Brooker, 2011–). *Counterpart* (Justin Marks, 2017–2019). *Dollhouse* (Joss Whedon, 2009–2010). *Homecoming* (Micah Bloomberg and Eli Horowitz, 2018–2020). *Lost* (J. J. Abrams, Damon Lindelof, and Jeffrey Lieber, 2004–2010). *Mad Men* (Matthew Weiner, 2007–2015). *Mr. Robot* (Sam Esmail, 2015–2019). *The Good Place* (Michael Schur, 2016–2020). *The Prisoner* (Patrick McGoohan and George Markstein, 1967–1968). *Twin Peaks: The Return* (David Lynch and Mark Frost, 2017). *Westworld* (Jonathan Nolan and Lisa Joy, 2016–2022).

Theatre and music: Gluck, Christoph Willibald. 1762. *Orfeo ed Euridice*. Mitchell, Anaïs. 2010. *Hadestown* (concept album; Broadway production 2019). Monteverdi, Claudio. 1607. *L'Orfeo*. Offenbach, Jacques. 1858. *Orphée aux enfers*.

Games: *Control* (Remedy Entertainment, 2019). *Disco Elysium* (ZA/UM, 2019). *Papers, Please* (Lucas Pope, 2013). *Portal* (Valve, 2007). *Portal 2* (Valve, 2011). *The Stanley Parable* (Davey Wreden, 2011; expanded edition, Galactic Cafe, 2013).

Law, Policy, and Official Instruments

Cases: *Bailey v. Alabama*, 219 U.S. 219 (1911). *Citizens United v. Federal Election Commission*, 558 U.S. 310 (2010). *Curlender v. Bio-Science Laboratories*, 106 Cal. App. 3d 811 (1980). *Dartmouth College v. Woodward*, 17 U.S. (4 Wheat.) 518 (1819). *Dred Scott v. Sandford*, 60 U.S. (19 How.) 393 (1857). *Frye v. United States*, 293 F. 1013 (D.C. Cir. 1923). *Gleitman v. Cosgrove*, 49 N.J. 22 (1967). *Google Spain SL v. Agencia Española de Protección de Datos*, Case C-131/12 (CJEU, 2014). *Nonhuman Rights Project, Inc. v. Breheny*, 38 N.Y.3d 555 (2022). *Perruche*, Cour de cassation, Assemblée plénière, 17 November 2000, no. 99-13.701. *Pollock v. Williams*, 322 U.S. 4 (1944). *Santa Clara County v. Southern Pacific Railroad Co.*, 118 U.S. 394 (1886). *Somerset v. Stewart* (1772) 98 Eng. Rep. 499 (K.B.). *State v. Grimsley*, 3 Ohio App. 3d 265 (1982). *Turpin v. Sortini*, 31 Cal. 3d 220 (1982). *United States v. Denny-Shaffer*, 2 F.3d 999 (10th Cir. 1993).

Treatises: Blackstone, William. 1765–69. *Commentaries on the Laws of England*. 4 vols. Oxford: Clarendon Press.

Statutes and instruments: Virginia General Assembly, Act XII (December 1662), on the condition of children born to enslaved mothers. South Carolina, An Act for the Better Ordering and Governing of Negroes and Other Slaves in This Province (the Negro Act), 1740. United States Constitution, Amendments XIII (1865) and XIV (1868). Employee Polygraph Protection Act of 1988, 29 U.S.C. §§ 2001–2009. France, Loi n° 2002-303 du 4 mars 2002, art. 1. France, Loi n° 2016-1088 du 8 août 2016 (right to disconnect, in force 2017). Portugal, Lei n.º 83/2021. Australia, Fair Work Legislation Amendment (Closing Loopholes No. 2) Act 2024. United Kingdom, Sexual Offences Act 2003, s. 76. New Zealand, Te Awa Tupua (Whanganui River Claims Settlement) Act 2017. Chile, Ley 21.383 (2021), amending Article 19 of the Constitution. Colorado House Bill 24-1058 (2024). California Senate Bill 1223 (2024). Regulation (EU) 2016/679 (General Data Protection Regulation), art. 17. International Labour Organization, Forced Labour Convention, 1930 (No. 29). *The Nuremberg Code* (1947). World Medical Association, *Declaration of Helsinki* (1964). National Commission for the Protection of Human Subjects of Biomedical and Behavioral Research, *The Belmont Report* (1979). UNESCO, *Recommendation on the Ethics of Neurotechnology* (2025). Management of Individuals' Neural Data (MIND) Act, proposed in the United States Senate, 2025.

Online Sources Cited (accessed October 2026)

9to5Mac. 2026. "Severance Season 3 Is Coming: Here's Everything We Know Right Now." March 11. https://9to5mac.com/2026/03/11/severance-season-3-heres-everything-we-know-so-far/

A.V. Club. 2022. "*Severance* Ends Season 1 with a Pitch-Perfect Adrenaline Rush." https://www.avclub.com/severance-season-1-finale-recap

American Battlefield Trust. "10 Facts: Cold Harbor." https://battlefields.org/learn/articles/10-facts-cold-harbor

American Society of Cinematographers. 2025. Clubhouse Conversations interview with Jessica Lee Gagné on *Severance*, season 2. https://theasc.com/?p=2241

Apple Books. 2022. *Severance: The Lexington Letter*. Apple, Inc., March 18. https://books.apple.com/us/book/id1613220757

Apple Books. 2025. *The You You Are*. Apple, Inc., January 31. https://books.apple.com/us/book/id6738364141

ARY News. 2025. "Severance Season 3 Confirmed: Here's What We Know." March 21. https://arynews.tv/severance-season-3-announced-on-apple-tv/

Backstage. 2025. "For Tramell Tillman, the Devil's in the Details." https://www.backstage.com/magazine/article/tramell-tillman-severance-photoshoot-interview-78836/

BGR. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2, Episode 4 Recap: In Which We're Reminded That Helly Was Never Cruel." https://bgr.com/entertainment/severance-season-2-episode-4-recap-in-which-were-reminded-that-helly-was-never-cruel/

Blavity. "*Severance* Recap." https://blavity.com/entertainment/severance-recap

Business & Human Rights Resource Centre. 2023. "OpenAI and Sama Hired Underpaid Workers in Kenya to Filter Toxic Content for ChatGPT." January 23. https://www.business-humanrights.org/en/latest-news/openai-and-sama-hired-underpaid-workers-in-kenia-to-filter-toxic-content-for-chatgpt

Business Insider (via AOL). "A Comprehensive *Severance* Season 1 Recap, Because It's Been a While." https://www.aol.com/comprehensive-severance-season-1-recap-183033424.html

Bustle. 2022. "The Cliffhanger *Severance* Ending, Explained." https://www.bustle.com/entertainment/severance-season-1-fianle-ending-explained

CLIR (Ron Makleff). 2015. "All the Names." https://www.clir.org/2015/09/all-the-names/

ComicBook.com. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2 Ending Explained: What Happens After That Cliffhanger?" https://comicbook.com/tv-shows/news/severance-season-2-ending-explained-finale-recap-cliffhanger/

Consequence. 2025. Review of *Severance*, season 2, episode 10. https://consequence.net/2025/03/severance-season-2-episode-10-finale-review

Cult of Mac. 2025. "Thrilling *Severance* Season 2 Finale Keeps Some Key Secrets." https://www.cultofmac.com/reviews/severance-season-2-episode-10-recap

Culture Dump. "The Paintings in *Severance*." https://culturedump.substack.com/p/the-paintings-in-severance

D&AD. "Severance: The Cube." Awards archive. https://www.dandad.org/work/d-ad-awards-archive/severance-the-cube

Dexerto. 2025. "Who Directed *Severance* Season 2?" https://www.dexerto.com/tv-movies/severance-season-2-directors-3032831/

Elle (via AOL). 2025. "The Goats in *Severance* Season 2 Point to a Terrifying Theory About Lumon." https://www.aol.com/alright-really-goats-severance-season-170000491.html

Emmy Magazine. 2025. "*Severance*'s Work/Life Balance." https://emmys.com/news/features/emmy-magazine/articles/cover-2025-03

Empire. 2025. "Severance's Season 2 Finale Is the Show at Its Best, But We Still Have Questions." https://empireonline.com/tv/features/severance-season-2-finale-best-but-still-questions

Globetrender. 2025. "*Severance* Cast Bring Lumon Industries to Life in NYC." January 17. https://globetrender.com/2025/01/17/severance-cast-bring-lumon-industries-to-life/

Goodreads. "All the Names." https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/2528

IAPP. "Mental Privacy and Integrity." https://iapp.org/news/a/mental-privacy-and-integrity

Inverse. 2025. Interview with Tramell Tillman on the season 2 finale. https://www.inverse.com/tramell-tillman-interview-severance-season-2-finale

Levin, Kevin M. 2014. "Old Myths Die Hard at Cold Harbor." *Civil War Memory*, June 4. https://cwmemory.com/2014/06/04/old-myths-die-hard-at-cold-harbor/

National Park Service. *Richmond National Battlefield Park*. Historical Handbook No. 33. https://npshistory.com/handbooks/historical/33/hh33q.htm

Nerdist. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2, Episode 4 Recap: New Revelations and Questions from 'Woe's Hollow.'" https://nerdist.com/article/severance-season-2-episode-4-recap-new-woes-hollow-revelations-and-questions/

Nerdist. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2, Episode 8 Recap: New Revelations and Questions from 'Sweet Vitriol.'" https://nerdist.com/article/severance-season-2-episode-8-recap-revelations-questions-sweet-vitriol/

Scraps from the Loft. Transcript of *Severance*, season 2, episode 6, "Attila." https://scrapsfromtheloft.com/tv-series/severance-s02e06-attila-transcript/

Severance Wiki. "Core Principles." https://severance.wiki/core_principles

Severance Wiki. "Half Loop." https://severance.wiki/s1e2

Severance Wiki. "The You You Are." https://severance.wiki/s1e4

Slashfilm. 2022. "*Severance* Took Influence from *The Matrix* and Many Other Classic '90s Films [Comic-Con]." https://slashfilm.com/936666/severance-took-influence-from-the-matrix-and-many-other-classic-90s-films-comic-con

Slashfilm. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2 Ending Explained." https://slashfilm.com/1815734/severance-season-2-ending-explained

Sportskeeda. 2025. "Is Apple Really Selling Lumon Terminal Pro? Details Explored." https://sportskeeda.com/us/shows/is-apple-really-selling-lumon-terminal-pro-details-explored

Sportskeeda. "*Severance*: What Is the Lexington Letter? Everything You Need to Know About the E-Book." https://sportskeeda.com/us/shows/severance-what-lexington-letter-everything-need-know-e-book

Stanford Law School. 2026. "Who Owns Digital Thoughts? The Limits of Property Law and the 2025 UNESCO Recommendation on the Ethics of Neurotechnology." March 30. https://law.stanford.edu/2026/03/30/who-owns-digital-thoughts-the-limits-of-property-law-and-the-2025-unesco-recommendation-on-the-ethics-of-neurotechnology/

The Cinematography Podcast. 2025. Episode 308: Jessica Lee Gagné. https://www.camnoir.com/tag/mark/

The Daily Beast. 2025. "The *Severance* Premiere Was Jam-Packed with Juicy Secrets and Reveals." https://www.thedailybeast.com/obsessed/severance-season-2-premiere-recap-jam-packed-with-juicy-secrets/

The Filibuster Blog. "*Severance* Explained: The Significance of Milchick and Natalie's Kier Paintings Scene." https://thefilibusterblog.com/tw/severance-explained-the-significance-of-milchick-and-natalies-kier-paintings-scene/

The Hollywood Reporter. 2022. Roundtable with the creators and cast of *Severance*. https://www.hollywoodreporter.com/tv/tv-features/severance-cast-creators-fan-theories-1235156482/

The Independent (via AOL). "*Severance* Creator Shares Real-Life Inspiration Behind Hit Show." https://www.aol.com/severance-creator-shares-real-life-112544284.html

The Ringer. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2, Episode 5 Recap: 'Trojan's Horse.'" February 13. https://www.theringer.com/2025/02/13/severance/severance-season-2-episode-5-recap-trojans-horse

The Ringer. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2 Finale Recap: Cold Comfort." March 20. https://www.theringer.com/2025/03/20/severance/severance-season-2-finale-episode-10-recap-cold-harbor

Time. 2025. "The *Severance* Goat Room Has Finally Been Explained." https://partners.time.com/7269445/severance-goat-theory-answer-season-2-finale

Today. 2025. "*Severance* Season 2 Finale Explained." https://www.today.com/today/amp/rcna197465

Tom's Guide. 2025. "*Severance* Season 3 Officially Greenlit, But I May Not Watch After That Season 2 Finale." https://www.tomsguide.com/entertainment/streaming/severance-season-3-officially-greenlit-but-i-may-not-watch-after-that-season-2-finale

TV Fanatic. 2022. Recap of *Severance*, season 1, episode 2, "Half Loop." https://www.tvfanatic.com/severance-season-1-episode-2-recap-half-loop/

TV Fanatic. 2022. Recap of *Severance*, season 1, episode 4, "The You You Are." https://www.tvfanatic.com/severance-season-1-episode-4-recap-the-you-you-are/

TV Insider. 2025. "*Severance* Aftershow: Stars Break Down That Shocking Revelation and ORTBO Gone Wrong." https://tvinsider.com/1174457/severance-season-2-episode-4-recap-helly-helena-mark-irving-ortbo-retreat-woes-hollow

TV Insider. 2025. "*Severance* Star Patricia Arquette Breaks Down Harmony's Dreary Past and Motivation Moving Forward." https://www.tvinsider.com/1180215/severance-season-2-harmony-episode-patricia-arquette-cobell-history-dead-mom-inventor-newfoundland

TV Obsessive. 2022. "*Severance* S1E4: 'The You You Are' Is Not a Nice Person." March 4. https://tvobsessive.com/2022/03/04/severance-s1e4-the-you-you-are-is-not-a-nice-person/

TVLine. 2022. "*Severance* Finale Recap: Out of Office." https://tvline.com/news/severance-recap-season-1-finale-ending-explained-apple-1234817550/

TVLine. 2025. "*Severance*: 5 Burning Questions We Have After the Season 2 Premiere." https://www.tvline.com/lists/severance-season-2-premiere-ending-explained-burning-questions/

TVLine. 2025. Recap of *Severance*, season 2, episode 10. https://tvline.com/recaps/severance-recap-season-2-finale-episode-10-mark-helly-gemma-1235420293

Variety. 2022. "*Severance* Waffle Party Explained." https://variety.com/2022/tv/news/severance-waffle-party-sex-scene-explained-dylan-kier-eagan-1235212918

Variety. 2025. "*Severance* Finale: How Season 2 Ends, and 13 Burning Questions for Season 3." https://variety.com/2025/tv/news/severance-finale-recap-season-2-1236344212

Variety Australia. 2025. "'Maybe I'm Biased': *Severance* Star Breaks Down Season Two Finale." https://au.variety.com/2025/tv/features/severance-dichen-lachman-breaks-down-season-two-finale-21138

Wikipedia. "All the Names." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/All_the_Names

Wikipedia. "Cold Harbor (Severance)." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Cold_Harbor_(Severance)

Wikipedia. "Defiant Jazz." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Defiant_Jazz

Wikipedia. "Gemma Scout." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Gemma_Scout

Wikipedia. "Goodbye, Mrs. Selvig." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Goodbye,_Mrs._Selvig

Wikipedia. "In Perpetuity." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/In_Perpetuity

Wikipedia. "Sweet Vitriol." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Sweet_Vitriol

Wikipedia. "The After Hours (Severance)." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_After_Hours_(Severance)

Wikipedia. "The We We Are." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_We_We_Are

Wikipedia. "The You You Are." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/The_You_You_Are

Wikipedia. "Trojan's Horse." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Trojan%27s_Horse

Wikipedia. "What's for Dinner? (Severance)." https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/What%27s_for_Dinner%3F_(Severance)

Keywords

SEVERANCE (TELEVISION SERIES) · DAN ERICKSON · BEN STILLER · TELEVISION STUDIES · SCIENCE FICTION STUDIES · SPECULATIVE FICTION · COGNITIVE ESTRANGEMENT · PERSONAL IDENTITY · JOHN LOCKE · DEREK PARFIT · BERNARD WILLIAMS · SPLIT-BRAIN · EPISODIC MEMORY · AMNESIA · DISSOCIATION · CEROPLASTIC SUBJECT · TOPOLOGICAL PERSONHOOD · MEMORY AND FORGETTING · LETHE · MNEMOSYNE · ANAMNESIS · LETHEAN MODE OF PRODUCTION · LOCKEAN ARBITRAGE · MNEMONIC ENCLOSURE · NECRERGY · KARL MARX · ESTRANGED LABOUR · REAL ABSTRACTION · TAYLORISM · SOCIAL REPRODUCTION · AFFECTIVE LABOUR · DATA WORK · CORPORATE RELIGION · LITURGICAL SUPPLEMENT · MAX WEBER · ÉMILE DURKHEIM · WALTER BENJAMIN · CAPITALISM AS RELIGION · POLITICAL THEOLOGY · GIORGIO AGAMBEN · MICHEL FOUCAULT · GILLES DELEUZE · SOCIETIES OF CONTROL · PASTORAL POWER · HETEROTOPIA · THOUGHT REFORM · FOUR TEMPERS · HUMORAL THEORY · DIALECTIC OF ENLIGHTENMENT · KATABASIS · ORPHIC GOLD TABLETS · MYTH OF ER · NEKYIA · DIOSCURIC STRUCTURE · SHABTI · INANNA · IZANAGI AND IZANAMI · BARDO THÖDOL · DANTE · GNOSTICISM · HYMN OF THE PEARL · SCAPEGOAT · ONOMASTICS · OUTIS · DOPPELGÄNGER · CLERK LITERATURE · BARTLEBY · ZAMYATIN · PHILIP K. DICK · COMPARATIVE LITERATURE · CONSENT · PRECEDENT AUTONOMY · ULYSSES CONTRACT · WRONGFUL LIFE · NON-IDENTITY PROBLEM · RECOGNITION · HEGEL · AXEL HONNETH · THIRTEENTH AMENDMENT · FORCED LABOUR · NEURORIGHTS · PSYCHOLOGICAL CONTINUITY · EPISTEMIC INJUSTICE · DIFFÉREND · MOURNING · CRYPT · KIERKEGAARDIAN REPETITION · NIETZSCHE · ACTIVE FORGETTING · NATALITY · HANNAH ARENDT · EMMANUEL LEVINAS · PAUL RICOEUR · IPSE AND IDEM · ORPHEUS AND EURYDICE · ORPHIC INVERSION · POST-MNEMONIC PERSON · ETHICS OF CARE · CURA PRINCIPLE · HYGINUS · HEIDEGGER · RIGHT TO DISCONNECT · RIGHT TO BE FORGOTTEN · AI MORAL STATUS · BATTLE OF COLD HARBOR.

Set in EB Garamond, with Cormorant Garamond for display, Jost for labels, and IBM Plex Mono for numerals. Figures drawn for this edition.